



MSME DAY

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Business as Usual
By EP UNNY



Ayodhya Donations
Kolkata Warehouse Collapse
Delhi Fire
Lucknow Fire
When you look up to pray, you find one more reason to pray.

AYODHYA PROBE WIDENS, POLICE FORM SEPARATE TEAM

Theft at Ram temple: Police arrest eight, recover part of stolen money

Rs 79.8 lakh seized from 7 accused, role of bank staff under scanner

Bhupendra Pandey & Deeptiman Tiwary
Lucknow, New Delhi, June 26

A DAY after police in Ayodhya registered an FIR on a complaint alleging theft, misappropriation of cash, embezzlement of funds and valuables donated to the Ram temple, all eight persons named in the FIR were arrested and sent to judicial custody for three days.

Police have so far recovered Rs 79.80 lakh from seven of the eight arrested men. Prosecu-



Tinnu Yadav (centre), one of the eight men arrested, being produced in an Ayodhya court, Friday. He used to work as a driver for Ram temple trust general secretary Champat Rai. **ANI** **RELATED REPORTS, PAGE 8**

tion Officer A K Verma said the recovered money was part of the donated funds allegedly

stolen from the temple.

The eight men — Avinash Shukla, Lavkush Mishra, Anu-

kalp Mishra, Manish Kumar Yadav, Karunesh Pandey, Ramashankar Mishra, Ram Shan-

kar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav and Subhash Srivastav — were produced by police before a remand magistrate.

Verma said they were sent to judicial custody for three days and will be produced again Monday before the Prevention of Corruption Act court for further proceedings.

According to Verma, no cash or valuables were recovered from Srivastav while Rs 79.80 lakh was recovered from the other accused.

Tinnu Yadav used to work as a driver for Champat Rai, general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmbhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust. According to an official, ever since the consecration of the idol in 2022, Tinnu had been involved in the functioning of affairs inside the temple.

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VIR CHAKRA FOR RIFLEMAN SUNIL KUMAR

Agniveer among six Army, IAF personnel killed in Op Sindoor, names made public

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 26

INDIA HAS officially released the names of six Armed Forces personnel who were killed in action during Operation Sindoor in May 2025. This is the first time that the names have been made public.

Of the six, five were Army soldiers and one an Indian Air Force personnel: Subedar Major Pawan Kumar from Headquarters 10 Infantry Brigade; Rifleman Sunil Kumar from the 4th battalion of the Jammu and Kashmir Light Infantry Regiment; Lance Naik Dinesh Kumar from the 5 Field Regiment; Agniveer Mood Murali-naik from the 851 Light Regiment; Havildar Sunil Kumar Singh from the 237 Field Workshop; and Sergeant Surendra Kumar from the 39 Wing of the IAF. The majority of the Army casualties were in J&K during Operation Sindoor.

Rifleman Sunil Kumar is a Vir Chakra awardee, and Sergeant Surinder Kumar has been awarded the Vayu Medal. On June 8, President Droupadi Murmu presented the Vir



The names of the six personnel on a wall at the National War Memorial, Friday. **PTI**

Chakra (posthumous) to Sunil Kumar's family at the Defence Investiture Ceremony.

The names were released alongside the list of all soldiers who made the supreme sacrifice during various military operations in 2025. The names of these soldiers will remain permanently inscribed at the National War Memorial in the Capital. Their names have also been published in the Roll of Honour on the website of the National War Memorial.

EXPRESS investigation

Union Minister gets Rs 99-lakh subsidy for his cucumber farm — from scheme under own ministry

As MoS Agriculture, Bhagirath Choudhary is ex officio Vice-President of the board that approved his Rajasthan project for horticulture scheme; his is one of only 467 approvals last year; his aide says details will be disclosed to Govt



Union Minister of State Bhagirath Choudhary

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, Peeh (Rajasthan), June 26



The signboard at Union MoS Bhagirath Choudhary's farm in Peeh, Deedwana-Kuchaman district, Rajasthan. **HARIKISHAN SHARMA**

Among beneficiaries: wife, son, mother of IAS officer

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, June 26

IT'S NOT just the Union Minister.

The mother, wife and son of a senior IAS officer are also among the beneficiaries in Rajasthan of the scheme under the Union Ministry of Agriculture and Farmers' Welfare to promote commercial farming, records investigated by *The Indian Express* show.

Records show the three family members of Naresh Pal Gangwar, a 1994-batch Rajasthan-cadre IAS officer, who is a Secretary in the Ministry of Fisheries, Animal Husbandry and Dairying, received a total of over Rs 1.16 crore in subsidies

across five years under the scheme.

Titled "Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture crops", the scheme is run by National Horticulture Board (NHB) under the Union Agriculture Ministry.

According to records, Gangwar has disclosed details of only one project approved under the scheme in the mandatory annual declaration of immovable property with the Department of Personnel and Training (DoPT) for 2021-22. Gangwar told *The Indian Express* that service rules mandate that he declare only the

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4 steps, Rs 1 crore cap: How the subsidy is cleared

Harikishan Sharma
New Delhi, June 26

What is the scheme?

"Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops" is a sub-scheme under National Horticulture Board's Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture (MIDH).

PURPOSE: Promote commercial farming (for profit) of horticultural crops on a large scale. The crops under the scheme are three types of vegetables: capsicum, cucumber and tomato; and eight varieties of flowers: anthurium, orchid, rose, lily, chrysanthemum, carnation, gypsophila and gerbera.

SUBSIDY: Upto 50 per cent of the project cost, capped at Rs 1 crore per family, is available as subsidy under the scheme.

BENEFICIARIES: Individuals, self-help groups, associations or groups of growers, trusts, co-operative societies, companies, farmer producer organisations, cooperative marketing federations, agricultural produce marketing committees,

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Medical supplies and other relief material being sent to Venezuela under Operation Amistad, on Friday. **ANI** **RELATED REPORT, PAGE 16**

Venezuela reels after deadly quakes, India sends transcontinental flights with medical aid

Amrita Nayak Dutta
New Delhi, June 26

THE INDIAN Armed Forces Friday dispatched two C-17 Globemaster III aircraft carrying a specialised medical contingent, relief supplies and medicines to assist Venezuela where back-to-back earthquakes have killed over 900 people and left thousands injured and missing.

Mounting Operation Amis-

tad (Spanish for friendship), the Indian Air Force is undertaking one of its largest humanitarian aid flights — Venezuela is around 15,000 km from India. The C-17 Globemaster III aircraft has spearheaded multiple global humanitarian and disaster relief (HADR) missions, delivering medical supplies, field hospitals and emergency aid to regions worldwide.

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THE BIG PICTURE

HOW IMMIGRANTS ARE SHAPING THE FOOTBALL WORLD CUP
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Rajasthan C-sec deaths: Centre seeks report after WHO asks for info

Anonna Dutt & Parul Kulshrestha
New Delhi, Jaipur, June 26

THE UNION Health Ministry has asked the Rajasthan government for a detailed report on women developing complications following caesarean operations across several government hospitals in the state, with some resulting in casualties.

Sources said the ministry sent a note after the World Health Organization (WHO) sought information from the Indian government on the possible link of spurious oxytocin to the cases. The WHO sought information to ascertain whether the issue was localised, or more widespread, with potential risk at other locations, the source said.

The Centre action followed

E. EXPLAINED

Drug under spotlight

Oxytocin is used to induce labour before a delivery and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after it. Many of the women who died or developed complications in Rajasthan saw excessive blood loss.

after the Rajasthan government and the top drug regulator in the country cancelled licences of a Kota-based wholesale drug distributor of oxytocin and two factories manufacturing the drug in Punjab and

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Telegram key platform for drug ads, Myanmar route a concern: NCB

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, June 26

ENCRYPTED MESSAGING platforms such as Telegram, WhatsApp and Signal have become major channels for drug trafficking worldwide, including in India. Of these three, Telegram has emerged as a key platform for drug-related advertising, according to the Narcotics Control Bureau's Annual Report 2025 released Friday.

According to the report, released by Union Home Minister Amit Shah, Telegram has become a prominent drug advertising platform, with public channels offering product list-



Union Home Minister Amit Shah at the Apex-Level Meeting of the Narco-Coordination Centre in New Delhi on Friday. ANI

ings, pricing and delivery details to large subscriber bases.

"Unlike darknet markets,

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Happening today

• **PRIME MINISTER NARENDRA** Modi will begin a state visit to Seychelles. During the visit, until June 29, the PM will hold talks with President Patrick Herminie and also attend the golden jubilee celebrations of the National Day of Seychelles.

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THE WORLD

ISRAEL, LEBANON SIGN FRAMEWORK DEAL AFTER TALKS MEDIATED BY U.S.
PAGE 16

• BUILT UNDER STATE GOVT'S ATAL E-LIBRARIES SCHEME, THESE FACILITIES STOCK BOOKS FOR COMPETITIVE EXAMS

Why Haryana's villages are turning libraries into gateways to govt jobs

Sukhbir Siwach
Gorakhpur (Fatehabad), June 26

AT 5 AM, before the rest of his family wakes up, Sahil Kumar makes his way to the village library in Pabra. There, he spends the next few hours poring over books to prepare for government recruitment exams for Group C and D jobs, along with dozens of other aspirants.

"It is centrally located, air-conditioned and open round the clock. We had to go all the way to Hisar before. Now we can study here, cutting commute time," Sahil Kumar, a BA

graduate and kabaddi player, tells *The Indian Express*.

Since 2020, a quiet transformation has been unfolding across Haryana's villages. Libraries and reading rooms, such as the one in Pabra, have mushroomed with one aim: helping students like Sahil

crack competitive examinations. Built under the Haryana government's Atal e-Libraries scheme, these facilities stock books for competitive exams and attract hundreds of government job aspirants, many targeting Group C and D posts.

According to officials, the Haryana government has set up



At a library in Gorakhpur village of Haryana's Fatehabad. **EXPRESS**

985 libraries, spending Rs 150 crore. For many rural youths, the libraries are a symbol of Haryana's growing aspiration.

"These libraries have been set up in chaupals and community centres," an official from the Development and Pan-

chayats Department says. "We've provided books, furniture and air conditioners to help students study."

The libraries have drawn thousands of students across the state. One such village is Gorakhpur in Fatehabad district, where two regulars cleared the Haryana Staff Selection Commission (HSSC) examination for Group D posts Friday.

The latest selections take the number of the library's regulars who have secured government jobs since it was set up in October 2020 to 40.

"We set up the library because youngsters, particularly girls, from our village preparing for competitive examinations

had to travel either 15 km to Bhuna town or 40 km to Hisar city to study," says Satywan Numberdar, who played a key role in establishing the facility. "Today, around 70 students regularly study at the library."

Group C posts include positions such as junior engineers, clerks, excise and taxation inspectors, auditors, assistant managers, patwaris, and male and female police constables. Group D posts comprise entry-level positions in government departments, including peons, animal attendants, helpers, gardeners, cooks and water carriers.

According to locals, the demand for village libraries gathered momentum after nearly

18,000 candidates were recruited for Group D posts in Haryana in 2018.

A typical library has 40 to 100 seats. Some are government-run, while others are privately managed. Most are simply furnished with study tables and chairs, and many have air conditioners to beat the summer heat. The panchayat-supported library in Pabra charges Rs 300 a month to cover maintenance costs, while three privately run libraries in Pabra charge around Rs 800.

Government libraries are funded under the Atal e-Libraries scheme, while private ones are financed by private

»CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

Three women arrested from Kaushambi home for ‘cooking beef’

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, June 26

THREE WOMEN were arrested after police raided a house in Uttar Pradesh’s Kaushambi on the allegation that they were cooking beef.

According to police, they received information on Wednesday that a family had allegedly brought beef and that the women were cooking it. After verifying the tip-off, a police team headed to the house identified by an informer.

Police said on seeing the raiding team, four men allegedly fled through the village’s narrow lanes. Police claimed the women, too, attempted to flee when officers entered the premises but were detained by women police personnel.

They said they recovered a container of cooked meat and a transparent plastic bag containing raw meat.

“We have arrested the three women. During questioning, they told us the meat was beef

that had been brought by their family members from outside,” said Deputy Superintendent of Police Abhishek Singh.

Police said they are looking for the women’s husbands and another man from the neighbourhood. The men work in Mumbai and recently came to Kaushambi.

Police said the women, all in their 30s, have been booked under different sections of the Uttar Pradesh Prevention of Cow Slaughter Act at Sarai Akil police station. They were produced before the court which sent them to judicial custody, Singh said.

Police said they recovered about 1 kg of raw meat and 1 kg of cooked meat.

“The meat samples have been sent to a forensic laboratory for examination, and we are awaiting the test results,” said Deputy SP Singh. A police officer said the investigation would also seek to establish where the meat was sourced from and whether it had been purchased previously too.

2023 train shooting: Western Rly told to pay Rs 8L to victim’s wife

Sadaf Modak
Mumbai, June 26

AROUND THREE years after a constable of the Railway Protection Force (RPF) allegedly killed his senior colleague and three passengers on an express train in Mumbai, the Railway Claims Tribunal (RCT) directed the Western Railway (WR) to pay Rs 8 lakh as compensation to one of the passenger’s wife.

Farida Bhanpurwala, the wife of 62-year-old Abdul Kadar Bhanpurwala, had approached the tribunal in 2024.

The railway administration told the tribunal it will not be contesting the matter on the issue of whether the incident took place and whether Abdul Kadar was a bonafide passenger, following which the compensation was awarded in April, with the final hearing held in May.

On July 31, 2023, now dismissed RPF constable Chetansingh Chaudhary, had allegedly shot his senior assistant sub-inspector Tikaram Meena and three passengers, Bhanpurwala, Asghar Ali Abbas and Syed Saifuddin, while he was on duty on the Jaipur-Mumbai passenger train. The trial in the case against Chaudhary is currently pending.

The case was put up before

the Lok Adalat in April and the tribunal gave its judgment, with the order made available in May.

It will be heard on July 17 for reporting compliance of its directions. The tribunal had directed that the victim’s wife be paid Rs 8 lakh along with interest as compensation.

Under the Railways Act, compensation can be sought arising out of an alleged untoward incident by an injured victim or in case of death, their family members, if an untoward incident occurred, whether or not there has been any wrongful act, neglect or default on the part of the railway administration. Before the tribunal, the Railways can contest if a person was a bonafide passenger based on facts including whether he was a ticket-holder, and can also contest the incident itself.

Following a 2020 notification by the Railways, to protect claimants from the compensation money being frittered away, the amount is invested in a savings account and disbursed monthly.

In the trial against Chaudhary, the sessions court in March directed the Thane jail authorities to admit him to a mental health institute for care and treatment.

Woman alleges sexual harassment at firm in Pune, CM Fadnavis announces inquiry

Chandan Haygunde
Pune, June 26

A WOMAN has filed a police complaint alleging that she was subjected to “quid pro quo” sexual harassment by senior officials at a Spanish multinational company in Pune district, claiming she was promised salary hikes and promotions if she became “closer” to them, and was later terminated after raising objections.

In a complaint lodged at the area police station on May 5, the woman alleged that the company’s HR head and CEO subjected her to unwelcome advances after she joined the firm in March 2024. She claimed she was promoted to the HR/admin executive position in September that year.

According to the complaint, the alleged harassment began in December 2024, when the two officials started making objectionable remarks, attempted to get physically close to her, and looked at her with inappropriately. She described it as a case of “quid pro quo” sexual harassment.

The woman claimed she submitted written complaints to the company’s management in June, September and November 2025, but no formal inquiry was initiated. She alleged, her services were terminated on April 16 this year on the grounds of “role redundancy”.

She further claimed she was pressured to sign the termination letter and threatened with damage to her career when she refused. The woman submitted copies of email exchanges, WhatsApp messages, voice recordings, and other documents along with her police complaint.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, the complainant said, “As I refused to sign the termination letter and decided to go for legal options against the harassment done to me, the company set up an internal committee (IC) for an inquiry. But I came to know that my cross-examination would be conducted by the respondent (the person who harassed me). I have raised objections to it.... I also submitted a complaint to the Maharashtra State Commission for Women.”

Manisha Kayande of the Shiv Sena raised the issue in the Maharashtra Legislative Council Thursday, demanding strict action against the Spanish multinational company and the individuals involved.

Replying to Kayande, CM Devendra Fadnavis announced that a senior officer will conduct an inquiry within 15 days and assured action would be taken against the company or individuals found guilty.

The Indian Express reached out to the company for its response however no reply was received

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Theft at Ram temple

Srivastav, a retired bank employee, was in-charge of the donation counting shifts at the counting room in the Pilgrim Facility Centre (PFC). The other six were involved in the counting work.

Verma said five-six serving bank employees were under the scanner for alleged embezzlement of funds and for conspiring with the arrested men. Their exact role and involvement were under investigation, he said.

There were allegations that some among the counting staff

had been slipping extra notes into currency bundles of 100 each and these were later shared.

An officer said the police probe team, led by Ayodhya Circle Officer Ashutosh Tiwari, will investigate the larger spectrum of the alleged theft and embezzlement.

The police team is likely to seek help from the Special Investigation Team (SIT) which was formed to probe the allegations. Police could ask the SIT for documents, including digital records, to assess the extent

NCB

which require specialised access, these platforms are widely accessible via smartphones, lowering entry barriers and enabling broader reach... Enforcement on these platforms is challenging because of jurisdictional issues in securing platform cooperation, the ephemeral nature of content, including auto-deletion of messages, and the use of multiple accounts, layered communication methods, and cryptocurrency payments by vendors to maintain anonymity,” the report said.

Earlier this month, the

Centre temporarily restricted Telegram in India ahead of the June 21 NEET-UG retest on the grounds that it was being used by “cheating rackets”. While access to the app was restricted until June 22, its message-editing feature was disabled until June 30.

The report by the apex drug law enforcement agency also flagged a trafficking corridor from Myanmar into India’s Northeast as a major security concern, warning that the drug trade in the region is linked to arms smuggling and financing of terror groups.

“Myanmar has now overtaken Afghanistan as the leading source of illicit opium,” the report said, “with the change

of the alleged theft and embezzlement, the officer said.

Another officer said the bank staff involved in carrying cash and valuables to the bank branch ever since 2022 will also be questioned by police – they had earlier been questioned by the SIT.

The FIR was lodged Thursday at Kotwali Ramjanmahoomi police station on a complaint by Krishna Mohan, a member of the Trust, two days after the SIT submitted its preliminary findings to the UP government.

The allegations, the arrests, especially of Tinnu Yadav who used to work as a driver for Champat Rai, has both alarmed

and upset RSS functionaries.

“It is a matter of concern for us. The Ram temple and its management are associated with the Sangh in public perception. It is casting a shadow. As an organisation, the Sangh always pushes for the highest standards of probity in public life,” a senior Sangh functionary told *The Indian Express*.

Another Sangh functionary described the episode as a systemic lapse rather than an act of individual wrongdoing. “This shows that the entire donation collection process was not fool-proof and was prone to leakages. Better systems should have been put in place,” the functionary said.

driven by the after-effects of the Taliban’s ban on poppy cultivation and the continued expansion of cultivation in Myanmar amid conflict and economic breakdown.”

“The porous border (between India and Myanmar) and Free Movement Regime facilitate trafficking, exacerbate local addiction, and fund insurgent groups,” the report said.

The report also pointed out that India is facing mounting pressure from a rapidly changing global narcotics landscape, marked by the rise of ultra-potent synthetic opioids and a record cocaine output.

The report flagged two emerging threats that require urgent attention: the spread of

nitazenes, a class of synthetic opioids said to be 500 times more potent than heroin, and the increasing link between drug trafficking and organised violence across transit economies.

“Drug law enforcement agencies across the country registered an all-time high of over 1.48 lakh cases and effected seizures of more than 1,200 tonnes of narcotic drugs and psychotropic substances. The scale and diversity of seizures, ranging from plant-based drugs to synthetic substances, pharmaceutical diversions and precursor chemicals, underscore the evolving and complex nature of the threat,” NCB Director Anurag Garg said in the report.

C-section deaths

Himachal, respectively. Sources said inspections had discovered widespread irregularities, including the absence of evidence of key tests regarding drug purity and proof of data fudging.

Oxytocin is used to induce labour before a delivery and to contract the uterus for preventing blood loss after it. Many of the women who died or developed complications in Rajasthan saw excessive blood loss.

In the latest case, eight women who underwent C-sections at the District Government Hospital in Paota, Jodhpur, on June 20 fell ill after surgery. Two of them who developed complications were moved to AIIMS, Jodhpur, and all are stable now.

Before that, complications were reported after caesarean deliveries at PBM Hospital in Bikaner. Of the six women who developed kidney failure after surgery, two died. The Bikaner cases followed a more severe episode in Kota, where five women died in May after undergoing caesarean deliveries at the New Medical Government Hospital. More than 40 days later, five other women remain admitted and continue to require dialysis after suffering kidney failure.

The Rajasthan authorities have denied a link between the deaths.

On the WHO approaching the Central government, an official said: “It is a routine part of the global pharmacovigilance and regulatory surveillance mechanism. The organisation regularly seeks information... to determine whether such incidents are confined to a particular location or whether there could be any implications for other countries... It should not be construed as a finding against the product or the manufacturer.”

The findings

CENTRE: In the first week of June, the Central Drugs Standard Control Organisation (CDSCO) held a joint inspection of the manufacturing units in Punjab and Himachal of Jackson Laboratories, the manufacturer of the oxytocin that is under a cloud in Rajasthan, along with the regulators of the two states.

Following the inspection, the licences of the units were cancelled.

Sources said that the inspection found that Jackson Laboratories, which has earlier too faced action over its products, was found to have not complied with a 2023 order by state regulators directing it to stop the production of several tablets, capsules, and injectables, on grounds of its unhygienic conditions.

What caused Rajasthan maternal deaths? Not just spurious oxytocin, say Govt doctors

“Acute kidney failure is usually caused by either haemorrhage before or after the delivery, preeclampsia or hypertension during pregnancy, and sepsis. These can be managed if the patient reaches a hospital on time. But in most cases they arrive very late...”

DR ANJALI DABRAL, RETIRED GYNAECOLOGIST FROM DELHI’S SAFDARIJUNG HOSPITAL

starvation, and heavy blood loss.

Dr Sinha says while she did not know the history of each patient, the deaths likely happened because of excessive bleeding, which can happen if C-section is not performed properly.

“With the rise in the number of C-section deliveries, there has been a corresponding increase in placenta accreta — a condition where the placenta attaches too deeply to the uterine wall and does not come out easily after delivery. A skilled surgeon is needed to take the placenta out properly. Otherwise, it can lead to massive bleeding. Sometimes doctors have to perform hysterectomy (removal of uterus) even in women who have only had one child to save them from bleeding out,” she says.

Bleeding before the pregnant woman reaches a hospital can also be a big risk factor. “If

they have already lost a lot of blood and there is another 500 ml to 800 ml loss during the C-section, new mothers can go into a shock.” The sudden blood loss and circulatory shock can, in turn, result in organs such as kidney shutting down.

Aside from surgical complications, the most common reasons why women might end up losing excessive blood, and end up in circulatory shock, are haemorrhage and hypertension. Women can end up with kidney damage and multi-organ failure because of sepsis (blood infection), as was seen in the cases of maternal deaths in Rajasthan as well. “Acute kidney failure is usually caused by either haemorrhage before or after the delivery, preeclampsia or hypertension during pregnancy, and sepsis. These can be managed if the patient reaches a hospital with adequate infrastructure on time. But in most

Aid sent to Venezuela

The Army’s medical team from 60 Para Field Hospital departed Friday afternoon from the Hindon Air Force Station and is en route Venezuela, the Army said in a statement, adding that the contingent comprises 41 personnel, including nine medical officers. It is equipped to provide emergency medical care, trauma management, life-saving surgical support and other essential healthcare services to those affected by the earthquakes.

According to the Army, the team is carrying approximately six tonnes of medical stores and humanitarian relief supplies provided by the Ministry of External Affairs. The BHISHM Cube (Bharat Health Initiative for Sahyog, Hita & Maitri) is being transported as part of India’s Aarogya Maitri Project.

The BHISHM Cube, it said, is a state-of-the-art, indigenous, rapidly deployable modular medical facility designed specifically for disaster and humanitarian response.

“Comprising compact, self-contained medical modules, it can be quickly assembled into a fully functional field hospital

capable of delivering advanced trauma care, emergency surgeries, intensive care support and essential medical treatment for up to 200 patients,” the Army said.

It is equipped with portable ventilators, patient monitors, diagnostic equipment, surgical instruments, power-generation and oxygen-support systems, enabling swift and effective medical assistance during humanitarian crises anywhere in the world.

“The dispatch of the medical contingent under Operation Amistad reflects India’s enduring commitment to humanitarian assistance and disaster relief and its readiness to extend timely support to friendly nations in times of crisis,” the statement noted.

Earlier, External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar, in a post on X, said the assistance contains an Army Field Hospital Unit and over 35 tonnes of relief supplies, medicines and medical equipment including two BHISHM Cubes. He said India is committed to supporting the government and people of Venezuela in this difficult time.

Libraries

individuals. Most stock books and study material for examinations conducted by the Haryana Staff Selection Commission.

The growing number of libraries reflects changing aspirations among rural youth, says Kuldeep Kundu, who runs one such private facility in Pabra.

“During the Bhopinder Singh Hooda-led Congress government, there was a surge in sports because government jobs were offered to sports persons who excelled at the national and international levels. During the BJP government, there has been a surge in libraries as people increasingly believe that government jobs are now being awarded on merit,” he says.

The movement is now spreading to neighbouring villages.

“Inspired by the success of the library at Pabra, we helped establish a library in the neighbouring Kinala. It was initially meant for both boys and girls, but girls occupied all the available seats almost immediately after it opened. We are now setting up another library exclusively for boys. We are also planning to establish a library in neighbouring Kandul village,” he says.

Fatehabad Deputy Commissioner Vivek Bharti welcomed the initiative.

“Young people have realised that government jobs can be secured through dedication and hard work. The increasing number of libraries reflects the belief that recruitment is based

on merit, making serious study essential,” he says.

The government now plans to establish Atale-Libraries in all 6,225 gram panchayats across the state.

“These libraries will be equipped with computers, air-conditioned study rooms, furniture and books for competitive examinations so that students in rural areas can access better educational facilities,” Haryana Development and Panchayats Minister Krishan Lal Panwar says, while an official adds: “We plan to establish another 1,000 libraries during the current financial year.”

The number of private libraries, too, is growing. For instance, encouraged by the success of the first library, Gorakhpur village has already opened a second one, with a third in the works.

Aashu hopes her own village of Faridpur is one of those villages. Also, a government job aspirant, Aashu commutes 7 km away to the Pabra library every day to study.

“I’m fortunate that my parents have given me a scooter to travel to the library. Other girls from my village come by bus and then have to walk nearly one kilometre from the bus stand to the library,” she says.

The impact is evident in the growing number of students preparing for competitive examinations. Aman Kumar, a BA final-year student, is one of them.

“I reach the library at 5 am every day and stay here till 10 pm whenever I don’t have to attend college. I dream of a government job in Haryana,” he says.

cases they arrive very late, often after bleeding for a long duration, so by the time they reach the hospital, their organs start shutting down,” says Dr Anjali Dabral, retired gynaecologist from Safdarjung hospital, Delhi’s other high volume maternity centre.

She adds that kidney failure can also happen if the woman has pre-existing chronic kidney disease. Dr Sheeba Marwah, associate professor at Safdarjung Hospital, says, “Sepsis may occur because good hygiene practices were not followed during the C-section, but they are more likely because of prolonged leaking of the amniotic fluid, multiple checks during a long labour and ungloved checks. The risk also goes up when a woman is anaemic — and 80% of pregnant women who come to us are. Anaemia limits the body’s ability to carry oxygen properly — and in its absence the body cannot fight off infections well.”

Dr Agarwal adds that there is a need to ensure that women receive regular ante-natal checkups, get their C-section done by qualified doctors and the hospital have a proper transfer facility in case a woman needs to be moved to a higher centre because of an emergency. “While the trend is changing, many still come to the hospital only at the time of

delivery. So we do not know whether they have any pre-existing conditions or whether they are likely to get any complications,” she says.

Dr Marwah adds that government centres like hers receive the most complicated cases and at the last moment, meaning the number of deaths are likely to be high at such centres. “While the number of maternal deaths has reduced significantly over the years, they continue to be a regular problem,” she says.

Rajasthan is one of the states with less than the average national Maternal Mortality Rate. The national average has come down to 88 per lakh live births, inching closer to the sustainable development goal of 70. Rajasthan has an MMR of 87. While states such as Maharashtra (36), Tamil Nadu (38), and Andhra Pradesh (47) have a much lower MMR, there are several states with a much higher mortality number such as Madhya Pradesh (159), Chhattisgarh (141), and Uttar Pradesh (141), according to the latest available Sample Registration Survey data.

Delivery by caesarean section has been on the rise in the country — increasing to 27.2% from 21.5% as per the recently released NFHS-6 data — going up to as high as 40.5% in urban areas.

‘Forced out in hours’: Gurgaon’s sealing drive leaves tenants scrambling for housing

Abhimanyu Hazarika
Gurgaon, June 26

ON JUNE 19, Sanghamitra Pati, a 25-year-old marketing manager, was visiting her parents in Odisha when enforcement teams arrived at the building where she lived in Gurgaon’s DLF Phase 3 to seal it.

“My friends had to literally break the lock on my fully furnished apartment to rescue my clothes and critical documents before the premises were sealed,” she said, recounting the sheer panic.

Pati is among several young professionals and families hit hard by a sealing drive across residential areas in DLF Phases I to V that is targeting unauthorised commercial accommodations.

On Thursday, a team of officials from the Gurgaon District Town Planner (Enforcement) went about pasting notices outside alleged illegal paying guest (PG) accommodations and guesthouses, and also slipped copies into rooms of tenants.

The ‘Public Interest Advisory’ asks tenants to make alternative living arrangements. According to the public notice, the



official deadline to secure new housing and avoid the inconvenience of the sealing action is June 30.

When the sealing drive began last Thursday, many tenants said they received sudden phone calls telling them to pack their belongings and vacate their homes within hours.

Four men working at a technology company, who did not wish to be named, said that their company does not have work from home.

“We have to find a place soon now, they should have told us sooner. We pay over Rs 20,000 each, at least, including

food, for a single room in our PG,” they said, bringing down their luggage from an accommodation on Siris Road.

The men also said that they are now trying to find a flat along the Rapid Metro line, but have not got any lead yet.

“Even now, our landlord has not spoken to us about our deposit, nor offered any help,” they said.

The demographic of the tenants displaced extends well beyond young IT employees. “Families with toddlers and elderly parents had to leave their accommodation and shift to hotels. Most of the affected



District Town Planning officials pasting notices in DLF Phase 2 and (above) at a PG near Nathupur Road in DLF Phase 3 in Gurgaon. EXPRESS

tenants are at work during the day,” said a guard outside a sealed property in DLF Phase 3.

Why the crackdown

The ongoing crackdown, led by District Town Planner (Enforcement) Amit Madholia, is based on directives from the Punjab and Haryana High Court, aimed at curbing zoning violations and unauthorised commercial activities in residential areas.

In recent enforcement action at S Block on Nathupur Road, officials accompanied by heavy police deployment sealed 11 establishments.

Madholia said the notices were issued beginning Wednesday as landlords had not conveyed the information to their tenants prior to the drive.

The drive targeted prominent properties like Hotel Moonlight and The Medicity hospital, alongside massive illegal PG facilities — including one spanning four floors with 72 rooms, and another operating 48 rooms out of a single apartment complex. Earth-movers were also deployed to raze illegal structures built in stilt parking spaces.

The DTCP’s advisory explicitly states that the department shall not be responsible for any loss or disruption caused to occupants. Madholia said the police will handle cases of deposits going unreturned and any landlord disputes.

Meanwhile, on Instagram, good samaritans are offering help. Gurgaon-based realtor Deepti Verma said she has received over 250 calls since the drive started. She said she would offer help to those aged under 25 — who have either started their internship or their first job — in finding accommodations, without a brokerage.

JUSTICE SWARNA KANTA MOVED TO CIVIL PETITIONS

Roster rejig: HC assigns MP/MLA cases to Justice Jain

Apurva Vishwanath
New Delhi, June 26

IN A reshuffle of its roster of cases, the Delhi High Court on Friday assigned criminal cases relating to sitting and former lawmakers to Justice Manoj Jain. This set of politically sensitive cases was being heard by Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma for nearly three years.

The roster change is a routine administrative move undertaken every year before the court reopens, after the summer break, to streamline the listing of cases. The change will take effect from July 1.

Justice Sharma will now hear civil writ petitions on subjects such as mines, sexual harassment at workplace, Right to Information and those involving statutory authorities such as the Delhi Transport Corporation, Urban Arts Commission, Airport Authority of India, etc.

A designated MP/MLA roster deals with criminal cases against former and current lawmakers. Since a majority of cases, especially in the national capital, involve opposition leaders like former chief minister Arvind Kejriwal, Justice Sharma’s courtroom was at the centre of heated political tussles.

In April, citing an apprehension of bias, Kejriwal and other accused had filed affidavits seeking Justice Sharma’s recusal from hearing the Central Bureau of Investigation’s challenge to the trial court’s order



Justice Swarna Kanta Sharma had been hearing criminal cases relating to lawmakers since three years. FILE

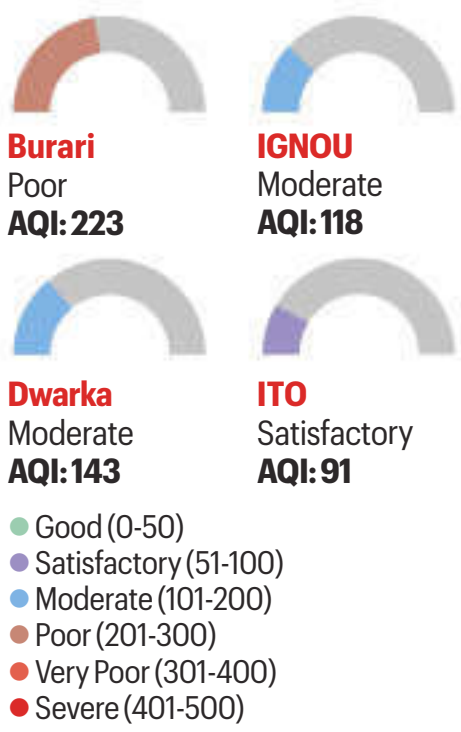
discharging them in the Delhi liquor policy case. Initially, Justice Sharma rejected the recusal application and instead initiated contempt proceedings against Kejriwal and others. Subsequently, the case was transferred to Justice Jain.

In April 2021, a Supreme Court bench of three judges, headed by then Chief Justice of India N V Ramana, had directed setting up of special courts and designated rosters to deal with criminal cases against lawmakers. The direction was part of the court’s effort to streamline such cases and clear the backlog. The bench had also directed that no prosecution against an MP or an MLA can be withdrawn without the permission of the high courts which are monitoring the progress of cases pending against such elected lawmakers.

• Skywatch


Forecast: June 27, 2026
Partly cloudy sky. Light rain, thunderstorm, lightning.
MAX: 39-41
3.8°C above normal
MIN: 26-28
0.1°C above normal

• AQI Tracker



• BRIEFLY

Woman shot dead by husband during argument

A 30-YEAR-OLD woman was allegedly shot dead by her husband in Tigris in south Delhi’s Sangam Vihar, police said. The incident happened around 4 pm on Thursday. The accused, identified as Shubham Rajput, allegedly fired four rounds at Kavita following an argument, killing her on the spot. Preliminary investigation suggests the couple had frequent disputes and the accused, who is currently absconding, had allegedly been threatening her. A case of murder has been registered and a probe is on, police said. PTI

EXPRESS exclusive

450 commercial buildings in Capital red-flagged over fire safety failures

Alok Singh
New Delhi, June 26

HOTELS, RESTAURANTS, banquet halls, guest houses, hospitals and nursing homes: 450 commercial buildings in Delhi have been red-flagged for not having the mandatory fire No-Objection Certificates (NOCs) or for violating building by-laws by the Delhi Fire Department.

The action comes weeks after the devastating fire at a Bed & Breakfast establishment in Malviya Nagar claimed 23

lives, including 13 foreign nationals.

According to sources, these buildings were identified during a survey conducted by district-level committees constituted by the Delhi government following the June 3 blaze. The committees were tasked with carrying out a city-wide inspection of all buildings with six storeys (ground plus five floors) or more, including hospitals and nursing homes, to assess compliance with fire safety norms and building bye-laws..

A total of 13 district-level

committees and 39 subdivision-level committees were formed for the exercise, and the survey is still underway.

Will action be taken?

Sources said notices have been served to all 450 establishments by the departments concerned. The Fire Department has also sought structural layout plans from the owners or operators of these buildings.

“If the Fire Department finds that the current layout does not match the plans previously submitted for obtaining

the fire NOC, the certificate may be cancelled. A fresh NOC will be issued only after the department concerned certifies that the building complies with all prescribed norms,” a senior Fire Department source said.

“Any approval for revised structures will depend on clearance from the department concerned and compliance with safety regulations,” the source said.

The district-level committees comprises the District Magistrates as chairperson, MCD Deputy Commissioner,

Deputy Commissioner of Police, and Divisional Officer, Fire.

These supervise the subdivision-level committee comprising the Sub-Divisional Magistrate (Revenue District) as the chairperson, MCD Assistant Commissioner, and Assistant Commissioner of Police.

The sub-division-level committee has to submit a daily report to the District Magistrate, who submit weekly reports to the Divisional Commissioner (Revenue) and Principal Secretary (Home), said officials.

Govt slashes DJB’s infra rates by up to 84% for commercial establishments

Press Trust of India
New Delhi, June 26

IN A move aimed at improving ease of doing business, the Delhi government has significantly reduced the Delhi Jal Board’s infrastructure charges for commercial establishments, including banquet halls, hotels and industries.

The DJB’s infrastructure charges (I&FC) are levied on properties for new constructions and additions on plots between 150 sqm and 200 sqm. The charges are to be paid before the start of construction work on water and sewerage infrastructure management by the DJB.

According to an official order issued on Thursday, the revised rates applicable to different categories of four-storey buildings on 1,000-sqm plots with a 150 floor area ratio (FAR) provide relief ranging from 14.5 per cent to 84.6 per cent, depending on the category and type of establishment.

“For commercial assembly and banquet halls, I&FC in A and B categories has been slashed from Rs 57.68 lakh to Rs 19.80 lakh, around 65.7 per cent reduction. Charges in C category have been reduced from Rs 41.20 lakh to Rs 19.80 lakh, while category D has witnessed a 199 per cent reduction, with charges coming down from Rs 24.72 lakh to Rs 19.80 lakh,” an order said. Similarly, projects in categories E and F will now pay Rs 990 lakh instead of Rs 16.48 lakh, translating into a 399 per cent reduction. In G and H categories, the charges have been reduced from Rs 16.48 lakh to Rs 5.94 lakh, marking a cut of 63.9 per cent.

Hotels have also received substantial relief under the revised structure. “Infrastructure charges for categories A and B have been brought down from Rs 57.68 lakh to Rs 24.06 lakh, a 58.3 per cent reduction. In category C, charges have been reduced by 41.6 per cent, from Rs 41.20 lakh to Rs 24.06 lakh,” the order added.



SIR-2026

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भारत निर्वाचन आयोग
Election Commission of India

CHIEF ELECTORAL OFFICER, HARYANA

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2

The BLO will assist you in filling the Enumeration Form (EF), if required.

3

The BLO will hand over a signed copy of the Enumeration Form (EF) to you as an acknowledgement.

4

The BLO will collect the second signed copy of the Enumeration Form (EF) from you.

5

Voters are requested to:

- Keep one recent coloured passport-size photograph ready.
- Fill, sign, and hand over the Enumeration Form (EF) to the BLO.
- Keep the second copy of the Enumeration Form (EF) safely till the completion of the Special Intensive Revision (SIR).
- Check your name in the draft electoral roll on **21 July 2026**.



6

If a voter is away on vacation, any family member may sign the Enumeration Form (EF) on their behalf and mention their relationship with the voter.

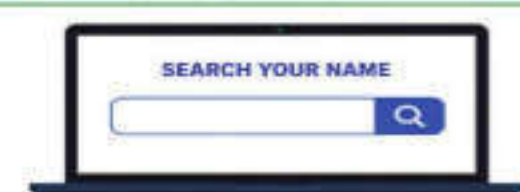
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Relation with Voter : _____
Signature : _____



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Check your name in the current voters list or in the last SIR electoral roll at

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Government of India

Ministry of Ayush (Ayurveda Section)

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Applications are invited (in duplicate) from eligible candidates for filling up the post of Director General (DG), Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), New Delhi, an autonomous body under the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India. Details in this regard are available on the website of the Ministry (www.ayush.gov.in) and Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), New Delhi (<https://ccras.nic.in>).

2.Application complete in all respect in the prescribed proforma may be submitted through proper channel to the undersigned in the Ministry of Ayush, Government of India, Ayush Bhawan, B-Block, GPO Complex, INA, New Delhi -110023 within 30 days from the date of publication of the advertisement for the post in the Employment News/Rozgar Samachar.

Sd/-

Under Secretary to the Government of India

CBC-17216/11/0006/2627

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1. Applications are invited for the following post at Viral Research and Diagnostic Laboratory (VRDL), Army Hospital R&R, Delhi Cantt - 110010 **purely on contractual basis for a period of 11 Months:**

S. No	Name of Post	Eligibility Criteria	Emoluments in Rs.	Remarks
(a)	Scientist B (Med/Non-med) (One vacancy)	Essential Qualification: (For Sci B - Med) MD/MS/DNB/MDS/M.V.Sc & AH recognized by MCI/DCI/ICI respectively. Or MBBS/ BDS/ B.V.Sc degree with ONE YEAR experience in research. Essential Qualification: (For Sci B - Non-med) First class Master's degree in Life Sciences from a recognized University with 2 years' experience in related field. OR 2nd class Master's Degree with Ph.D in relevant subject from a recognized University. Desirable Qualifications: (i) MD in the related subject from a recognized university for candidates with first class. (ii) Research/training experience in Viral Diagnosis/Infectious disease outbreak diagnosis/ Sangers Sequencing/NGS/field experience of sample collection and transport in viral disease outbreak. (iii) Knowledge of Computer Applications/Data Management/molecular bioinformatics tools, Primer/Probe designing, phylogenetic analysis. (iv) At least two original research publications (published or accepted) in PubMed indexed journal. Note: (i) MD/MVSc/PhD degree in relevant subject shall be treated equivalent to three years' experience. (ii) Candidates with MD/MS/MVSc/ PhD degree and age less than 40 years will be preferred.	56000 + HRA	Increment admissible as per DST norms

2. Desirous candidates are requested to apply with Bio-data/CV to email: vrldhrdelhi@gmail.com

3. Selection is based purely on merit. Shortlisted candidates will be intimated telephonically or by email for examination and interview.

4. The last date of receipt of application is **05 July 2026**.



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MSME DAY

MSMEs: Strengthening small businesses, building global economies

Continued from previous page

Digital shift reshaping MSMEs
Sustaining this massive socio-economic impact in a rapidly evolving world requires a fundamental shift in how small businesses operate. Presently, the horizon of the MSME sector is being rewritten with the help of technology. The democratisation of digital tools, ranging from cloud-based accounting software and regional e-commerce marketplaces to localised AI tools for marketing, has provided small businesses with the ability to create a wider reach.

However, this digital leap has its own pros and cons. Though technology provides unprecedented opportunities, the rapid pace of adoption is highlighting the challenges that tend

International MSME Day, observed on June 27, celebrates key role of MSMEs in fostering economic resilience & advancing sustainable development worldwide

to act as a hurdle for businesses. The hurdle is the chronic global credit crunch. According to data from early 2026, loans for SMBs grew quite slowly in comparison to early times. Instead of rapid double-digit jump, credit growth cooled down as global uncertainty made leaders more careful.

The road ahead
International MSME Day is simply more than a celebration; it is a recognition of the entrepreneurial journey that powers economies, creates opportunities and strengthens communities worldwide. It has increasingly demon-

strated its ability to adapt, innovate, and contribute to economic development even in the face of significant challenges. MSMEs' role in generating employment, fostering innovation, supporting sustainable development, and promoting inclusive growth makes them an indispensable component for the global economy.

Hence, on this International MSME Day, the global community celebrates not only the achievements of MSMEs but also their enduring potential to shape an innovative, inclusive, and sustainable future.

Bank of India

Fuelling MSME growth in the digital era

AS THE BEDROCK of the national economy, India's MSME sector continues to drive industrial output, employment and exports. In alignment with the Government of India's updated vision for structural formalisation and green transitions, Bank of India (BoI) remains at the forefront of empowering small enterprises through targeted financial innovations.

Recognising the evolving needs of the modern business ecosystem, the Bank has restructured its MSME lending framework to prioritise speed, digitisation and sustainability.

To cater to diverse business lifecycles, the Bank offers a robust suite of tailored lending schemes. Key products include the BoI ECLGSS.O, BoI Star Asset Backed Loan and BoI Star Welcome Offer for scaling infrastructure, BoI Star Doctor Plus under its dedicated healthcare portfolio and the BoI Star Vehicle

Mukesh Kumar Jha
Field General Manager
Bank of India, New Delhi

Yuva Udyami' and 'Star Udyami Vanita' continue to provide crucial capital concessions to youth and women entrepreneurs. To guarantee seamless, hassle-free credit delivery, the Bank has digitised its credit ecosystem through integrations with the Jan-Samarth Portal and straight-through processing e-platforms also using PSB loans in 59 minutes, the bank has drastically cut processing timelines.

Under the guidance of its leadership at FGMO New Delhi, the Bank has recently organised customer outreach programme at its New Delhi Zone in the esteemed presence of Bank's ED Subrat Kumar and FGM Mukesh Kumar Jha. The Bank continues to conduct extensive customer outreach across key economic zones, reinforcing its commitment to grassroots development and accelerating India's journey toward a robust digital economy.

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MSME DAY

Unleashing India's MSME export potential

Our small businesses have survived crises and are ready for global markets. A National Export Development Mission can help them get there.

Sushma Morthania, Director General, India SME Forum

INDIA'S MICRO, SMALL AND medium enterprises (MSMEs) have repeatedly demonstrated an extraordinary ability to withstand adversity. Over the past few years, they have weathered consecutive global crises, from pandemic induced supply chain shocks to inflationary pressures and geopolitical disruptions like the Red Sea crisis and the Iran-Israel conflict. Through it all, India's small businesses have continued to produce, innovate, and export.

This resilience is not accidental; it is anchored in a fundamental shift in India's economic philosophy. During the pandemic, targeted initiatives like the Emergency Credit Line Guarantee Scheme (ECLGS) prevented widespread business failures and preserved millions of livelihoods. Even amid recent maritime disruptions, proactive coordination across ministries has minimised the impact on exporters. Today, India is approaching global trade not from a position of defensive protectionism, but from one of confident global engagement.

The commerce ministry, under Union Minister Piyush Goyal, has fundamentally transformed how India negotiates free trade agreements (FTAs). Unlike earlier pacts that often exposed domestic industries without creating sufficient reciprocal opportunities, the new generation of FTAs, with the UAE, Australia, EFTA, and the UK, focuses on securing meaningful market access while protecting strategic interests. For millions of small enterprises, these agreements are not simply diplomatic milestones. They represent access to consumers and global value chains that were previously out of reach.

Yet, market access alone does not create exporters. India currently has over eight crore registered MSMEs, but only a relatively small proportion participate directly in exports. This represents one of our country's greatest untapped economic opportunities. If India is to achieve its ambition of becoming a developed economy and significantly expanding its merchandise exports over the coming decade, we need a National Export Development Mission with a singular, bold objective, that of creating one crore new export-ready enterprises.

India SME Forum Leadership Congratulating Minister Piyush Goyal and Minister of State Jiten Prasad on the spate of FTAs

Across the country, MSMEs are already producing world-class engineering products, processed foods, textiles, electronics and precision manufacturing goods. The barrier is not entrepreneurial ability, it is infrastructure, compliance, and market connectivity. Export readiness requires a completely different support ecosystem than domestic trade. MSMEs need easy access to internationally accredited testing laboratories, product standardisation, export warehousing, digital trade platforms, and export financing.

Equally important is the urgent need to reduce regulatory friction. While significant progress has been made through digitisation and ease-of-doing-business reforms, first-time exporters still encounter duplicative documentation, cer-

tification delays and procedural bottlenecks that drive up transaction costs. Every hour saved in compliance is an hour invested in competitiveness.

At the India SME Forum, our interactions with thousands of entrepreneurs across the country reveal a remarkable shift in ambition. A decade ago, many micro-enterprises saw exports as the domain of large corporations. Today, they are asking far more strategic questions: How can we meet European standards? Can we leverage global e-commerce platforms? How do we integrate into global supply chains? This change in mindset reflects the growing confidence and global aspirations of India's MSME sector.

When India's MSMEs succeed on the global stage, India succeeds with them. The next chapter of the country's growth story will not be shaped solely by its largest industrial corridors or biggest corporations. It will be driven by the workshops, factories, farms and innovation hubs of millions of small enterprises across Bharat. These businesses are ready to compete with the world—provided they are equipped with the right tools, robust infrastructure, and greater access to markets.

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OWNER OF FACTORY IN MUNDKA AREA AMONG THREE ARRESTED

Three workers die in septic tank after inhaling toxic gas at Outer Delhi factory



Outside the factory where the incident happened. TASHI TOBGYAL

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 26

MARWAH PRINTERS in Outer Delhi's Mundka Industrial Area wore a deserted look on Friday evening. The black iron gate outside the two-floor factory with white paint scraping off its walls was locked. On the lane outside, was lying the sewage and blue gloves of three men who died after allegedly inhaling toxic gas in a septic tank at the factory earlier in the day. A case has been registered under sections of Manual Scavenging act and the SC/ST ACT and three persons have been arrested. "Three people have been arrested — Suraj Marwah, the owner of Marwah Printers; aged 50; Jayant (61) and Neeraj (35), contractor for labourers. Further investigation is ongoing," said DCP (Outer) Vikram Singh. The deceased have been identified as Arun (38); Sandeep (32); and Chand (42), all residents of Sultanpuri in Outer Delhi, said a Delhi Fire Services (DFS) official. According to police, a PCR call was received at Mundka police station regarding the incident and a team immediately

rushed to the spot. During the preliminary inquiry, police said it was found that a printing unit had hired a contractor named Neeraj, a resident of Nangloi, to clean a septic tank located inside the factory premises in Gali No. 1 of Mundka Industrial Area. "Neeraj, along with three other workers, was engaged in cleaning the tank when the incident took place. He allegedly told one of the workers that they have to get inside and clean out the garbage stuck in the machine" said a senior police officer. Rescue efforts were initiated soon after and the workers were pulled out. However, they could not be saved, according to officers. Police said the bodies have been shifted to Sanjay Gandhi Memorial Hospital in Mangolpuri for post-mortem examination. Officers said the autopsy will help determine the exact cause of death. Officials are also examining whether all mandatory safety protocols were followed before the cleaning operation began. Police also said appropriate legal action is being taken under relevant provisions of law.

GROUND report

‘Forced to clean sewage; no safety gear’: Kin cope with loss

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 26

FOR RS 600, Arun left home on Friday morning. The daily wage came only when work came. For the family, it meant groceries for a few days, school expenses for the children, and a little more time before financial worry returned. By 10 am, Arun was still at home in Sultanpuri in Outer Delhi, where he lived with his wife, Aarti, and their three young sons in a two-room ground-floor house inside a cramped lane filled with hovering flies and a putrid stench. A septic tank and sewage cleaner, Arun had not yet been called by his contractor, Naresh. And then came the call. "He came to me and said, 'Neeraj bhai ne bulaya hai'. 'Tanki saaf krni hai, (Neeraj sir has called me. A tank has to be cleaned)' " says Aarti. Arun left. A few hours later, another call came. This one was to tell Aarti that her husband had fainted inside the septic tank. "When I reached there, they said he is no more. I had seen him two hours ago. Why did he go inside? It was not his job," says Aarti, recalling that Arun was usually outside the tanks, operating what she calls the "tractor" — an informal term used among tank cleaners to denote the machine that extracts sewage out of a tank using a pipe while other



Relatives of the deceased outside the mortuary of the Sanjay Gandhi Hospital in Mangolpuri on Friday. TASHI TOBGYAL

workers are inside the tank, pushing the waste towards the pipe. As Aarti holds on to the couple's three boys — all between the ages of 6 and 8 — Arun's elder brother, Narender, says that he had been working with Neeraj for more than five years. "They didn't give him any safety gear. He went there with his neighbours, Sandeep and Chand. They were asked on the phone to just remove the water from the tank. No one was supposed to go in," says Narender. Arun was not the first one to go inside. When the tractors couldn't clear the tank mechanically,

the contractor forced one of them to go in and clean it manually. "Something got stuck inside. So, to clean it, the contractor forced Chand to go inside and clean it. He had been working with the contractor for a long time. He couldn't say no," says Shivani, nephew of Chand. "We have still not told his wife and his two kids about the incident. They think he is admitted," adds Shivani, standing outside the mortuary of Sanjay Gandhi Hospital. When Chand didn't come out after 10-odd minutes, Arun followed him inside. Sandeep was waiting outside anxiously. Having recently

● RECENT INCIDENTS IN THE CAPITAL

- **April 2026:** A young sanitation worker dies in East Delhi's Dilshad Garden after falling into a deep drain while cleaning it
- **September 2025:** A man (40) dies, 3 others hospitalised in critical condition after falling into a sewer in Northwest Delhi's Ashok Vihar
- **February 2025:** Two sanitation workers die, another injured while cleaning a sewage tank in Outer Delhi's Narela
- In 2023, Supreme Court told authorities to raise the compensation in sewer deaths from Rs 10 lakh to Rs 30 lakh

lost his job, Sandeep also couldn't afford to say no and had to jump in to save his neighbours, who had got him the contract through their reference. About two lanes behind Arun's house, Sandeep's wife, Nisha, stands in front of the family's rented lodgings. "I was leaving home for some work and Sandeep was still at home. I told him I would be back soon after dropping our daughter to school. By the time I came back, he wasn't there. My mother-in-law said that he had got some work," she says. The next thing Nisha recalls is that her uncle called her to say that Sandeep was no more. "I have a 10-year-old daughter. My in-laws. What work am I supposed to find?" she says.

Poor families targeted to sell their children, racket busted

Drishhti Jain
Ghaziabad, June 26

EVEN BEFORE she was born, her parents were already allegedly considering selling her — the buyers were based out of Andhra Pradesh. On seeing the newborn in May, however, the hearts of the parents — who work as labourers in Ghaziabad — melted. They said no to the people pursuing them, police told *The Indian Express*. Eleven days later, a woman named Pooja, who was among the people pursuing the parents, allegedly kidnapped the infant from her house on May 26 and handed the baby over to another accused, identified as Manoj. Earlier this month, the Tronica City Police rescued the infant, and arrested Pooja and Manoj, apart from 11 others, as they busted a human trafficking racket with the help of tip-off, local intelligence and CCTV footage, said officers. The accused abducted the baby girl from Pooja Colony and were about to hand her

over to three others. The gang planned to take the child to Andhra Pradesh and sell her to a couple, identified as Raju and Deepthi. On Friday, the police arrested three more accused from the Tronica City of Ghaziabad, identified as Tarannum (29), Anil Lakda (33), and Karun (49). The alleged syndicate, said officers, operated across Delhi-NCR and through their network, identified parents from weak financial backgrounds who were expecting a child. While the accused allegedly sold the newborns across the country, their buyers were mostly concentrated in Tamil Nadu and Andhra Pradesh, according to officers. Accused Anil and Karun said that they had joined the gang through Tarannum and another syndicate member Pradeep. They allegedly told the police that they would contact such families, lure them with money, and share information with other gang members through WhatsApp, their regu-

lar channel of communication. "Once a task was completed, they deleted the WhatsApp messages," said police. Apart from running a racket, they also used fake currency while dealing and making payments to the parents. "After the birth of a child, they mixed fake notes with a few genuine currency notes and handed the money to the parents of the abducted infant. By the time, the parents would find that the notes were counterfeit, the gang would have already fled with the baby," an officer said, adding that since the parents had themselves accepted money in exchange for the child, they were afraid to lodge complaints against the gang. Fake currency notes worth Rs 2,500 and four mobile phones have been recovered from the possession of the accused. Earlier this month, Delhi Police had also busted a similar racket that was operating out of a doctor's clinic in Northwest Delhi's Begumpur.

Plotted GK gym-owner killing, rose as a local gangster: Shabir pursued by cops for over a year

Pragynesh
New Delhi, June 26



Shabir Chaudhary in custody.

MONTHS AFTER Nadir Shah, an Afghan-origin businessman, was shot dead outside his gym in South Delhi's Greater Kailash-I on September 12, 2024, police were still connecting the dots to crack the murder case. Investigators suspected gangster Hashim Baba's involvement and they were hot on the trail of his allies — Shabir Chaudhary and Anwar Chacha. In April 2025, they finally caught hold of a man, who later became a witness in the case, for allegedly arranging an escape for the shooters. "This man told the police that Shabir and Anwar had masterminded the shooting. That is how we established the link with Hashim Baba," said a police source. The same month, Shabir and Anwar Chacha were both booked in a case filed under the stringent Maharashtra Control of Organised Crime Act (MCOCA). After over a year-long pur-

suit, police had a breakthrough on June 14 — Shabir Ahmad was nabbed from the Shambhu border in Haryana following specific intelligence and technical surveillance, an official said. He has been brought to Delhi for further legal proceedings, officers said on Friday. According to police, Shabir is a key member of the Hashim Baba gang, and allegedly heads the Shabir Chaudhary-Hashim Baba-Anwar Chacha crime syndicate. DCP Praveen Tripathi, who led the team that arrested him, told *The Indian Express*, "His gang is operating predominantly in the Trans-Yamuna and

North-East Delhi areas, including Seelampur, Bhajanpura, Maujpur, Shahdara, and adjoining districts of Uttar Pradesh. Multiple cases of extortion, murder, attempt to murder, land grabbing and other heinous crimes have been registered against the members of this gang. Members of this syndicate were also found to be operating from outside the country, mainly Nepal and Dubai." **Rise and fall of Shabir** It was a hot and humid afternoon in July, 2008. Shabir Chaudhary, who was gradually building a notorious reputation as a local gangster, was fuming, according to police. A native of Uttar Pradesh's Muzaffarnagar, he had allegedly started off with involvement in extortion and murder cases in North East Delhi in the mid-90s. Sitting somewhere in the dusty, cramped, and labyrinthian lanes of Seelampur — where budding gangsters in North East Delhi allegedly got trained — he plotted revenge for his brother's

killing, said officers. His brother, Shamim Chaudhary, was allegedly shot dead by the members of a rival gang led by jailed Anwar Thakur. The two alleged shooters, Roti and Ayub, were to come near Seelampur police station, learnt Shabir. That afternoon, Shabir and his men lynched both the shooters, on the gate of the police station, according to officers. Shabir then allegedly learnt that a man named Irshad had provided shelter to his brother's killers, and pierced 18 bullets inside Irshad's body on August 3. He now ticked all three hallmarks needed in the making of crime boss: poverty, misery and revenge, said police. Shabir would soon go to jail, where he would meet the kingmakers of the syndicates operating from the underbelly of the city — Hashim Baba and his "organiser-in-chief" Anwar Chacha, said police. The first MCOCA case against Shabir was filed in 2009, but Shabbir managed to get bail,

said a police officer. He merged his gang with Baba, and had been involved in over 14 cases, including that of murder, extortion, kidnapping. His recent big hit was arranging weapons and an escape plan for the killers of Nadir Shah. Shabir's arrest came as the second major blow to the Hashim Baba gang in the Capital. Earlier in February, the Delhi Police's Special Cell nabbed Mahfooz Ali alias Bobby Kabootar (45), who was known to be the last standing strongman for Hashim Baba gang in Northeast Delhi, overseeing all his extortion and betting operations. He was nabbed while he was crossing South Delhi's Mahipalpur area in his SUV, after a shopping spree with his girlfriend. Officers said Kabootar had been on the Delhi Police's wanted list for 10 years, managing to evade arrest whenever attempts were made to nab him. Local police and the Special Staff of the North District had conducted several raids to apprehend him.

● AT HUMANYUN'S TOMB MUSEUM

A date with a Renaissance master, his iconic depiction of mother and child

Anusree KC
New Delhi, June 26

IT WAS created more than five centuries ago, when Babur was yet to show up in India and Sikander Lodhi, who lies today in Lodhi Garden, was sultan of Delhi. It came to life in a studio in Florence where Sandro Botticelli lived and worked for most of his life, and significant portions of the artwork were likely created by the Early Renaissance master himself. The home of the painting is Museo Stibbert in Florence — but you can now see it at the Havells Gallery at the Humayun's Tomb World Heritage Site Museum near Sunder Nursery, Nizamuddin.

The luminous tempera of Botticelli's Madonna and Child, which is dated to the dying years of the 15th century, is the only painting in the exhibition of artworks in stone, bronze, and clay. The idea of the exhibition, which is ongoing until August 8, came together during a conversation over dinner between Andrea Anastasio, the director of the Italian Cultural Centre in India, and art historian Professor Naman P Ahuja of Jawahar Lal Nehru University. Anastasio had read Ahuja's essay, 'One Mother, Many Mother Tongues', first published by the Getty Foundation and subsequently by the arts magazine Marg in 2019, on the

representation of the bond between mother and child in art and literature down the ages. "I told him, this would be fantastic. It's a dream if we can blend this variety with the iconography of motherhood in Italy and the Mediterranean, where the mother holding a child has been depicted in very powerful ways much before the Romans came," Anastasio said. Ahuja agreed, and a year and a half of collaborative efforts followed to bring the exhibition to fruition. At its heart is the idea that Ahuja articulated in his paper — that the same image of the mother can be read through many mother tongues, regionally, culturally, personally.



● Madonna and Child

Sandro Botticelli's Madonna and Child, loaned from the Museo Stibbert in Florence, is part of the exhibition 'One Mother, Many Mother Tongues', which is on view at the Havells Gallery, first floor, Museum Courtyard, Humayun Tomb Museum, until August 8. PHOTO COURTESY: GURDEEP SINGH, ITALIAN EMBASSY CULTURAL CENTRE "When we work in advertising or media studies, the image has to appeal to multiple communities, religious groups, genders. The same image has to speak to a diverse group of people. I found a fantastic case study for that in Indian antiquity," Ahuja said. The exhibition, he said, is not an argument for sameness, but a demonstration of productive difference. Botticelli's workshop produced a whole series of Madonna and Child, depictions of the Virgin Mary and the infant Jesus, one of the most enduring

subjects in the history of art, to feed the demand for paintings on religious themes in the homes of wealthy Florentines. The Museo Stibbert artwork was completed in 1496-97, and belongs to the final period of Botticelli's life (1445-1510), by when he had lost his primary benefactor, Lorenzo de' Medici, the de facto ruler of the Florentine republic and the greatest patron of Renaissance art. Botticelli had by then all but abandoned the mythological grandeur of his earlier work and sunk into an almost obsess-

ive engagement with Madonna and Child, a theme he would paint some 40 times in the last two decades of his life. "The [Museo Stibbert] Madonna is completely withdrawn in herself. She looks melancholic... So it's a beautiful blend of theological statement, philosophical understanding, and the search for formal beauty," Anastasio said. The Museo Stibbert was set up by the English-Italian businessman Frederick Stibbert (1838-1906) using the vast fortune amassed in India by his

grandfather Giles Stibbert, an officer of the East India Company who fought in the Battle of Plassey in 1757, which led to the British taking over Bengal, and then the Battle of Buxar in 1764 in which the company defeated the combined armies of the Mughal emperor, the Nawabs of Oudh and Bengal, and the Maharaja of Benaras. According to the Museo Stibbert website, Frederick Stibbert collected artworks for about 50 years to transform his sprawling residence in Monttugi, Florence, into a historical museum. He left his collection to the Florence municipality in his will, and the museum was opened to the public in 1909.





House Guests at Guesthouse

A FOUR-DAY visit to Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh by the 13-member Parliamentary Standing Committee on External Affairs ended on a happy note on Wednesday as Chief Minister Omar Abdullah hosted the members at a guesthouse deep in the forest on the outskirts of Srinagar. Sources said the committee members were pleased with the hospitality shown by Abdullah at the guesthouse, where former PMs Indira Gandhi and Jawaharlal Nehru also stayed during their tenures. The committee, led by Congress MP Shashi Tharoor, has members including Congress's Rajeev Shukla, BJP MP Arun Govil and others. All the members were happy with the visit to the "historic guesthouse", said sources.

Focus on Healthcare

AS THE BJP prepares for the Punjab Assembly polls early next year, party's national general secretary Tarun Chugh on Friday called on Union Health Minister J P Nadda to discuss what he claimed was the "alarming" deterioration of the state's healthcare system. Insiders said the meeting initiated by the newly sworn-in Rajya Sabha MP was likely the first step towards "a key electoral promise" that the BJP is likely to announce during its poll campaign, targeting the AAP government's handling of the key health portfolio in Punjab.

Shah unveils 3-yr roadmap against drug networks

New Delhi: Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Friday announced a new three-year roadmap aimed at dismantling drug trafficking networks through a "ruthless crackdown", enforcement and financial investigations.

Chairing the 10th apex-level meeting of the Narco-Coordination Centre (NCORD), the home minister released the Vision Document on Drug Control (2026-2029), the Narcotics Control Bureau Annual Report-2025, and inaugurated the agency's zonal offices in Jammu and Guwahati via videoconferencing.

He said the vision document outlines a strategy focused on strengthening institutional capacity against synthetic drugs, darknet-based trafficking, cross-border smuggling and other emerging threats.

"Under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, we will strike the entire drug trade ecosystem so decisively over the next three years that it will not be able to recover for decades," Shah said. PTI

OPPOSITION DOUBLES DOWN ON SC-MONITORED PROBE

‘You will tell us what faith is’: Yogi says SP, Cong testing Ram bhakts’ patience

Express News Service
Lucknow, New Delhi, June 26

AMID ARRESTS of eight persons for the alleged theft and embezzlement of funds and valuables donated at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, Uttar Pradesh Chief Minister Yogi Adityanath on Friday warned that those "playing with the faith of Sanatan Dharma" will face consequences and asked the Samajwadi Party and the Congress not to test the patience of Ram bhakts.

He also came down heavily on the Congress and Samajwadi Party (SP) for "testing the patience of Ram bhakts by raising questions on the alleged embezzlement, questioning their locus standi on the issue.

On the other hand, the Opposition parties on Friday doubled down on their demand for a Supreme Court-monitored probe into the allegations of, saying Champat Rai's resignation as general secretary of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra trust was not enough, since there were so many questions and the issue was too big.



UP CM Yogi Adityanath inaugurates a hospital in Gorakhpur, Friday. PTI

Speaking at an event in Deoria, Adityanath said during his visit to Ayodhya on June 19, he had said the Special Investigation Team (SIT) was constituted to probe the claims and the government would take action as soon as its report is submitted. "The moment the SIT report came, action started," he said.

Taking a jibe at the Congress and the SP, he said, "Now you will tell us what faith is? They say faith has been compromised. This is not acceptable. The government, on the very first day, had made it clear that everything will come out."

"Tam telling (Opposition), do not test the patience of Ram bhakts. Stop playing with the faith of Ram bhakts. If you do not have concrete facts, then stop making allegations, counter allegations. And if you have the facts, present it with evidence before the SIT," he added.

Yogi further said, "The government has been initiating action as per the SIT's recommendations. And when a team of senior officials is working on it, then stop making political statements."

The CM also claimed the Op-

position had even questioned the existence of Lord Ram. "One of them used to say Lord Ram never existed. They even wanted to deny Ayodhya's existence. They continued fighting in court with a battery of lawyers against the Ram Janmabhoomi movement and the Ram temple," he added.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Congress Rajya Sabha member Rajeev Shukla said, "This issue is so big, Champat Rai couldn't be the only one behind this. So his resignation is not enough. The allegations look to be large-scale and the only way to find out the truth is by an investigation done by a Supreme Court-monitored probe. There are so many questions. Those directions were those accused in the case working under?"

At a press conference in Delhi, Shukla said the "self-proclaimed protectors of Hinduism" have been completely exposed with the revelations of the theft of donations at the Ram Temple in Ayodhya.

SP general secretary Shivpal Singh Yadav said a "huge theft

took place at Lord Ram's temple". "There should be a thorough investigation, and the culprits should be given strict punishment," he said.

TMC Rajya Sabha MP Sagarika Ghose told *The Indian Express* that the theft of donations had "exposed the moral plank of Hindutva politics of the BJP-RSS".

Former Delhi CM and Aam Aadmi Party (AAP) national convener Arvind Kejriwal, who visited the Ram Temple Friday, said a "major robbery" had taken place and that influential people involved in the alleged embezzlement of donations and gifts were being "protected".

CPI Rajya Sabha member P Sandosh Kumar said the theft "exposes the complete collapse of oversight and accountability inside the Ram Temple Trust".

Shiv Sena (UBT) MP Sanjay Raut said the main "culprits" of the theft are still working in the Trust. "Those who consider themselves 'Hindutvawadi' steal crores of rupees from the temple, and this money enters politics, where you use it to buy MPs and split political parties..."

In eye of donation row, Champat Rai and Anil Mishra face Opp ire



Ram Mandir Trust general secretary Champat Rai (right) and Trustee Anil Mishra. EXPRESS

Lalmuni Verma & Shyamal Yadav
Lucknow, New Delhi, June 26

A DAY after eight men were arrested for the embezzlement of funds donated to the Ram temple in Ayodhya, the two key members of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust who continued to face the Opposition's ire are its general secretary Champat Rai and trustee Anil Mishra. Though there have been no allegations against the two, one of the eight arrested is Rai's former driver Ram Shankar Yadav alias Tinnu Yadav.

Champat Rai

The 79-year-old was born in the Nagina tehsil of Uttar Pradesh's Bijnor district. After completing his post-graduate studies in Physics, Rai taught at a college in Nagina for 11 years before joining the RSS and becoming a pracharak during the Emergency. He served as a *gat nayak* (*shakha* organiser) and then *sah-zila karyavah* (district joint secretary) and was among those detained during the Emergency.

Between 1981 and 1984, Rai served as the Sangh's zila pracharak in Dehradun before moving on to Saharanpur and later Meerut. In the mid-1980s, when VHP was launching movements for the Ram Temple in Ayodhya, many RSS pracharaks were transferred to the VHP to work under the late Ashok Singhal. Rai was one of them. Rai became the prant co-organisation secretary of the VHP in July 1986 and later served as the organisation secretary for western UP.

At the height of the Ram Janmabhoomi movement in 1991, Rai was moved to Ayodhya. From 1991 to 1995, he was the VHP's co-organisation secretary for UP. He was shifted to Delhi in 1996 as the outfit's central co-secretary. He became VHP's international vice-president in 2018.

Rai came to the spotlight when he was appointed the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra's general secretary, becoming its key face. He super-

vised the temple construction from Karsevak Puram in Ayodhya, which served as his base. As the general secretary, he was practically the person in charge.

Even as he came under Opposition fire — with AAP national convener Arvind Kejriwal alleging that Rai refused to share accounts of the donations with the Prime Minister and the SIT that had been set up was only an eye-wash constituted to protect "big-people" — VHP's key functionaries in Ayodhya and Lucknow defended Rai, saying there might have been a "lapse in supervision" by Rai because "he trusted people around him".

Anil Mishra

Mishra, 65, was one of the 15 trustees of the Shri Ram Janmabhoomi Teerth Kshetra, which was formed in February 2020.

Ahead of the consecration ceremony of the Ram Temple on January 22, 2024, Mishra and his wife, Usha, performed the rituals as "*Pradhan Yajman* (main hosts)". Mishra began the rituals for the consecration of the Ram Lalla idol on January 16 by taking a dip in the Saryu river, amid the chanting of mantras. After that, he began a fast and performed the prashchita, sankalpa, and karmakuti pujas, which lasted for eight hours.

Mishra lives in Ayodhya and, since being named a trustee, has frequently interacted with the media, locals, and VIP visitors about the progress of the temple's construction work.

Mishra hails from UP's Ambedkar Nagar. He too joined the RSS during the Emergency but became more active post-1990. He rose through the ranks, becoming a *prant sah-karyavah* and later the *prant karyavah* of the RSS in Awadh region. He was also associated with the Ram temple movement and is a member of the RSS's Awadh regional unit. At the Trust, he supervises all sales and purchases. His office is located in the basement of Pilgrims Facilitation Centre, adjoining the counting centre, where donations are counted.

‘No special ties with CM’: Karnataka BJP chief amid MLC poll cross-voting row

Express News Service
Bengaluru, June 26

KARNATAKA BJP president B Y Vijayendra, who is in the eye of an internal party storm after cross-voting by party MLAs in the June 18 MLC elections, has sought to allay speculation that his close ties with Chief Minister D K Shivakumar played a role in the development.

During the course of a visit to the temple town of Dharmasthala—where he had earlier sought to hold a BJP legislature meeting to get the MLAs to swear on God regarding their

voting—Vijayendra said on Friday that he had no business or friendly ties with Shivakumar.

"When the cross-voting happened, there were allegations that Vijayendra had business ties with Shivakumar. There is a friendly association between Vijayendra and Shivakumar, it was insinuated on social media and made to seem that I have myself facilitated the cross-voting..." he added.

"There is no business association between Vijayendra and Shivakumar. There is no special friendship either..." he added.

Can Sarma govt in Assam stop Aadhaar cards for all above 18? Experts differ

Amaal Sheikh
New Delhi, June 26

ANNOUNCING THAT his government would stop issuing Aadhaar cards to adults above the age of 18, Chief Minister Himanta Biswa Sarma framed it as a measure to check illegal Bangladeshi migrants obtaining Indian identity documents.

However, experts are divided on whether a state government, whose role is essentially defined as an Aadhaar "registrar", can impose a pre-clearance requirement on enrolment, when it is not part of the Aadhaar Act 2016 or in the regulations and processes set by the Unique Identification Authority of India (UIDAI).

Sarma said that now, no more Aadhaar cards will be approved for adults at the district level in Assam. "If at all, there is some genuine person, then the Deputy Commissioner will send a proposal and the government will approve. But at the DC level, no more Aadhaar cards will be issued to a citizen more than 18 years of age."

Alok Prasanna Kumar, co-founder of the Vidhi Centre for Legal Policy, says: "The state government has no legal power to stop Aadhaar enrolment. At best, a state can request the Central government to ask the UIDAI to do the same."

Prasanna Kumar adds that the state government as such is not involved in the issue of Aadhaar cards, with a person applying directly to the UIDAI, biometrics processed centrally, and the UIDAI issuing the card.

Usha Ramanathan, an activist who has written extensively on the Aadhaar framework, also says that Assam's actions appear to be "a simple usurpation of power... a brazen statement of defiance of the law".



CM Himanta Biswa Sarma at an event in Guwahati on Friday. ANI

Section 3(1) of the UIDAI Act provides that every resident shall be entitled to obtain an Aadhaar number by submitting demographic and biometric information through the enrolment process. "Resident" is defined as "an individual who has resided in India for a period or periods amounting in all to one hundred and eighty-two days or more in the twelve months immediately preceding the date of application for enrolment." There is no age limit defined for Aadhaar enrolment, with even a newborn entitled to do so.

The proviso to Section 3(1) gives only the Central government the power to notify any additional category of individuals who may be entitled.

Section 9 of the Act states that the Aadhaar number shall not by itself "confer any right, or be proof of, citizenship or domicile". The decision to use Aadhaar enrolment as a check on immigration therefore has to contend with the Act's own framing of what Aadhaar is and is not.

Sources in the Central government argue that adult enrolments already require approval by the state—and Assam's "infil-

‘Mamata Banerjee is still our leader, she formed the party... but I backed majority’

Atri Mitra & Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, June 26

EARLIER THIS week, veteran MLA Arup Roy replaced Mamata Banerjee as the Trinamool Congress's (TMC) chairperson at a special session convened by the party's rebel bloc. In an interview, Roy, the Howrah Madhya MLA, talks about the rebellion that has split the party, Mamata Banerjee as his leader, and what the rebel bloc will do next. Excerpts:

You have been with Mamata Banerjee and the TMC from the very first day. You have seen TMC in Opposition

and then as a ruling party, and again in Opposition. What is your experience?

Ami uttor debo na, er kono uttor hoy na (I will not give any answer. This can have no answer).

Why did you decide to side with the rebels?

I did not organise anybody; others did. I stood with the side that had more numbers. I received an invitation from the Leader of the Opposition's (LoP Ritabrata Banerjee) side and attended their meeting.

What went through your mind?

Numbers. Those who have

the numbers approached me and showed the signatures they had collected. I saw that and signed their letter.

You are now the chairperson of the rebel group that claims to have the majority of MLAs and leaders on its side. What is your priority for the party?

Things will take time. The district committees and state committees have not been formed. It will take time.

While you claimed you did not sign the proposal to appoint Sovondeb Chattopadhyay the Leader of the Opposition, the party



displayed a signature, claiming it was yours. What is your response?

I remember that the first

meeting (after the election loss) was held at the residence of Mamata Banerjee. I did sign there. But the signature on the document that the police showed me (following a complaint that some of the signatures submitted by the party to the Speaker's office had been forged) was not my signature.

Is the next step gaining control of the party symbol and others?

As far as the party symbol is concerned, the Election Commission (EC) will decide it. We gave a formal letter to the EC.

Who gets to control the

bank account of the party? Is there any plan to audit the money in the account?

There was no resolution passed about the bank account. The LoP (Ritabrata Banerjee), however, said one auditor would be appointed to examine the account.

Most of the MPs and MLAs who have rebelled have questioned the leadership of Abhishek Banerjee. Do you agree with them?

The opinions of the MPs and the MLAs are separate. The MLAs who gave their opinions it is their personal statement. I have no allegations against anybody.

You are now chairperson of the TMC, while Mamata Banerjee is the chairperson of the other half.

Mamata Banerjee is still our leader. She formed the party. She is *Kandari* (the person who steers) of the party. We started the party because of Mamata Banerjee. I am trying to move her party forward.

The LoP (Ritabrata Banerjee) said he wants Mamata Banerjee as the TMC's chief advisor...

He expressed his opinion, but I am not saying that. What I want to say, I have already done.

What will be your strategy

in the Assembly?

We will provide constructive criticism. We will point out the faults of the BJP and oppose their policies.

What do you have to say about TMC workers who have come under attack following the defeat in the elections?

We have to stand beside our workers. I said that in the meeting also. Those who are facing legal cases for committing crimes, their issue is separate. But those workers and leaders who are innocent, we have to stand beside them. It is our prime responsibility to stand beside them.

GROUNDreport

Priest stabbed 26 times: Rajasthan Police probe row over land worth crores owned by Math

Parul Kulshrestha
Kota, June 26

BEHIND THE killing of Devanand Maharaj, the chief priest of Kota's Chandresal Math, who was stabbed 26 times outside his residence earlier this month, may lie a battle for control of the 10th-century Math, its trust and 345 bighas of land – shaped by a complex interplay of caste, faith, power and money.

Among the eight arrested for the June 5 murder of Devanand, 35, are another Math priest, Nandan Ban, and a Kota-based lawyer, Santosh Kumar Rai. Four people, including a minor, were hired to carry out the murder, says the Station House Officer of Borkheda Police Station, Anil Tailor, who is investigating the case. Investigators and trust members talk of an escalating dispute between Devanand and Rai, who represented the trust in a civil dispute over nominations to the Math body that controls the shrine and its vast properties.

Devanand's kin say that five months ago, he received death threats, asking him to leave the Math. "These recordings have been given to police," his brother Budhraj Gurjar says.

Born Dev Shankar Poswal in Rajasthan's Sawai Madhopur district, and married at the age of 15 in 2006, Devanand had left



Chandresal Math in Kota; (R) Devanand Maharaj. PARUL KULSHRESTHA

home in 2018 and announced renunciation of the world. He was earlier affiliated with the Juna Akhada, which is part of the Dashnam Sanyasi monastic order as the Chandresal Math. What's different is that while the Math follows the Ban Panth, a scholar-ascetic tradition, Juna Akhada follows the Giri Panth, a warrior-ascetic tradition. Fis-sures followed as shifting between the two orders is traditionally not permitted. "When he joined, a lot of people had objections," admits Brijmohan, 70, a member of the Chandresal Mahadev Mandir Trust.

There were also caste under-currents, with a section of the trustees accusing Devanand of "favouring" members of his own Gurjar community. A trust member says: "Gurjars wanted

him to take charge of the Math so that their possession of the land would remain secure."

But it wasn't until 2024, when Devanand began "consolidating power", that the dispute took its present form. At the heart of it were 345 bighas, or 215 acres, of disputed temple land.

Investigators and trust members say the dispute dates back nearly half a century, when the then mahant, Sharavan Ban, decided to sell 500 bighas of temple land, much of which passed into private hands. In 1998, after discovering that donated land had been alienated, residents of nearby villages filed a civil suit to recover 345 bighas they had managed to trace.

In 2003, while court proceedings were underway, residents approached the state govern-



SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT

ment to register a trust – a move that shifted control of the Math's assets away from the mahant, leaving him only as caretaker and manager. Sharavan Ban's family argued at the time that the land was their private property. In 2016, after years of hearings, the court held that the properties belonged to the Math. However, says a trust member, "the court appointed a receiver until the property dispute and all related appeals were finally disposed of".

The member says the court also held that 270 of the 345 bighas were agricultural land, and would be auctioned off every year by the tehsildar, with the money deposited in a bank account. "This now amounts to Rs 4 crore. This money too has become a point of dispute," says the member. The order was challenged before the court of the Additional District Judge-I, where the matter remains pending.

The last hearing was on May 27.

Earlier this year, Rai entered the picture, at a time when the Math was already divided between those for and against Devanand. Rai reportedly offered to fight the case free of charge, but gradually gained influence among Devanand's opponents. Trust members claim Rai also sought to place his own nominees in the seven vacant trust positions, potentially giving him control over the Math's properties, undercutting Devanand. Elderly trustees also relied on Rai to handle the litigation, allowing him to become a key figure in trust affairs.

Says a trust member: "Rai used to visit the Math and got in touch with other members, representing them in court... But Devanand didn't cede." On the other hand, he joined the fight, backing his own supporters in the trust.

Records of the Rajasthan's Devasthan Department, which manages the state's religious endowments, trusts and historic temples, show Devanand had applied to add names to the trust, a move Rai objected to.

The hearing was on June 10, says a department official, calling Devanand's application "routine". On June 5, Devanand was killed.

No aloo-pyaaz, steep petrol: Manipur district feels pinch of conflict

Sukrita Baruah
Guwahati, June 26

SOME PARTS of Manipur have been struggling to receive a regular supply of groceries and other goods for over a month as unrest in the state turned into a three-way conflict, with blockades on multiple sides choking the flow of supplies.

The starkest example of this currently is the Kuki-Zo-majority Kangpokpi district. The major routes for goods to come into the district starts from Dimapur in Nagaland and pass through Manipur's Naga-majority Senapati district or through Meitei-majority Imphal.

With the conflict in the state widening from one that started in 2023 between the Kuki-Zo and Meitei communities to the latest escalations between the Kuki-Zo and Naga communities, the route to Kangpokpi faces issues on multiple fronts. Naga groups in both Senapati and the state capital have blocked the plying of goods vehicles into Kangpokpi.

The current set of blockades began after tensions flared on May 13, with the killing of three Kuki-Zo church leaders in Kangpokpi, which was followed by a mass taking of hostages on both sides. This culminated in six Naga hostages being found killed earlier this month.

During this time, blockades and shutdowns were called by both sides, but Kuki-Zo groups in Kangpokpi found that they were the worst affected by this



network of blockades. The complete blockades were subsequently called off, but a United Naga Council leader said the community's "economic blockade" against Kuki-Zos is still ongoing.

A wholesale distributor in Kangpokpi, who did not want to be identified, said, "There are no goods – no sugar, salt, aloo (potatoes) or pyaaz (onions). We had some stock, and shops made that last for about a month. We didn't allow panic buying and distributed and sold items according to people's needs. But that stock has also finished, except for items that sell less, like confectionery. It has been over for about 20 days now, our supply hasn't come in since May 13."

He said that petrol is being sold at Rs 300 per litre in bottles in the town, and LPG cylinders for between Rs 3,500 and Rs 4,000.

The last time he had stock to sell, the wholesaler said, was a

couple of days ago, when Deputy Chief Minister Nemcha Kipgen, who is an MLA from the district, facilitated the arrival of 640 bags – 50 kg each – of rice.

"Normally, these kinds of bags are sold for around Rs 1,800 each, but these were sold for Rs 2,000 because of additional logistical expenses," said the distributor.

A district administration official said that they received a consignment of rice with the help of the three MLAs representing the district, of which 40-50 quintals were distributed to each Sub-Divisional Officer (SDO) on Friday, to be sold through distributors. He said that a truck of LPG cylinders also arrived for ration card holders on Friday.

"We have received an amount of rice, with the assistance of the MLAs and transported by the security forces, but I cannot say that is enough food supplies," he said.

The challenge in movement is also affecting access to healthcare. With the district hospital's limited facilities, patients requiring further treatment would earlier travel to Imphal, and later, after the start of the conflict between Meiteis and Kuki-Zos, to Kohima by road.

"Now if there are serious patients, they contact the relevant SDO in charge of the area to facilitate their movement in an Army convoy to Imphal, which is being done every two to three days," said the official.

3 held for 'poisoning' MP forest pond in mass hunting attempt

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, June 26

Carcasses of 12 cheetal, 2 sambar found near pond in Vijayraghavgarh forest range

THE MADHYA Pradesh Forest Department has arrested three men for allegedly poisoning a forest pond to hunt wild animals after 12 cheetal and two sambar were found dead in Katni district's Vijayraghavgarh forest range.

The deaths came to light on Thursday during a routine patrol by forest personnel in the Ghughri beat of the Vijayraghavgarh range.

Officials found the carcasses of the animals scattered within a radius of around 100 metres of a pond in Reserve Forest compartment RF-62. The area was subsequently secured, and an investigation was launched.

According to forest officials, a dog squad was pressed into service as part of efforts to trace those responsible. During the search, the dog squad led investigators to a house in Ghughri village.

Forest officials said searches at the premises led to the recovery of fresh meat, blood-stains, animal hair, snares and other equipment suspected to have been used for hunting.

Based on the investigation, forest officials detained three suspects. Officials said the three

admitted during preliminary questioning that they had mixed a poisonous substance into the pond with the intention of killing wild animals for meat. The alleged confession has not been independently verified.

All 14 carcasses were seized and subjected to post-mortem examination. Forest officials said the animals were later disposed of in accordance with departmental procedures. Water samples from the pond have also been collected and sent to a laboratory for chemical analysis to establish the exact cause of death.

The accused have been booked under provisions of the Wildlife (Protection) Act. "Preliminary questioning suggests the accused mixed poison into the pond. We have collected water samples for forensic examination and registered a case under the Wildlife (Protection) Act. Further investigation is underway," DFO Garvit Gangawar said.

HC raps state govt, civic body over Surat demolitions: 'Axe has to fall..'

Aditi Raja & Kamal Saiyed
Vadodara/Surat, June 26



Around 150 homes in Surat's Nasirnagar were razed in May.

AFTER NEARLY 150 homes in Surat's Nasirnagar were reduced to rubble in May, no authority has yet taken responsibility for the demolition – a gap that prompted the Gujarat High Court Thursday to question the state government, the municipal corporation, and even Torrent Power over who ordered the action and why due process was allegedly bypassed.

Residents of Nasirnagar slum in the city's Ved Darwaja area moved the Gujarat High Court earlier this month, challenging the demolition of several shanties, alleging that bulldozers razed their homes without notice or any demolition order.

The demolition, allegedly carried out under police protection, has since been denied by the Surat Municipal Corporation, even as BJP MLA Vinu Moradiya called the episode

"something fishy," deepening questions over who authorised the operation.

Hearing the petition, Justice Nikhil Kariel orally questioned the Surat Municipal Corporation and remarked that even the "demolition of a single house" without due process could "not be countenanced".

The court orally directed the Surat civic body to prepare a "definite rehabilitation plan" for the displaced residents by Mon-

day, pending the decision on the petition. "I will not hear a submission that you do not have accommodation. Rent tents if you have to... The axe has to fall, and it will," Justice Kariel said orally.

It also asked the government to explain why a deputy commissioner of police rank officer and municipal officials were allegedly present if the demolition was, as authorities claimed, not an official exercise.

Through Government Pleader G H Virk, the court orally directed that a personal affidavit from the Surat police commissioner should be placed before the HC Monday, explaining the police response to the residents' complaints. "If the commissioner is informed that 150 houses have been demolished, either he says it was an official demolition by the Corporation, or he explains why no FIR has been registered... The (Commissioner) cannot choose to ignore such allegations."

GOVERNMENT OF INDIA
MINISTRY OF DEFENCE
EX-SERVICEMEN CONTRIBUTORY HEALTH SCHEME
STATION HQ (ECHS CELL), 7BRD AF STN TUGHLAKABAD
PHONE: 011-21820078
e-mail: echstughlakabad7brd@gmail.com
EMPLOYMENT NOTICE

1. ECHS invites applications to engage following Medical Officer, ParaMedical and Non-Medical Staff on contractual basis in ECHS Polyclinic, Khanpur for a period of one-year for ESM and 11 Months for Civilian Candidate renewable for additional period of one yearfor ESM only till attaining the maximum age subject to performance of candidates/other conditions according to the criteria as mentioned against eachpost: -

Appointment	Minimum Qualification	Work Experience	No. of vacancy	Fixed Remuneration
Medical Officer	MBBS	Min three years after internship. Preferable additional qualifications in Medicine/ Surgery.	02	95,000/-
Dental Officer	BDS	Minimum 03 Yrs work experience.	01	95,000/-
Lab Assistant	DMLT/ Class-I Laboratory Tech Course (Armed Forces)	Minimum three years work experience in Laboratory	01	36500/-
Lab Technician	(i) B.Sc (Medical Lab Technology) or (i) Matriculation/ Higher Secondary/ Senior Secondary (10+2) with Science from Recognized Institution/Board. (ii) Diploma in Medical Lab Technology from a Recognized Institution.	Minimum 03 yrs experience as a Lab Assistant in a Medical Lab	01	36500/-
Pharmacist	i) B Pharmacy form a recognized institute or (i) 10+2 with Science stream (physics, Chemistry, Biology) from a recognized board. And (ii) Approved Diploma in Pharmacy from an Institute recognized by the Pharmacy council of India and registered as pharmacist under the Pharmacy Act 1948.	Minimum 03 years experience	01	36500/-
Dental Hygienist	Diploma Holder in Dental Hyg/ Class-DH/DORA Course (Armed Forces)	Minimum 05 years experience in Dental Laboratory	01	36500/-
Clerk	Graduate/ Class-I Clerical trade (Armed Forces)	Minimum 05 years experience	01	29,200/-
Driver	Education - 8 Class Class-I MT driver (Armed Forces) Posses of Civil driving License	Minimum 05 years work experience as Driver	01	25,600/-
Vigilance Operator	Education-Class 8th or GD Trade for Armed Forces personnel	-	01	21,800/-
Multi-Tasking Staff (MTS)	Education -Class 8 GD trade (Armed Forces)	Minimum 05 years service	01	21,800/-
House Keeper	Literate	Minimum 05 years service	01	21,800/-

2. For Terms & Conditions, Application Form & Remuneration. Kindly see our website www.echs.gov.in for additional details, please contact Sin HQ (ECHS Cell) 7 BRD, AF Stn Tughlakabad at Mob No. 9086846728, 7470610570& e-mail id: - echstughlakabad7brd@gmail.com. Also approach concerned ECHS Polyclinic for details. Preference will be given to the Ex-Servicemen.

3. Last date of receipt of application as per format given at our website. Application as per requisite format along with self attested photocopies of testimonials in support of educational qualifications and work experience will be submitted to OIC ECHS Cell, 7BRD Air Force Station, Tughlakabad-110080 by 10 Jul 26 in duplicate copy. Any application received after 10 Jul 26 will not be accepted.

4. Interview Date Timing & Venue. Candidate must reach ECHS Polyclinic C/O 7 BRD Air Force Station, Tughlakabad at 1000 hrs. on 22 Jul 26 for the interview. Candidates must bring all the original certificates/mark sheets/degree of 10th /Matric, 10+2 & graduation /post-graduation/diploma/course, work experience and discharge book. PPO, service records and 01 PP size color photograph at the time of interview. No TA/DA is admissible. Only candidates meeting the qualitative requirements may apply.

Note- For Medical& Dental Officers only: As per policy of Cent Org (ECHS), AG's Br, HHQ of MoD(Army) Delhi Cantt, the Selected Medical& Dental Officer will undergo 10 days on the job training(OJT) and obtain certificate from OIC Polyclinic before assuming the charge as a contractual employment. The said period remains unpaid and is a mandatory requirement before assuming the charge.

संचालनालय वित्तीय प्रबंध एवं सूचना प्रणाली,
छत्तीसगढ़ मंत्रालय, महानदी भवन, नवा रायपुर अटल नगर
ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट निविदा निरस्तीकरण सूचना

क्रमांक/1/484373/2026 नवा रायपुर अटल नगर, दिनांक 23-06-2026

इस कार्यालय के निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना क्रमांक 1/215735/2025 दिनांक 17/12/2025 द्वारा आमंत्रित ऑनलाईन निविदा निरस्त किया जाता है।
(संचालक द्वारा अनुमोदित)

हस्ता./-
सहायक संचालक
वित्तीय प्रबंध एवं
सूचना प्रणाली, छत्तीसगढ़

No.262701680/3

FOOD CORPORATION OF INDIA
Regional Office : Punjab, Bays No. 34-38, Sector 31-A,
Chandigarh-160047, Ph: 0172-2638543-545, Fax : 2638259

NOTICE
Sh. Amit Pal Singh, AG- III (Tech), DOB- 22/11/1989 posted at Regional Office Chandigarh, Punjab did not join the duty after availing 561 days Ex-India leave w.e.f 16/06/2023 to 27/12/2024 to visit USA which was sanctioned vide HRMS Ref No.: NOCCOUNTR/RO CHANDIGARH/296918/2 dated 02/06/2023 and is still on unauthorized absence till date. The official had also furnished an undertaking vide HRMS Ref No.: NOCCOUNTR/ RO CHANDIGARH/296918/2 dated 02/06/2023 that "I will not extend the leave granted to me. In case of overstay of the period allowed, the Management would treat that I have voluntarily abandoned my duty with Food Corporation of India and that the Management will be free to strike off my name from the rolls of Food Corporation of India. I would have no claim and right on the service of the corporation thereafter." Further, Chargesheet under Reg-58 dated 16.12.2025 has been issued to the official since the official is absent from work after the expiry of his sanctioned Ex-India leave period. However, the said Chargesheet, which was sent through speed post, has been returned unserved from the residential address in Himachal & Punjab available as per his service records. The same has been returned unserved with remarks of 'insufficient address' and 'no such person on this add'. An email/application dated 14.05.2026 from <mbt.singh89@gmail.com> has been received to this office regarding resignation of above mentioned official. However, the authenticity and authorship of the said communication could not be verified, as it was not submitted through the official email ID of the employee. In the absence of verifiable proof establishing that the email was actually sent by Sh. Amit Pal Singh, the same cannot be treated as a valid resignation request for administrative purposes. Therefore, Sh. Amit Pal Singh, AG-III (Tech), is hereby given a final opportunity to resume duty within thirty (30) days from the date of issue/ publication of this notice, failing which further disciplinary action shall be initiated against him under Regulation 63 (ii) of FCI (Staff) Regulation, 1971.

General Manager (Punjab Region)

ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण
प्लॉट नं०-1 सेक्टर के०पी०-4, ग्रेटर नोएडा सिटी, गौतमबुद्ध नगर-201308, उ०प्र०
वेबसाइट: www.greaternoidaauthority.in | ईमेल: authority@gnida.in

पत्रांक: वरि० प्र०/ई-निविदा सेल/ 2026 / 772 दिनांक: 25 / 06 / 2026

ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना

महाप्रबन्धक (अभियन्त्रण) ग्रेटर नोएडा औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा मुख्य कार्यपालक अधिकारी, ग्रेटर नोएडा की ओर से ई-निविदा आमंत्रण सूचना संख्या – वरि० प्र० (ई-निविदा सेल) / 2026 / 771 दिनांक 25 / 06 / 2026 के माध्यम से उल्लेखित क्रम संख्या-01 से 24 तक के कार्य की ई-निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती हैं। समस्त नियम व शर्तें ग्रेटर नोएडा प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.greaternoidaauthority.in पर ई-निविदा लिंक एवं ई-पोर्टल <https://etender.up.nic.in> पर उपलब्ध हैं, किसी परिवर्तन, संशोधन व अतिरिक्त सूचनाओं के लिए उक्त वेबसाइट देखते रहें।

क्र.सं.	कार्य का नाम/वर्क सर्फिल	अनुमानित लागत
निर्माण का कार्य		
1.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर फाई-3 में बाइप्लेनोवाल की मरम्मत और कोइल फेसिंग का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-4)	रु० 33.99 लाख
2.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम तिलपता करनावास में तिलपता करनावास से रथोरराजपुर तक नहर सफाई का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-2)	रु० 44.02 लाख
3.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम चमतावली व बोडाकी में बारात घर और खेल के मैदान के नवीनीकरण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-6)	रु० 45.10 लाख
4.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम अमीनाबाद उर्फ नियाना में इंटरलॉकिंग टाइल्स लगाने और ड्रेन का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 51.59 लाख
5.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम बागपुर आर०सी०सी० नाली का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 66.90 लाख
6.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर बीटा-1 एवं 2 में वन विभाग पार्क की चारदीवारी का सिल अनुसंधान कार्य एवं एफ०आर०पी० रेलिंग लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-6)	रु० 90.20 लाख
7.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम रोसनपुर में इंटरलॉकिंग टाइल्स उपलब्ध कराने व विद्युत और (अवशेष) नाली का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 107.26 लाख
8.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम सैनी में आर०सी०सी० ड्रेन का निर्माण और सी०सी० रोड उद्घाटन का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-2)	रु० 127.78 लाख
9.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के विभिन्न ग्रामों के तालाबों की सुरक्षा हेतु कॉंस वायर जाली लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 142.39 लाख
10.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के वर्क सर्फिल 8 के 17 ग्रामों में ओपन जिम उपकरण उपलब्ध कराने और लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 155.93 लाख
11.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के अधिवृष्टित क्षेत्र में ग्राम सिरसा का स्मार्ट बिलेज के रूप में विकास कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-8)	रु० 158.10 लाख
12.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में खसना नाले (ताज राजमार्ग) के किनारे आर०सी०सी० प्रोटेक्शन वॉल का निर्माण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-1)	रु० 195.91 लाख
वार्षिक अनुरक्षण		
13.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ईकोटैक-2 (एल०जी० साइड) का तीन वर्षों के अनुरक्षण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-5)	रु० 128.96 लाख
14.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर टेकजोन-2 तीन वर्षों तक रखरखाव / अनुरक्षण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु० 113.23 लाख
15.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम तिलपता रोटीरी से मकोडा रोटीरी तक 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क का तीन वर्षों तक रखरखाव / अनुरक्षण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु० 150.63 लाख
16.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ज्यू-3 में 60 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क का तीन वर्षों तक अनुरक्षण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-7)	रु० 162.55 लाख
विद्युतीकरण के कार्य		
17.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के ग्राम हतेवा, नवादा, बिसायव और घघोला ग्रामों में ई-लाइटिंग / सामाजिक प्रयोजन भवन के लिए आंतरिक विद्युतीकरण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ई एमड.एम-3)	रु० 06.16 लाख
18.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के जी०एन०आई०एन० कार्यालय भवन में 33 / 0.415 के.बी. ड्राई टाइप ट्रांसफार्मर की रिप्लेसिंग स्थापना परीक्षण एवं कमीशनिंग का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएमड.एम-2)	रु० 32.86 लाख
19.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ओमिकॉन-1 में 120.78 वर्ग मीटर क्षेत्र में स्थित (सी+3 चार मंजिला) मकानों का विद्युत कार्यों की मरम्मत और रखरखाव का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएमड.एम-2)	रु० 124.45 लाख
20.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ज्यू-3 और बीडर्स एरिया के पार्कों, सड़कों और फुटपाथों पर एल.ई.डी. स्ट्रीट लाइट और एल.ई.डी. हाई मास्ट लगाने का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-ईएमड.एम-3)	रु० 132.22 लाख
उद्यान विभाग		
21.	ग्रेटर नोएडा 130 मीटर चौड़ी सड़क (सेक्टर ओमिकॉन-3) के साथ पार्क और ग्रीन बेल्ट का दो वर्षों हेतु संचालित अनुरक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-उद्यान)	रु० 131.30 लाख
22.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ओमिकॉन-1 में दो वर्षों हेतु वृक्षों, झाड़ियों और लॉन के सहित संचालित कार्य अनुरक्षण का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल उद्यान)	रु० 151.43 लाख
23.	ग्रेटर नोएडा के सेक्टर ज्यू-2 में सभी पार्कों में घास लगाना एवं पड़ पौधों एवं लॉन तथा संचालित कार्य सहित एक वर्ष तक के लिए अनुरक्षण कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-उद्यान)	रु० 153.11 लाख
स्वास्थ्य विभाग		
24.	ग्रेटर नोएडा में ग्राम पोवारी स्थित गौशाला में एक वर्ष हेतु हरे चारे की आपूर्ति का कार्य। (वर्क सर्फिल-स्वास्थ्य)	रु० 78.84 लाख

क्रम सं०- 01 से 24 तक के कार्यों को दिनांक 30.06.2026 से 10.07.2026 को 5:00 बजे तक अपलोड किया जा सकता है। प्राप्त ई-निविदाओं की प्री-क्वालिफिकेशन दिनांक 13.07.2026 को 11:00 बजे खोली जाएगी।

वरिष्ठ प्रबंधक (ई-निविदा सेल)

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epaper.indianexpress.com

उ०प्र० अग्निशमन तथा आपात सेवा मुख्यालय, लखनऊ।

प्रथम/द्वितीय तल, चतुर्थ टावर, सिग्नेचर बिल्डिंग पुलिस मुख्यालय, लखनऊ

Email- fshqup@gmail.com

पत्रसंख्या: एफ०एस० (टी)- 233-2026 (HP) दिनांक: जून, 24,2026

निविदा सूचना

उत्तर प्रदेश अग्निशमन तथा आपात सेवा हेतु 03 अदद हाईड्रोलिक प्लेटफार्मों (ऊँचाई 72मीटर) क्रय/निर्माण किये जाने हेतु जेम पोर्टल पर जेम कस्टम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7704902 दिनांक 24.06.2026 को कस्टम बिड की गयी। जिसका विवरण निम्नवत है:-

BID DETAILS	
जेम कस्टम बिड संख्या	GEM/2026/B/7704902
दिनांक	24.06.2026
बिड बंद होने की तारीख/समय	09.07.2026 17:00:00
बिड खुलने होने की तारीख/समय	09.07.2026 17:30:00
बिड पेशकश वैधता (बंद होने की तारीख से)	180(DAYS)
प्री-बिड मीटिंग तारीख/समय	30.06.2026 12:00:00 UPFSHQ, LKO
	Online

उत्तर प्रदेश अग्निशमन तथा आपात सेवा हेतु 03 अदद हाईड्रोलिक प्लेटफार्मों (ऊँचाई 72 मीटर) क्रय/निर्माण किये जाने हेतु जेम पोर्टल पर जेम कस्टम बिड संख्या- GEM/2026/B/7704902 दिनांक 24.06.2026 में उल्लिखित एवं जेम पोर्टल पर उल्लिखित क्रय संबंधित समस्त नियम व शर्तों के साथ ही ऑनलाइन प्रतिभाग करने का कष्ट करें।

(सुभाष कुमार)

मुख्य अग्निशमन अधिकारी/नोडल अधिकारी (परचेज), अग्निशमन तथा आपात सेवा, मुख्यालय, उ०प्र०, लखनऊ।

UPID-253004 Date 25/06/2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

**SOUTH CENTRAL RAILWAY**
Follow us on  @SCRRailwayIndia Details of the Tender Notices of S.C Railway can be seen on our website : www.scr.indianrailways.gov.in

EXPRESSION OF INTEREST (EOI)
Expression of Interest (EOI) for Engagement of Professional Housekeeping Agencies for Better On Board Housekeeping Services (OBHS) in Coaching Trains over South Central Railway.

On behalf of President of India, PCME/SCR Invites EOI to empanel competent and experienced agencies for providing enhanced and high-quality On-Board Housekeeping Services as per the policy guidelines on "Reforms for Better On-Board Services" and Evaluation Criteria for empanelment of agencies, issued by Railway Board.

- EOI offer and required documents can be downloaded from the website <http://scr.indianrailways.gov.in>
- EOI shall be submitted in sealed envelope, using prescribed format, along with complete details of technical offer and relevant documents. The EOI proposals shall be submitted in the Box available in Dy.CENHM/SCR, Room No. 105, First Floor, Mechanical Department, South Central Railway, Headquarters Office, Rail Nilayam, Secunderabad-500003.
- Date & Time of EOI documents submission: Within 15 days of issue of this notification.

A478 Principal Chief Mechanical Engineer, Secunderabad

AUGMENTATION OF INSTALLED AUTOMATIC FIRE ALARM AND DETECTION SYSTEM

Tender No. SNT-14-LMG-2026-27
Dated: 24-06-2026. Works tenders through "E" Tendering system for and on behalf of the president of India are invited for the works as detailed below:-
Name of work: Augmentation of Installed Automatic Fire Alarm and Detection System of make Ravel & Nofotire of Lumding Division. **Tender Value:** ₹2,47,22,874.31/- **Earnest Money:** ₹4,94,500/- **Date & time of Closing of tender:** At 15.00 hrs. & opening at 15.30 hrs. on 16-07-2026. The complete information with tender documents of above e-tender will be available in the website www.ireps.gov.in

DSTE, Lumding
 **NORTHEAST FRONTIER RAILWAY**
Serving Customers With A Smile

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that that accused person(s) **Mukeet Ur Rehman S/o Mr. Mansoor R/o S-1/9, 2nd Floor, Jogabai Extn., Batla House, Jamia Nagar, New Delhi-110025 also at: H.No. 650, Banbatan Chowk, Khair Nagar Gate, Kaisar Ganj, Meerut, U.P.-250002** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No./CC No. **2461/24 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Darya Ganj, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Mukeet Ur Rehman** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Mukeet Ur Rehman** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Mukeet Ur Rehman** of FIR No./CC No. **2461/24 U/s 138 NI Act, PS Darya Ganj, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **01.08.2026 at 10:00 AM.**

By Order
Sh. Arjun Kirar
Ld. JMFC-05 (NI Act), CBA-1
Room No. 2, Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/8262/CD/2026 (Court Matter)

**Directorate of Medical Education and Research, Haryana Panchkula**

4th Floor, DHL Square, Plot No. 9, IT Park, Sector-22, Panchkula Haryana 134112
Ph. 0172-2584633, 2560799 | email: dmer-hry@nic.in
Website: <https://dmer.haryana.gov.in/>

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is informed to the General Public and all Private Nursing Institutes [ANM, GNM, B.Sc. (Nursing), P.B.B.Sc. (Nursing), M.Sc. (Nursing) & NPCC] running in the State of Haryana that it is required/mandatory to submit the Bank Guarantee/FDR as per the applicable policy. All Private Nursing Institutes (Schools/Colleges), which have not submitted the Bank Guarantee/FDR and not deposited the penalty of Rs. 5 lakh are hereby, informed to submit Bank Guarantee/FDR in the Directorate of Medical Education & Research, Haryana and deposit penalty of Rs. 5 lakh in State under Head-0210-02-800-51-51 under DDO code 1163-Medical Education and Research, Haryana within (15) days of the publication of this Public Notice failing which the delinquent and defaulting institutes will be debarred from participating in counseling for admission for all courses of Nursing for the academic session (2026-27 onwards).

Director
Medical Education & Research
Haryana, Panchkula
No. 46606/HR/Y

OFFICE OF THE PRINCIPAL OF GOVT. COLLEGE FOR WOMEN, MANPUR (PALWAL)

TENDER NOTICE

For :- Tender Notice for Housekeeping, Cleanliness and Security Premises for whole campus.

Seales tender is hereby invited on contract basis (For Housekeeping Cleanliness and Security Premises) in Govt. College for Girls, Manpur from interested and eligible Cooperative L&C Societies/agencies (approved by Govt. of Haryana) having at least 3 year's experience in similar service prescribed form. Interested service agencies can collect tender form, from the office of Principal Govt. College for Girls, Manpur, on any working day between 10:00 AM to 3:00 PM by paying 500/- (Payable through demand draft of any nationalized bank drawn in favor Principal, Govt. College for Girls, Manpur) cash payment. All terms and conditions will be available on college website www.gcwmanpur.ac.in

1.	Date of Pre Bid meeting :-	11.07.2026 (11:00 AM at GC Hathin)
2.	Last date of receipt to sealed tender document :-	13.07.2026
3.	Date of Opening Technical Bid of Tender :-	14.07.2026
4.	Date of Opening Financial Bid of Tender :-	15.07.2026

Sd/-
Dr. Ram Niwas Yadav
Principal

No. 46602/HR/Y

**HARYANA REAL ESTATE REGULATORY AUTHORITY**
New Mini Secretariat, 2nd Floor, Sector-1, Panchkula.
E-mail: hreapkl-hry@gov.in, officer.rera.hry@gmail.com
Website: www.haryanarera.gov.in

PUBLIC NOTICE

It is hereby brought to the notice of the general public, homebuyers, investors, and all concerned persons that Aerens Jai Realty is presently developing a residential plotted colony on land measuring 53.9 acres in Sector-22 & 24, Yamunanagar. However, the said colony is being developed without a RERA Registration. As per Section 3 of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016, no promoter shall advertise, market, book, sell, or offer for sale any plot, apartment, or building in a real estate project without obtaining registration from the Real Estate Regulatory Authority.

Therefore, the general public is hereby cautioned:

- Not to book, purchase, invest in, or make any payment for any plot or unit in the project being developed on land measuring 53.9 acres in Sector-22 & 24, Yamunanagar by Aerens Jai Realty.
- Any transaction made in violation of the above provisions shall be at the sole risk, cost, and consequences of the purchaser and the Authority shall not be responsible for any loss or dispute arising therefrom.

This public notice is issued in the interest of the general public to prevent fraudulent or illegal real estate transactions and to ensure compliance with the provisions of the Real Estate (Regulation and Development) Act, 2016. For verification of registered projects, the general public is advised to visit the official website of Haryana Real Estate Regulatory Authority (HRERA) Panchkula

Secretary (Acting), HRERA Panchkula
No. 46608/HR/Y

IRRIGATION AND WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT, UTTAR PRADESH
FORM-18 [Sub-rule (2) of rule 20]
Declatration by Appropriate Government/Collector [Under Sub-section (1) of section 11 of the Act]
NOTIFICATION
May 21, 2026

No. 653/VIII/S.A.L.O/Sambhal--Under Sub-Section (1) Of Section 11 Of The Right To Fair compensation and transparency in rehabilitation resettlement Act, 2013, Whereas the Government of Uttar Pradesh/Collector (for the purpose of Appropriate Government) is satisfied that a total of 0.1408 Hectares of land is required in the Village-Paryawali Samhal, Tehsil-Sambal, District-Sambal is required for public purpose, namely, project, MADHYA GANGA CANAL PHASE 2 through IRRIGATION AND WATER RESOURCES DEPARTMENT, UTTAR PRADESH, THROUGH EXECUTIVE ENGINEER MADHYA GANGA CANAL CONSTRUCTION DIVISION-2, HARIDWAR (name of requirement body).

2- Social Impact assessment study was carried out by the State Impact Assessment Agency and submits its recommendations to the Appropriate Government which has approved its recommendation on dated.....

3- The summary of the social Impact Assessment report as follow

SOCIAL IMPACT ASSESSMENT IS NOT APPLICABLE.

4- A total of ZERO families are likely to be displaced due to the land acquisition. The reason necessitating such displacement is as under:

Deputy Collector/Assistant Collectoris appointed as Administrator for the purpose of rehabilitation and resettlement of the project affected families.

5- Therefore, the Governor is pleased to notify for general information that the land mentioned in the Schedule below is needed for public purpose-

SCHEDULE

District	Tehsil	Pargana	Village	Plot No.	Arca to be Acquired
					Hectares
	1	2	3	4	5
					6
	Sambal	Sambal	Sambal	Paryawali	631
	"	"	"	"	627
					0.0960
					0.0448
				Total...	0.1408

6- The Governor is also pleased to authorize the Collector for the purpose of land acquisition to take necessary steps to entre upon and survey of land, take levels of any land, dig or sub soil into the sub-oil and do all the Acts required for the proper execution of work as provided and specified under section 12 of the Act.

7- Under section 15 of the Act any person interested in the land may within 60 (days after the publication of this notification, make an objection to the acquisition of land in the locality in writing to the Collector.

8- Under section 11(4) of the Act, no person shall make any transaction or cause any transaction of land i.e. sale/purchase, specified in the preliminary notification or create any encumbrances on such land from the date of publication of such notification till such time as the proceedings of land acquisition is completed, without prior approval of the Collector.

NOTE: A plan of land may be inspected in the Office of the Collector for the purpose of acquisition.

Sd/-Illigible Collector, Sambhal.

UPID-253027 Dt. 25.06.2026 www.upidadv.gov.in

Office of Superintending Engineer Rampur Circle, P.W.D. Rampur
E-Procurement Notice Inviting Tenders (In anticipation of sanction)

Ref.No. 3314/E-Nivida-RampurCir./26-27 Dated :- 05-06-2026

1. On behalf of the Governor of UP, tenders for following work on Percentage rates invited by the Superintending Engineer, Rampur Circle, PWD Rampur online at website <http://etender.up.nic.in> from registered contractors (Category as per below table) from date 01.07.2026 at 10:00 am to 09.07.2026 at 12.00 pm. Technical bid /Prequalification of tenders shall be opened on 09.07.2026 at 12.30 pm in office of undersigned by tender committee in presence of authorised representatives/bidders who wish to be present. Financial bid of the tenders' who qualify in technical bid shall be opened on date and time as specified by a notice in the office of undersigned. In case of Government holiday the required process shall be carried out on next working day.

2. Details of the works are following:

S. No.	DIST RICT	Name of Work	Estimated Cost Excl. GST (Rs.in Lakh)	Bid Security (Rs.in Lakh) only by Net banking	Cost of Bid Document (only by Net banking accepted)	Time of Completion (including rainy season)	Category of road (Road Category)	Address of contractor/Engineer eligible to execute the work	Address of Superintending Engineer	Address of Chief Engineer
1	Rampur	Construction of a helipad at Village Karimganj at Km. 61 of the Bhamora-Shahbad-Bilari State Highway-125) in Shahbad Tehsil, Rampur District, in the financial year 2026-27.	84.00	6.20	2354.00	6 Months	A & B	Construction Division, W.D. Rampur	Rampur Circle P.W.D. Rampur	Meerabad Zone P.W.D. Meerabad
2	Rampur	Construction of a helipad at Village Rathonda at km 7 of the Dhamaura-Rathonda-Chinchali Road, in Tehsil Milak Rampur District, in the financial year 2026-27.	55.00	4.75	2354.00	6 Months	A B & C			

- All work including 02 years maintenance period after completion of work.
- The Rates adopted in the BOQ are including all other taxes but excluding GST.
- The Bid Security and tender cost should be deposited online through Net Banking.
- Additional Security will be payable (as per rule at the time of Agreement) according to G.O. No 86/2026/649/2026/23-7099/106/2025 लोक निर्माण अनुभाग-7 दिनांक 23-05-2026

All terms & conditions can be seen on website <http://etender.up.nic.in> The bidder have to login on Prahari URL <http://wms.upwd.gov.in/Prahari> to upload required documents as per Government order 14/2020/879/लेखन-7-2020-176 (सा०)/०६ लोक निर्माण अनुभाग-7 दिनांक 25.08.2020, Government order 879(1) / लेखन-7-2020-176 (सा०)/०६ लोक निर्माण अनुभाग-7 दिनांक 25.08.2020&E.N.C./H.O.D.'s upwd letter No.417 / 133000 ६० खं०/ 20 दिनांक 28.08.2020

(Er. Gaurav Singh)
Executive Engineer
Cons.Div.PWD, Rampur
Email- cdrampur@gmail.com

UPID-252958
Date 24.06.2026
www.upidadv.nic.in

(Er. Sanjay Jayant)
Superintending Engineer Rampur Circle, PWD, Rampur
Email- pwdrampur@gmail.com

**राज्य पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता मिशन**, (एस. डब्ल्यू.एस.एम.), उ०प्र०
नमामि गंगे तथा ग्रामीण जलापूर्ति विभाग, उत्तर प्रदेश शासन

पत्रांक: 1142 /W-314(ID)/DEPU.SELECTION-III/2023 दिनांक: 23 जुन, 2026

प्रदेश के ग्रामीण क्षेत्रों में पाइप पेयजल योजनाओं के माध्यम से शुद्ध पेयजल आपूर्ति सुनिश्चित करायें जाने के उद्देश्य से "जल जीवन मिशन" का क्रियान्वयन नमामि गंगे तथा ग्रामीण जलापूर्ति विभाग द्वारा किया जा रहा है। विभाग के अधीन नमामि गंगे तथा ग्रामीण जलापूर्ति निदेशालय तथा जनपद स्तर पर एक ढाँचा के गठन हेतु राज्य एवं जनपद स्तरीय पद सृजित किये गये हैं। उक्त के क्रम में निम्नलिखित पदों पर राज्य सरकार / भारत सरकार के अधीन सरकारी /अर्द्धसरकारी विभागों/उपक्रम में कार्यरत प्रतिनियुक्ति /सेवा स्थानान्तरण/पद स्थापन हेतु अर्द्ध अधिकारियों/ कर्मचारियों से आवेदन आमंत्रित किये जाते हैं-

क्र.सं.	पद का नाम	पदों की संख्या	वेतनमान	चयनक
1.	बिदा एवं लेखाधिकारी	01	सेल-09 (वेतन-5400)	समान वेतनमान में कार्यरत बिदा एवं लेखाधिकारी।
2.	सहायक लेखाधिकारी	05	सेल-8 (वेतन-4800)	समान वेतनमान में कार्यरत सहायक लेखाधिकारी।
3.	लेखाकार	03	सेल-6 (वेतन-4200)	समान वेतनमान में कार्यरत लेखाकार।
4.	सहायक लेखाकार	04	सेल-5 (वेतन-3800)	समान वेतनमान में कार्यरत सहायक लेखाकार।
5.	दीर्घा सम्येक	02	सेल-4 (वेतन-4200)	समान वेतनमान में कार्यरत दीर्घा सम्येक।
6.	प्रत्येक लेखा	01	सेल-3 (वेतन-4200)	प्रत्येक लेखनमान में एक कम कीर्त लेखनमान योजनाकारी राजकीय विभाग में कम से कम 07 वर्ष सहायक लेखाकार के पद पर कार्य करने का अनुभव।
7.	अधीनस्थ अधिवक्ता	02	सेल-12 (वेतन-7800)	सहायक लेखनमान में कार्यरत अनुभवी विधिक इंजीनियर।
8.	अधीनस्थ अधिवक्ता	05	सेल-11 (वेतन-6800)	सहायक लेखनमान में कार्यरत अनुभवी विधिक इंजीनियर।

उपरोक्त पदों के सम्बन्ध में आवेदन पत्र मिशन की वेबसाइट www.swsmp.up.gov.in पर अपलोड करके हुए अपलोड किये गये आवेदन पत्र की संलग्नक सहित एक प्रति (हार्डकॉपी) कार्यालय के पते पर अन्तिम तिथि तक उपलब्ध कराया जाना आवश्यक है। आवेदन पत्र का प्रारूप मिशन की वेबसाइट www.swsmp.up.gov.in पर उपलब्ध है।

आवेदन पत्र विभाग के नियन्त्रक अधिकारी से अग्रसारित कराते हुए अपलोड किया जाना अनिवार्य है। आवेदन पत्र प्राप्त करने की अन्तिम तिथि 15.07.2026 की सायं 5:00 बजे तक है। निर्धारित समय के उपरान्त प्राप्त आवेदन पत्रों पर विचार नहीं किया जायेगा।

- कार्यालय का पता एवं दूरभाष नं०- राज्य पेयजल एवं स्वच्छता मिशन, किसान बाजार, विभूति खण्ड, गोमती नगर, लखनऊ-226010 दूरभाष: (0522) 2239426
- कार्यालय का ई-मेल: ed.swsmpup@rediffmail.com
- आवेदन हेतु वेबसाइट: www.swsmp.up.gov.in

आर.ओ. संख्या-253018, दिनांक- 25/06/2026
www.upidadv.gov.in

अधिशासी निदेशक

कार्यालय प्रधानाचार्य, एस०एन० मेडिकल कॉलेज, आगरा।
पत्र संख्या-एस०पी०एस०/2026-27/3936 दिनांक- 22.06.2026

ई-निविदा सूचना

सरोजिनी नायडू मेडिकल कालेज, आगरा में वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के अन्तर्गत प्रतिष्ठित / अनुभवी एवं मान्यता प्राप्त फर्मों से एस०एन० मेडिकल कालेज आगरा में दवाओं की आपूर्ति हेतु निविदायें ई-टेंडर प्रणाली हेतु अधिकृत वेबसाइट <http://etender.up.nic.in> के माध्यम से आमंत्रित की जाती हैं।

निविदा में अंकित बयाने की धनराशि की एफ०डी०आर० जो किसी शिड्यूल कॉमर्शियल बैंक की बनी हो अथवा पोस्ट ऑफिस की एन.एस.सी. (डी०डी०, बैंकर चैक, पे आर्डर मान्य नहीं) जो प्रधानाचार्य, सरोजिनी नायडू मेडिकल कालेज, आगरा के पक्ष में बन्धक हो, निविदा के साथ स्कैन कापी अपलोड करें। बयाने की धनराशि की एफ०डी०आर० / एन०एस०सी० तथा टेंडर फीस का डिमाण्ड ड्राफ्ट मूल रूप में टैक्नीकल बिड खुलने की तिथि से पूर्व कार्यालय प्रधानाचार्य, एस०एन० मेडिकल कॉलेज, आगरा में पंजीकृत डाक से जमा कराना अनिवार्य है। डाक विलम्ब के लिए निविदा दाता स्वयं जिम्मेदार होंगे। निविदा की तिथियों का विवरण निम्न प्रकार है।

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A passport that doesn’t count, a narrowing idea of citizenship



FAIZAN MUSTAFA

CITIZENSHIP IS a vertical relationship between the individual and the state. Originally, citizenship used to signify a belief in certain liberal and republican ideas and did not have much to do with territory and status. Today, it is all about territory, status, and exclusion rather than inclusion. The Foreigners’ Tribunals in Assam reportedly denied citizenship to people despite some possessing as many as 15 documents. The judiciary, too, has become quite restrictive in this regard.

In Shabbir Hussain’s (1951) case — a trader who got stuck in Lahore during Partition and returned to India only on a temporary permit but was subsequently arrested for overstaying in India — the apex court refused to treat him as a Pakistani national. Similarly, in *Abdul Khader* (1960), the Supreme Court refused to treat Khader as a foreigner despite his having a Pakistani passport. But in *Izhar Ahmad Khan* (1962), the Court treated possession of a Pakistani passport as conclusive proof of Pakistani citizenship. By 2008, the Court had become even more restrictive when, in *Razia Begum*, it held that even possession of an Indian passport was not sufficient proof of citizenship.

B R Ambedkar said that the citizenship provisions of the Constitution had given the Constitution’s Drafting Committee “a headache”. Yet, the citizenship topic was considered so settled that no constitutional law syllabus included it with prominence. After the Citizenship Amendment Act, 2019 (CAA), citizenship became the most important subject not only for law students but for the masses. Though the government enacted the CAA with great alacrity, it took five years to notify its rules. The Special Intense Revision (SIR) in Bihar in 2025 and other states in 2026 has once again brought the citizenship debate to the centre stage.

The SC, in its Bihar SIR judgment, held that the passport is “conclusive proof” of citizenship. The latest clarification by the Min-



ILLUSTRATION: C R SASIKUMAR

istry of External Affairs (MEA) has explicitly said it is nothing more than a travel document. Strictly in terms of law and judgments, the MEA is correct. But since the government does not issue any citizenship card or certificate, how should one prove their citizenship? Why hasn’t a single resident of Assam among the 3.11 crore people whose citizenship was proved during the NRC exercise been issued a citizenship card? Is the latest clarification a precursor to such a document? If yes, not only will people have to queue up like during demonetisation, but just like the Assam NRC, an overwhelming number of Indians won’t be able to prove their citizenship. In Assam, a majority of the 19 lakh excluded people were Hindus.

Article 5, on the commencement of the Constitution, conferred citizenship on everyone born in India. Article 11 empowers Parliament to regulate citizenship by law, and thus the Citizenship Act was passed in 1955. It has been amended six times, but major amendments were made in 1986, 2003, and 2019. Parliament, over the decades, has narrowed the universal principles of citizenship incorporated in Article 5. Unlike the original Act, which gave citizenship on the principle of *jus soli* or by birth, the 1986 amendment was less

Since passports and voter ID cards can be issued only to citizens, why is there no presumption of citizenship? Is this not an official act?

inclusive as it added the condition that, in addition to one’s own birth in India, one can get citizenship only if either parent was an Indian citizen at the time of birth. In 2003, an amendment under the Vajpayee government added that either both parents should be Indian citizens or one must be an Indian citizen and the other should not be an illegal migrant. With these restrictive amendments, India has almost moved towards the narrow principle of *jus sanguinis* — blood relationships become more important than birth on Indian soil.

Based on these provisions, how is Indian citizenship to be proved? Section 2(1)(e) of the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam, 2023, says evidence can be either oral or documentary. “Proved” under Section 2(1)(j) means that after considering the matters before it, the court believes such a fact to exist or a prudent man would act upon the supposition that it exists. The crucial point is that “proved” is a subjective state of mind of the judge. “Disproved” under Section 2(1)(c) means a belief that it does not exist. The third concept is “conclusive proof”, which under Section 2(1)(b) means that if a fact is declared by the evidence law as conclusive proof of another, on the proof of that fact, the court shall not allow

evidence to disprove it. Since today, a passport, Aadhaar, or voter ID card is not taken as “conclusive” proof of citizenship, evidence can certainly be given to disprove someone’s citizenship status.

But evidence law also provides for certain “presumptions of fact” and “presumptions of law”. Section 2(1)(h) lays down that whenever this law provides the court may presume a fact, it may regard it as proved unless it is disproved. Section 2(1)(l) says that when the evidence law directs that the court shall presume a fact, it shall regard it as proved unless and until it is disproved. Thus, in cases of rape where sexual intercourse by the accused is proved, Section 120 provides for the presumption that it was without consent.

Since passports and voter ID cards can be issued only to citizens, why is there no presumption of citizenship? Is this not an official act? Many of us have experienced police verification prior to the issuance of passports. Passport, voter ID, etc., require governmental satisfaction about citizenship. Section 78 of the Sakshya Adhiniyam says the court shall presume every document to be genuine if it is declared by law as evidence of any particular fact and is certified by any government officer. Section 104 says the one who asserts a fact bears the burden of proof. Shouldn’t anyone who questions someone’s citizenship despite a passport or voter ID bear the burden of proving such an assertion?

During the SIR, the EC insisted on certain documents and arbitrarily excluded Aadhaar and its own voter ID card, which the Supreme Court did not find problematic. But none of the documents included was a proof of citizenship. Under the law of estoppel, the government cannot deny citizenship to those to whom it had issued a passport or voter ID card, unless the same were obtained fraudulently. This author’s own first passport explicitly certified him as a citizen. Why has this seal of citizenship been dropped? The proof of citizenship should be demanded only from those who are caught while crossing over to India, or a foreigner found in India with a passport of another country, or those born abroad. For anyone born in India, there must be a presumption of citizenship, and voter ID and a passport must be taken as conclusive proof of citizenship.

The writer is vice-chancellor, Chanakya National Law University, Patna. Views are personal

A long-overdue correction on conversion

jasthan (2025) and Maharashtra (2026).

Several Christian groups insist that the “right to propagate” includes “right to proselytise”. However, in *Rev. Stainislaus vs State of Madhya Pradesh* (1977), the SC stated that while Article 25 of the Constitution gives freedom to choose one’s religion, it does not give the right to convert other persons. The government’s move is in line with that verdict.

Before Independence, reformers and leaders like Ram Mohan Roy, Vivekananda and Gandhi raised serious questions over conversions. In an interview in March 1931, when a journalist asked whether he would favour the retention of foreign missionaries in India after Independence, Gandhi’s reply was, “If instead of confining themselves purely to humanitarian work and material service to the poor, they do proselytising by means of medical aid, education, I would certainly ask them to withdraw”. In another interview in Harijan on May 11, 1935, he stated, “If I had power and could legislate, I should certainly stop all proselytising. It is the cause of much avoidable conflict”.

Jawaharlal Nehru, however, reassured missionaries in 1946. “Christians form the third-largest group in the country, and it is absurd for anyone to imagine that their religious or other rights can be suppressed,” he said. In the Constituent Assembly, issues like “propaganda” or “propagation” and “conversions” were debated. Congress

had earlier promised freedom to “profess and practise” religion in its election manifesto. But the missionaries demanded the “right to propagate” that included the right to convert. Members like KM Munshi, Alladi Krishnaswami Aiyer and C Rajagopalachari took a contrarian view on the right to conversion. Sardar Patel and Maulana Azad insisted that missionaries must abjure mass conversions. But most such suggestions could not muster a majority support in the Assembly. Finally, Article 19, which included the phrase “to propagate religion,” became the law.

Questions continued to be raised over missionary work. The Niyogi Committee, appointed by the Madhya Pradesh Government in 1954 to look into the activities of the missionaries in the state’s tribal areas, came out with a stinging report against missionaries. Its recommendations included: The missionaries whose primary object is proselytisation should be asked to withdraw, and the influx of foreign missionaries should be checked. The Constitution should be amended in order to rule out propagation by foreigners and conversions by illicit means, and legislative measures should be enacted for controlling conversion by illegal means.

The Nehru government rubbished the committee’s claims. Seven decades later, the Modi government is taking steps to implement those recommendations.

The writer, president, India Foundation, is with the BJP

‘Anyway, it’s a girl’ — 45 years later, it still rankles

of the Girl Child. However, my wife and I see every day as a blessing, for we have two lovely daughters and a chirpy granddaughter in our midst. The start to our happiness was slightly odd, though.

It was 1981, and we were excited as our first child was about to be born. I was ready with a handheld bulky “two-in-one” (a transistor plus cassette recorder) outside the operating theatre (OT) of a Jammu hospital as the child was being delivered by C-section. Why the two-in-one? Well, it was just a would-be father’s fad that the first cry of the child should be recorded for listening later in life as my wife and I aged.

We were waiting with sweets outside the OT as a nurse exited and hurried away. A second one did the same. We were worried now.

Then, out came the gynaecologist and said, “Anyway, congratulations — it’s a girl.” We were overjoyed. The “anyway”, however, rankles to this day, 45 years later. No hospital staff asked for sweets, as is the custom. We had to literally force them to accept it.

Our second girl came from a Gauhati hospital. And as my wife drifted in and out of anaesthesia after C-section, she asked for the child. But nobody would tell her anything — “*sab theek hai*”, was the only response. Fi-

Social mores have changed over the past decades, but have attitudes toward a girl child changed for the better?

nally, she yelled and was shown the baby girl. No one asked for sweets here, either. What a welcome for a girl child.

Social mores have changed, but have attitudes toward a girl child changed for the better? The joint family has given way to a nuclear one. The “*hum do hamare do*” drive — whose logo was a sketch of a set of parents holding hands of a boy and a girl — spearheaded the family planning drive in the last century but is invisible now. The admirable “*beti bachao beti padhao*” drive started in 2015 seems to have faded. Modern technology has benefitted the medical field immensely, with the average lifespan in India increasing from 32 years in 1947 to 72 in 2022. However, the same technology has been used for female foeticide — the re-

cent arrest in Pune of some doctors and a Class XII dropout moving around with a portable sonography probe attached to an app for sex determination tests makes for frightful reading.

Another October 11 will soon come, as will platitudes spewed by politicians extolling the girl child as a goddess incarnate. But the ground reality is what counts. The sex ratio at birth, as per the SRS data, is slightly better in urban areas than in rural belts, indicating that education may well be key to protecting the female child. Leaders of religion, thought, politics, and social standing must redouble their efforts to ensure that the Viksit Bharat drive stays a balanced one.

The writer is a retired air vice marshal

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Science, not ideology

KUDOS TO your editorial (‘In West Bengal, keep egg on the menu’, *IE*, June 26). You have rightly defended the inclusion of eggs in the mid-day meal scheme, one of India’s most successful flagship welfare programmes. Public nutrition programmes should be guided by science, health and the best interests of children, not by ideological or sectarian considerations. The preparation and distribution of mid-day meals should remain the responsibility of government-run community kitchens or authorised public agencies rather than private or religious organisations.

Nawal Thorat, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar

THE NEW budget increases funds for mid-day meals, but removing eggs from school plates in Kolkata raises serious concerns. In a state where 98 per cent of people eat non-vegetarian food, this decision feels less about nutrition and more about imposing a particular belief (‘In West Bengal, keep egg on the menu’, *IE*, June 26). Food choices in India carry deep social meaning, and such moves risk breaking trust, especially after assurances that Bengal’s culinary traditions would be respected. Nutrition should be guided by science and practicality, not ideology.

K Chidanand Kumar, Bengaluru

Manufactured history

IT IS the duty of those in charge of education to give schoolchildren an all-round perspective on history. Unfortunately, the recent “rationalisation” exercises seem to indicate the opposite (‘NCERT’s new Social Science textbook for Class 9 has SIR, more details on Emergency’, *IE*, June 26). We have a burning example in our western neighbourhood of what depths intellectual discourse plumbs once a whole generation is taught selectively pruned or manufactured history. NCERT and the government would do well to prepare more balanced history lessons.

Rahul Gaur, Gurugram



RAM RAJYA

BY RAM MADHAV

THE UNION Home Ministry promulgated new Foreign Contribution (Regulation) Act (FCRA) rules earlier this week, which seek to restrict the activities of NGOs that receive foreign funding. The rules say that the foreign contributions can be used for the construction or maintenance of religious places, printing and digitisation of sacred scriptures, building facilities for pilgrims, running community kitchens and promoting indigenous and tribal faith practices. However, they ban proselytisation activity using foreign money.

Even before the amendments were formally gazetted, they created ripples not only across India but even in the US. The proposed amendments to the FCRA became an electoral issue during the recent assembly elections in Kerala and Tamil Nadu. The ripples reached Capitol Hill in Washington, DC too. James Risch, who heads the Senate Foreign Relations Committee, threatened that the US “will not hesitate to call out countries who violate the internationally recognised human rights of Christians”.

After Independence, states like Orissa (1967), Madhya Pradesh (1968), and Arunachal Pradesh (1978) introduced anti-conversion laws. They were followed by Chhattisgarh (2000), Gujarat (2003), Himachal Pradesh (2006), Jharkhand (2017), Uttarakhand (2018), Uttar Pradesh (2021), Haryana (2022), Ra-

In ‘Rev. Stainislaus vs State of Madhya Pradesh’ (1977), the SC stated that while Article 25 gives freedom to choose one’s religion, it does not give the right to convert other persons



MANMOHAN BHADUR

THE LATEST SRS 2024 (Sample Registration System) population data is a cause for worry for the national drive to protect the girl child. From 952 female births to 1,000 male deliveries in 1947, the ratio reduced to an abysmal low of 896 girls to 1,000 boys in 2015-17; now, the SRS shows an improvement to 918 girls to 1,000 boys in 2022-24. Good news, but still way below the ratio at Independence, which is also the World Health Organisation’s reported biologically expected level.

An annual ritual takes place on October 11, when the world commemorates the Day

LOHAGAD FORT MURDER: KETAN AGARWAL’S FATHER URGES FADNAVIS TO FAST-TRACK CASE TRIAL

CM appoints Nikam as special prosecutor

Siya and Chetan deleted chats before and after Ketan’s death: Cops

Express News Service
Mumbai, June 26

MAHARASHTRA CHIEF Minister Devendra Fadnavis on Friday approved the appointment of senior lawyer Ujjwal Nikam as the special public prosecutor (SPP) in the Ketan Agarwal murder case and directed steps to set up a fast-track court for the trial.

The approval came after Ketan’s father, Vishal Agarwal, met the Chief Minister in Pune and submitted a request seeking Nikam’s appointment as SPP in the case. Following the meeting, Fadnavis issued written directions to the secretary of the state’s Law and Judiciary Department to appoint and examine the proposal for constituting a fast-track court, officials said.

Nikam, currently a Rajya Sabha MP, is a senior criminal lawyer known for handling high-profile cases, including the 26/11 Mumbai terror attacks. He had contested the 2024 Lok Sabha election on a BJP ticket but was unsuccessful.

Speaking to the media after the meeting, Vishal Agarwal said, “My young son has passed away. I think there should be a minimum punishment of hanging. I requested the Chief Minister. He has assured me that the case will be fast-tracked. An SIT has already been formed. I have full confidence in him.”

Asked whether he was aware of Ketan’s fiancée Siya Goyal’s alleged relationship with Chetan Chaudhary, Vishal Agarwal said he knew nothing about it.

Ketan (25) died on June 18 after falling from the western cliff of Lohagad Fort in Pune district. Initially, it was believed that Ketan accidentally slipped into the valley at Lohagad and died. But a police probe revealed



Maharashtra Chief Minister Devendra Fadnavis meets the family members of Ketan Agarwal on Friday. PTI

that his fiancée Siya and her alleged lover Chetan allegedly had pushed him from the fort.

Both accused, Siya and Chetan, were taken into custody on June 23 and have been remanded to police custody till June 29 by a local court. An FIR has been registered at the Lonavala Rural Police Station.

Deleted texts

A probe by the Pune rural police revealed that Siya (20) and Chetan (22) deleted chats between them before and after the death of Ketan on June 18.

A senior police officer confirmed that Siya and Chetan’s mobile phones were being sent to the forensic lab to retrieve their chats. Police had seized their cellphones during investigation, following their arrest.

The police on Friday questioned Siya’s brother Sahil Goyal for nearly 10 hours, an official said. He was later allowed to go home.

The officer said Sahil was quizzed about his sister’s relationship with co-accused Chetan. “We had summoned him for questioning in the morning. He was allowed to go late in the evening,” said an officer from Lonavala rural police station.

“Sahil knows Chetan, and we cross-checked certain things with him. He was questioned

for nearly 10 hours,” he said.

According to the police, Siya and Chetan had been in constant contact for nearly six months before the incident, logging an extraordinary 2,004 phone calls totalling 238 hours of conversation.

On the day of the crime, the duo allegedly met at a cafe to finalise the murder plot, mapping out the precise spot at Lohagad Fort where Ketan would be pushed, said the police.

DSP for the Lonavala division Gajanan Tonpe said investigators have firmly established active roles of both accused.

Earlier in the day, police said Chetan had provoked Siya to eliminate Ketan. Chetan initially claimed that he was present at the fort but did not go to the spot where Ketan was pushed off the cliff, and did not know exactly what happened, an officer said. “However, it was evident that he was lying,” he said, adding that both of them finally admitted to their roles and narrated the entire sequence of events.

Ketan and Siya got engaged in February and were to have a destination wedding in Udaipur, Rajasthan, later this year. But Siya was allegedly in a relationship with Chetan since October 2025. The duo together conspired to kill Ketan, said police.

WITH PTI INPUTS

A ‘cheerful girl’, a ‘well-liked’ boy, a ‘sportsman’ and a murder plot

Dipanith Nath, Shubham Kurale, Soham Shah
Pune, June 26

AS THE ongoing probe into the alleged murder of realtor Ketan Agarwal reveals new details, police claim it was co-accused Chetan Chaudhary who instigated Agarwal’s fiancée Siya Goyal to eliminate him.

Siya Goyal

Coming from an affluent family, Siya, 20, is a commerce student at a well-known Pune college. Her family, which lives in a bungalow called Lila Kunj in Bibewadi in Pune, is in the dry fruits business.

Bibewadi is known as a highly sought-after residential and commercial neighbourhood in southern Pune, located about an hour’s drive from the Lodha Belmondo apartment in Gahunje, where Ketan lived. Those who know Siya describe her as “cheerful”, interested in fashion and, recently, active with her own baking business.

Ketan’s mother Rakhi Agarwal said: “Siya was well-behaved, like any regular girl. She was always smiling. She had come home several times – for a puja, for dinner, for a birthday. We went shopping and for meals.”

The families were distantly related. Searching for answers for the murder, Rakhi says they had put “only two conditions” to Siya before the wedding — “we do not allow drinking in our house”, and “I would not let her attend parties”.

Their engagement, on Valentine’s Day this year, had been a grand affair, held in a Pune hotel. The wedding was planned at a palace in Udaipur, Rajasthan, with two aircraft chartered for the guests.

Photos and videos of the couple have gone viral after Ketan’s death. A social media post

by Siya after the incident has also surfaced. “You left me on my birthday,” she posted. “You left when we were so close to getting married. I still can’t understand why you did this to me. I had dreams, questions I’ll never get answers to.”

Siya has a brother, two years younger to her. Siya’s father Praveen Goyal was admitted to hospital on Thursday. In first comments to the media, her parents said Ketan was “more of a son” to them than their own. “We want justice for Ketan... for the accused to pay the same way,” Praveen said. Asked if they would feel the same even if that meant Siya, he said: “Yes, even Siya.”

Chetan Choudhary

The 22-year-old reportedly met Siya around eight-nine months ago, at a party. Neighbours at the much modest Shree Parshwa Nagar Society, where the Chaudhary family has lived for many years, say they are shocked at the allegations against Chetan. “I have known the family for several years. Chetan was well-known here, mainly for his active participation in sports,” said a neighbour. “He never showed any violent streak, and everyone had only good things to say about his behaviour,” the neighbour said.

Chetan’s uncle Udayram said it was hard to believe the allegations against the 22-year-old. Reiterating that he was a sports person, he said the Choudhary home is full of trophies won by Chetan, “over 150”.

Chetan’s lawyer Ram Shahan said he is “pursuing BBA”.

Those who know Chetan say he would either be seen playing cricket in the compound, or helping his father Babul Chaudhary with the family’s business. The Chaudharys run a dry fruits business, along with that in spices, named Dhanaashri Masala, at Market Yard,

near where the Goyals stay.

Chetan’s family said he “has been falsely implicated by Siya”. “Chetan told us he was standing a few feet away from Siya and Ketan (when the latter was allegedly killed),” Babul said.

He also claimed that Chetan was being threatened in police custody. Shahane underlined that his client is “Accused No.2”. Police’s reference to over 2,000 calls between Chetan and Siya lacked any chronological context or supporting evidence, Shahane said. “No evidence has been placed before court so far.”

Ketan Agarwal

Neighbours of the 26-year-old remember him as a friendly and well-liked young man.

Lodha Belmondo in Gahunje, where Ketan lived with his family, is described on housing sites as “Pune’s most-premium riverside township”.

Lalita Singh, who lives in another tower in the society, said: “The Agarwal family has good relations with everyone. Ketan was kind and cheerful.”

Having completed higher studies in Massachusetts, US, Ketan, returned to India a couple of years ago and, after interning at Mahindra Logistic, joined the family’s construction firm ‘Success Group’ as Chief Marketing Officer and Director.

Multiple members of Ketan’s family hold leadership roles in the company, with father Vishal Agarwal the CEO and grandfather Devchand Agarwal the Chairman. Other family members in the business include Kuldeep Agarwal (Chief Operating Officer), Vijay Agarwal (Chief Financial Officer), Mayur Agarwal (Head Project Manager), and Harsh Agarwal (Director). Ketan’s father Vishal is also the Director or Designated Director of many firms, according to the Ministry of Corporate Affairs data.

• BRIEFLY



Chief of Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi and Ladakh Lieutenant Governor V K Saxena at Lok Niwas, Leh, on Friday. ANI

LADAKH

Army chief calls on Ladakh L-G, discusses civil-military cooperation

CHIEF OF Army Staff General Upendra Dwivedi on Friday called on Ladakh L-G Vinai Kumar Saxena and discussed strengthening civil-military cooperation, as well as advancing collective efforts for peace, stability and development in the UT. Sharing details of the meeting, held at Lok Niwas in Leh, on X, the L-G said, “Chief of Army Staff, General Upendra Dwivedi, called on today at Lok Niwas, Leh. We discussed strengthening civil-military cooperation, fostering closer coordination between administration and armed forces, re-employment of Agniveers in the UT administration and advancing collective efforts for peace, stability and development in the region.” PTI

Shimla: 6 killed as pickup vehicle falls into gorge

SIX PERSONS were killed after the pickup vehicle they were travelling in fell into a gorge near Urman in Himachal Pradesh’s Shimla Friday, police said. The milk van was on its way from Rampur to Takleh when it occurred. The deceased included Asha Kumari and her son Yugal from Kullu district’s Anni; their ages were unknown. The other deceased were Abhishek Sani (23), Layak Ram (56), Nitin (23), and the driver Ashok Jain (23) — all hailing from Rampur villages. Police said a case has been filed in the matter and an investigation has begun. PTI

Gujarat: Man arrested for killing lion cub

A 50-YEAR-OLD man was arrested for Gujarat’s Porbandar Friday for allegedly killing a male lion cub whose carcass was found recently, forest department officials said. The man, Baa-van Chavda, is a resident of Rabari Ness, the region near Junagadh city from where the carcass of the cub aged 7-8 months was found on June 24. Deputy Conservator of Forests (Junagadh) Akshay Joshi said, “The accused possesses a cruel mindset... He has admitted to having killed the lion cub. He also admitted to have killed several dogs and snakes in the past.” ENS

‘Humiliating’: PMCH principal after transfer over absence during minister’s visit

Himanshu Harsh
Patna, June 26

TERMING THE Bihar Health Department’s decision to remove him from additional charge as principal of Patna Medical College and Hospital (PMCH) as “humiliating” and “authoritarian”, Dr Narendra Pratap Singh said on Friday that he was not asked for any explanation and that he had “no faith” in Health Minister Nishant Kumar.

“This action is humiliating. It has hurt my dignity. I think it is better to resign, retire and serve the public from home. Staying with such a government makes me feel disgusted,” Singh said. He was removed from the post and transferred to Bettiah on Thursday, two days after he was found absent during Health Minister Kumar’s scheduled visit to PMCH. During the visit, the minister said repeated calls to the principal went unanswered and noted that no other officer had been assigned charge in his absence. Calling it a serious lapse, Nishant Kumar said action would be taken.

In a notification, the department said Singh had not applied for leave, informed the department, or handed over charge to any other officer before remaining unavailable. The order said that because of his absence, several important administrative issues requiring discussion with the principal could not be taken up. It said that Singh’s conduct reflected “gross negligence”, “dereliction of duty”, “misuse of government resources” and “unauthorised absence”. He was removed from additional charge as PMCH principal and posted as professor, Department of Psychiatry, Government Medical College, Bettiah, with immediate effect. Obstetrics and Gynaecology Department Professor Geeta Singh was given additional charge as PMCH principal.

[FROM PAGE 1 | FULL REPORTS ON WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM]

Union Minister gets Rs 99-lakh subsidy for his farm

large scale for profit — of select vegetables and flowers comes under Mission for Integrated Development of Horticulture (MIDH), which was launched in 2014-15 and is administered by the National Horticulture Board (NHB), an autonomous organisation under the administrative control of Choudhary’s Ministry.

The initiative offers a maximum subsidy of 50 per cent, capped at Rs 1 crore per family, of the project cost for farming capsicum, cucumber and tomato, and eight varieties of flowers, including rose, anthurium and orchids (*see adjacent story*).

Choudhary’s project for cucumber cultivation across 16,592 sq m is one of 467 approved by NHB in 2025 under the scheme titled “Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post-Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops”.

According to NHB’s official website, its activities are managed by a Board of Directors headed by the Union Agriculture Minister as ex-officio President,

with the Union MoS for Agriculture as ex-officio Vice-President.

While the Board’s official website lists its ex-officio Vice-President as “Hon’ble Minister of State for Agriculture & Farmers Welfare”, the emails provided are bagirath.choudhary@sansad.nic.in/ mosaf-woffice@gmail.com.

Other members include the Secretary, Department of Agriculture and Farmers’ Welfare; the Director General, Indian Council of Agricultural Research; and other officials and representatives of the horticulture industry.

On paper, the MoS has no direct role in approving projects for subsidy under the scheme. The final approval is granted by an NHB project approval committee that does not include the board’s president or vice-president (*see adjacent story*).

The Indian Express sent a questionnaire to Choudhary, detailing its findings and seeking his response on whether the subsidy constituted a case of conflict of interest. His office

confirmed receipt of the email, but Choudhary was unavailable for comment.

Official data shows that of the 467 projects, with a total cost of Rs 144 crore and covering an area of 677 acres, that were approved during the financial year 2025-26 under this scheme, there were 60 that received over Rs 50 lakh each as subsidy.

The Indian Express visited the project site at Choudhary’s farm in Peeh village of Rajasthan’s Deedwana-Kuchaman district. Apart from the subsidy amount, the signboard put up at the site — part of mandatory requirement under the scheme — shows the total cost of the project as “1,99,20,000” (Rs 1.99 crore).

It states that the promoter’s share was “49,80,000” (Rs 49.8 lakh) — and that the Minister took a loan of “1,49,40,000” (Rs 1.49 crore) from HDFC Bank for the project.

Records show that Choudhary, who is the BJP MP from Ajmer and has been MoS at the Agriculture Ministry since 2024, filed an application for

clearance to start work on the project under the NHB scheme on April 15, 2025. The project was granted in-principle approval under the scheme 14 days later, on April 29, 2025.

On March 11, 2026, records show, the project received final clearance from NHB. And, on March 30, “capital investment subsidy” of Rs 99.03 lakh was credited to Choudhary’s HDFC Bank loan account at Kishangarh in Rajasthan. The records reviewed by this newspaper on the transfer of subsidy do not mention the remaining Rs 57,000 from the amount of “99,60,000” shown on the signboard.

Records show that in Peeh, Choudhary owns 9.7 hectares of agricultural land under khata number 315 (khasra numbers 508, 509, 610, 611, 621) and 1.1332 hectares under khata number 991 (khasra numbers 2315/510).

Khasra is the number assigned to an agricultural plot or field, and acts as an identifier in land records. Khata is the record that provides details of all plots owned by an individual or

family within a village.

Choudhary’s last available declaration to the Prime Minister’s Office (PMO), as on March 31, 2025, recorded Rs 4.41 crore worth of immovable and movable assets. The list includes agricultural land at 11 locations, including Khata/Khasra numbers 315, 1053, 1053/1 and 1058 at Peeh, valued at Rs 5.85 lakh. There is no specific mention of the NHB project, which received initial approval under the scheme a month later. An aide at the Minister’s office said details of the project “will be disclosed to the government”.

It was not the first time Choudhary had applied for subsidy under the scheme. Records show he had submitted an application in September 2018, but that was rejected due to a delay in receiving the hard copy. That same year, his son Subhash Choudhary had applied for a mixed vegetable/ cucumber project in Peeh village, but the application was rejected because a “structure” used in the project was “not eligible under the scheme guidelines”.

Four steps, Rs 1 crore cap: How the subsidy is cleared

marketing boards, municipal corporations, agro-industries corporations, state agriculture universities and R&D organisations.

What are the key conditions to avail subsidy?

- The applicant must own, or hold, registered lease records for a minimum of 10 years on, at least 4,000 sq m (1,000 sq m in northeastern states).
- The subsidy is linked to the “term loan” taken for the project. A term loan is a one-time amount (no top-up) with a fixed repayment period.
- “The time limit for completion of the project would be a maximum of 18 months from the date of disbursement of first installment of the term loan,” the scheme’s guidelines state.
- The subsidy is deposited in the loan account within three months of completion of the project (Note: The minimum loan taken should be

more than the estimated subsidy being proposed).

How to obtain the subsidy?

STEP 1: Apply online through the NHB portal for “In-Principle Approval cum Letter of Comfort” for the project, with all necessary documents, including PAN and land records, detailed project report, site layout plan, final loan sanction letter along with detailed appraisal note from lending bank.

STEP 2: In-principle approval is followed by an on-site check by a Joint Inspection Team comprising NHB and bank representatives, state horticulture officials, and experts.

STEP 3: The final approval is granted by an NHB project approval committee that does not include the board’s president or vice-president.

STEP 4: Subsidy is deposited in the loan account of the applicant within three months of completion of the project.

Among scheme’s beneficiaries: wife, son and mother of senior IAS officer

project in which his wife is involved and that “my mother (Smt. Bindumati) and my son (Kumar Writwik) are not dependent on me”.

Records show the subsidies obtained by his family are all for projects in Jaipur district. Consider this:

- A project by Gangwar’s mother Bindumati for cucumber cultivation in Bhasingpura village, under Jorpura Jobner Tehsil, received Rs 46.03 lakh in subsidy to her bank account in January 2025. The project area and cost: 8,880 sq m; Rs 99.38 lakh. At the time, Gangwar was posted as Additional Secretary in the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest & Climate Change.

- A project by Gangwar’s son Kumar Writwik for cucumber cultivation in Dhani Boraj village under Jorpura Jobner Tehsil received Rs 46.49 lakh in subsidy in his bank account in March 2023. The area and project cost: 8,736 sq m; Rs 97.94 lakh. Gangwar was Additional Secretary in the Environment Ministry.
- A project listed in the name of Gangwar’s wife Dr Ranjita Singh “and Others”, for cultivating cucumbers at Dhani Boraj village under Phulera Tehsil, received a subsidy of Rs 24.36 lakh in her bank account in 2021-22. The project area and cost: 4,048 sq m; Rs 49.31 lakh. Gangwar was Agriculture Production Commissioner & Prin-

icipal Secretary in the Rajasthan government when the application process began in May 2020. Later, he served in the state as Principal Secretary, Industries/MSME/ Investment & NRIs, and OSD, Bhiwadi Integrated Development Authority, till December 2020.

In his declaration of immovable property for 2024-2025, filed on January 1, 2026 with DoPT, Gangwar declared agricultural land at Khasra No. 1203/544 & 1205/544 in Dhani Boraj village under the names of his wife, mother, son and daughter.

“A project of Rs.50 lacs for commercial horticulture on the said land by the owners (Ranjita Singh, Bindumati, Kumar



The signboard at the Gangwar family farm. HARIKISHAN SHARMA

Writwik, Chitrangda Singh) have been sanctioned by NHB under “Development of Commercial Horticulture through Production and Post Harvest Management of Horticulture Crops” scheme,” Gangwar

noted in his declaration.

“The project will be funded by Bank loan and subsidy from NHB (75% of the project cost) and owners’ contributions (25% of the project cost). The owners’ contribution is being

mobilized by the owners from their own savings. Other development works and associated infrastructure, such as, office-cum-residence water harvesting-system, boundary wall, etc. [Approx. cost is around Rs 40 lakhs], from their own savings,” the declaration stated.

All India Services (AIS) Conduct Rules, 1968, state that Class I & Class II officers are required to disclose all details of all immovable property owned, acquired or inherited or held on lease or mortgage, either in own name or in the name of any member of family or in the name of any other dependent.

Responding to an emailed query from *The Indian Express*, Gangwar said that “sec-

tion 2 (b) of AIS (Conduct) Rules, 1968 provides the definition of ‘Member of Family’ which states that the persons (including parents or Son/Daughter) wholly dependent on the Government Servant covers under the definition of Member of Family”.

“In this regard, it is hereby informed that my mother (Smt. Bindumati) and my son (Kumar Writwik) are not dependent on me. In my service records also, it is clearly mentioned that they are not dependent on me, as per AIS (Conduct) Rules, 1968, the information pertaining to them is not required to be filled in the Annual Property Return,” he said.

TEL AVIV, BEIRUT HAD BEEN DISCUSSING POTENTIAL ISRAELI WITHDRAWALS FROM SOUTHERN LEBANON

Israel, Lebanon sign framework peace deal after US-brokered talks

Talks aim to end fighting between Israel, Hezbollah

Reuters
Jerusalem, Beirut, Washington, June 26

ISRAEL AND Lebanon signed a framework agreement in Washington on Friday following several days of talks to secure an end to fighting between Israel and Iran-backed Hezbollah militants. Lebanese Ambassador Nada Moawad and her Israeli counterpart Yechiel Leiter signed the trilateral document with the US at the State Department in Washington.

“Today we’ve taken the first step in what will be a difficult journey, without a doubt, but an important and an essential and a necessary one,” US Secretary of State Marco Rubio said before the agreement was inked.

The conflict between Israel and Hezbollah broke out when the armed group fired at Israel on March 2, days after the US and Israel attacked Iran.

The Hezbollah attacks triggered Israeli air and ground attacks that have killed more than



US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, State Department Counselor Daniel Holler, Israeli Ambassador Yechiel Leiter and Lebanese Ambassador Nada Moawad sign a framework deal in Washington, on Friday. REUTERS

4,000 people in Lebanon and displaced more than a million.

The officials did not provide details of the framework deal and did not say how its terms would differ from those included in an April 16 ceasefire deal that preceded several rounds of US-brokered Israel-Lebanon talks.

“The trilateral framework we signed today is a first step on the road to restoring Lebanese sovereignty and territorial integrity,

securing a permanent and final cessation of hostilities, enabling our people to go back to their land, and allowing all Lebanese to live in peace, security, and prosperity,” Moawad said.

Leiter praised Moawad for negotiating like a “lioness.”

“In this performance-based trilateral framework agreement, Iran is out, Hezbollah is out, and the road to peace between Israel and Lebanon is in,” he said.

They did not take questions

from reporters.

Israel’s death toll from this round of hostilities with Hezbollah includes at least 32 soldiers and four Israeli civilians. Hezbollah does not release figures on its war dead. Reuters reported on May 4 that several thousand Hezbollah fighters had been killed in the war.

The talks in Washington have included discussions on a proposal for Israeli forces to hand some of the territory they

occupied in southern Lebanon to Lebanon’s military.

A State Department official told Reuters on Thursday that Israel had agreed to pull back from some of that territory, something Israeli and Lebanese officials denied.

Before the talks resumed this week, Israel and Hezbollah agreed to halt fire even as Israel kept troops in occupied southern Lebanon -- territory it describes as a “buffer zone” aimed at thwarting Hezbollah attacks on northern Israel.

Violence has persisted since the ceasefire, with Israel saying on Friday its troops had struck and killed what the military described as seven Hezbollah members who were operating near the territory it is occupying. Reuters could not confirm this.

Israeli forces dropped leaflets over the southern Lebanese town of Mansouri on Friday ordering residents to leave, Lebanese state media reported, the first such order issued since the latest ceasefire between Israel and Hezbollah took effect.

A senior Lebanese military official said Israel had recently added Mansouri to its occupation zone. The official said Lebanese farmers had continued to enter and leave the town, but had not been living there.



Rescue workers search through the rubble of a collapsed building for survivors on Friday, a day after two earthquakes struck Caracas, Venezuela. REUTERS

Foreign rescue teams arrive as Venezuela quake toll tops 920

Reuters
Caracas, La Guaira, Moron, June 26

DESPERATE VENEZUELANs and foreign rescuers raced to find survivors trapped under rubble on Friday after twin earthquakes flattened parts of Caracas and surrounding areas, as frustration mounted over a lack of heavy equipment and the death toll neared 1,000.

Foreign rescue teams and aid began arriving nearly two days after magnitude 7.2 and 7.5 tremors struck about 160 km west of Caracas.

The government estimated hundreds of people were still trapped and missing on top of 920 confirmed fatalities and 3,360 injuries. A website set up to take reports of people still unaccounted for had over 50,000 listed as of Friday afternoon.

The UN’s aid chief gave a similar tally. The US Geological Survey has predicted high potential for more than 10,000 deaths, which would place the quakes among the deadliest earthquakes in Latin America in the last century.

La Guaira, a coastal city just outside Caracas, was the worst affected, as at least 100 buildings, including high-rise apartments, crumbled to the ground.

The government of interim President Delcy Rodriguez, who took power after the

INTERNATIONAL AID MOBILISED

Rescuers, cash and other emergency aid are arriving in Venezuela after two powerful earthquakes shattered areas in and around Caracas, leaving thousands missing.

United Nations: 25 international teams, about 1,000 personnel mobilised to support government-led relief efforts.

United States: \$150 million aid, rescue teams, airlift, logistics support and military assistance for relief operations.

Mexico: Deploying 250 military rescuers, five dogs, aircraft, drone, rescue equipment and medical supplies.

Pope Leo XIV: Donated €100,000 (\$114,000) from the Vatican’s charity fund for quake relief.

France: Deploying urban search-and-rescue teams with medics, engineers and rescue dogs.

Red Cross: Dispatching 17 tonnes of humanitarian supplies, including hygiene kits, kitchen sets and mosquito nets.

Germany: Deploying a 48-member federal disaster relief team for rescue and recovery operations.

Colombia: Sending 60-plus rescuers, dog teams, 12 tonnes of equipment and firefighters

Spain: Sending 97 rescuers and firefighters; plans to establish a field hospital.

Italy: Dispatching an advance team; firefighters, defence ministry and air force mobilised for assistance. Reuters

United States captured her predecessor in January, has pledged a massive deployment of assistance. State television showed images of her making a visit on Thursday to La Guaira.

Yet help was overall patchy on Friday, with authorities like firefighters, police, civil protection and the military on the streets in some places but absent or minimally present in others.

Rodriguez, who said La Guaira state would be “militarized” to facilitate rescue work,

thanked the volunteer caravans and said the government had distributed 2,600 tons of food.

Foreign rescue teams began arriving late on Thursday, with a small contingent from the Dominican Republic the first to reach La Guaira.

The US said it was mobilizing \$150 million in aid and easing sanctions to facilitate earthquake relief. The US military dispatched two ships and said helicopters and aircraft would help search-and-rescue operations.

OpenAI limits new ChatGPT to Trump-approved customers

Associated Press
June 26

ChatGPT maker OpenAI said Friday it is restricting the release of its new artificial intelligence model at the request of President Donald Trump’s administration, the latest in an unprecedented government vetting of AI products that could pose cybersecurity risks.

OpenAI said its new AI product, called GPT-5.6 Sol, would only be available for now to a “small group of trusted

partners” approved by the Trump administration.

“We don’t believe this kind of government access process should become the long-term default,” OpenAI said in a statement. The company said it viewed the testing period as a temporary step on the “path to broader availability in the coming weeks.”

OpenAI’s staggered release of a powerful new AI system follows actions the government took earlier this month against OpenAI rival Anthropic, maker



OpenAI CEO Sam Altman. FILE

of the Claude chatbot.

Anthropic took offline two new AI models, known as Fable

5 and Mythos 5, just days after publicly releasing them to comply with a Trump directive blocking their use by foreign nationals.

The White House said on Friday that it continues to collaborate with the frontier AI labs on addressing the challenges of scaling the fast-growing technology.

Officials have grown increasingly concerned since Anthropic warned earlier this year that its Mythos model was adept at finding software flaws

in a way that could be weaponized by malicious hackers and threaten critical computer networks around the world.

Trump earlier in June signed an executive order on AI oversight that established a framework for the federal government to vet the national security risks of the most advanced AI systems for up to 30 days before their public release.

The order described participation by AI developers as voluntary but the framework has not yet been fully developed.

Australia pledges tougher laws to keep kids below 16 away from social media

Associated Press
Melbourne, June 26

THE AUSTRALIAN government plans to strengthen laws that ban children younger than 16 from social media platforms, Prime Minister Anthony Albanese said.

Observers said on Friday the government was responding to evidence that the ban on young children holding accounts on platforms including Facebook, Instagram and YouTube had failed since it came into force on Dec. 10 last year. Australia was the first country in the world to pass legislation keeping youth off social media, but others have since followed.

Albanese told Parliament on Thursday this government was considering options to strengthen the ban.

“We’re working on that as a priority because this is something that other generations didn’t have to deal with, which is why it’s complex,” Albanese



Prime Minister Anthony Albanese

told Parliament.

He told the Australian Broadcasting Corp. on Friday the government was asking “are the laws as strong as possible?” and did eSafety Commissioner Julie Inman Grant, Australia’s online safety watchdog, “have every power at her disposal?”

Britain announced last week plans to ban children under 16 from a range of platforms to protect them from harmful content and excessive screen time.

Twin storm warning triggers evacuations in southern Japan

Tokyo: Japan grappled with transport disruptions on Friday while bracing for more torrential rain and risks from two approaching tropical storms that spurred authorities to issue high-level landslide warnings and order the evacuation of 1 million people.

More than 200 flights were cancelled and dozens of train services suspended while many expressways were closed, the land ministry said, while carmaker Toyota briefly halted operations at a factory in the southern region of Kyushu.

Weather officials said a lingering seasonal rain front combined with warm, moist air from tropical storms Mekkhala and Higos brought downpours to wide swathes of Japan’s west, threatening landslides, floods and swollen rivers.

About 1 million people faced evacuation orders after some were lifted in Okinawa and other southern areas.

Ukraine unleashes its heaviest drone bombardments of Russia

Associated Press
Kyiv, June 26

UKRAINE LAUNCHED a major nighttime attack on a dozen Russian regions, Russian-held Crimea and the surrounding seas, Moscow’s Defence Ministry said on Friday, in what appeared to be one of Kyiv’s biggest drone assaults since the Kremlin’s full-scale invasion more than four years ago.

Russian air defences intercepted 660 Ukrainian drones, Russia’s Defence Ministry said. The previous biggest Ukrainian attack over the past year, as Ukraine has accelerated its drone development, involved 556 drones on May 17.

In an effort to turn the tables on Russia’s grinding war of attrition, Ukrainian long-range drones have been battering oil production and energy facilities behind the front line and deep inside Russia.

The campaign has choked Russian fuel supplies and military deliveries, stalling Moscow’s



A Ukrainian serviceman fires a CAESAR self-propelled howitzer toward Russian positions in the Dnipropetrovsk region. FILE

efforts on the battlefield, Western officials and analysts say, and has heaped pressure on Russian President Vladimir Putin.

Ukraine’s Security Service said it used drones to strike Russian navy ships and air defence radars in Kerch, an important port city in Crimea. The targets were two reconnaissance and minelaying ships, the Volga and the Vyatka, and the cargo-passenger ferry

Petrovavlovsk, the agency said, claiming that the strikes started a large fire.

The major attack came hours after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said on X that he had ordered “a 40-day influence operation,” believed to mean an escalation of attacks, aimed at “compelling (Russia) to end the war” after US peace efforts over the past year yielded no breakthrough.

A LOOSE COLLECTIVE OF CYBERCRIMINALS INITIALLY TOOK CREDIT FOR CRIPPLING JAGUAR LAND ROVER LAST YEAR; INVESTIGATORS NOW SEE RUSSIAN HANDS BEHIND THE RANSOMWARE ATTACK

The \$2.5 billion whodunit: A cyber attack that left a dent in Britain’s economy

Adam Goldman, Jane Bradley, Dustin Volz & Michael Schwirtz
June 26

LAST YEAR, hackers burrowed into the computer systems of Jaguar Land Rover, a crown jewel of British manufacturing. It was a devastating attack that forced Jaguar to lock down its computers and suspend production for five weeks. The hack even put a dent in the broader economy, making it the costliest cyberattack in nation’s history.

The hack was alarming, but also mysterious. There was never a demand for money, as is common in such intrusions. A loose collective of hackers that

included some in Britain took credit. Their claim led to news media speculation that they were the culprits.

They were not. A group of Russian hackers was responsible, according to five people familiar with an investigation into the hack. They spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the case.

Law enforcement and private-sector cyber-response specialists from Britain and the United States determined that the attack was different in methodology and motivation from the hacking collective, said four of the people.

Authorities are still sorting through the murky details trying

to determine whether the attackers were operating at the behest of the Kremlin, or with its tacit assent.

The hack in late August 2025, and its economic impact were widely covered. In October, The Telegraph newspaper reported that authorities were looking into whether Russia was involved. The conclusion by government and some private-sector investigators that the group was Russian has not been previously reported.

Hacking by Russian groups is hardly new. Still, the attack on Jaguar — and the potential involvement of the Russian state — raises the possibility that this was no typical ransom



Land Rovers being transported from the Jaguar Land Rover factory in Solihull, England. NYT

attack but an assault on the economic foundation of a sovereign state. It played into longstanding fears that an adversa-

rial state could remotely paralyze critical infrastructure, like an energy grid or key manufacturers, stoking chaos and caus-

ing economic damage.

The Jaguar infiltration had profound consequences. It slowed manufacturing in the third quarter of 2025, delivering an estimated \$2.5 billion hit to the British economy, and it cost the company about \$350 million in the 2026 fiscal year.

It also carried powerful symbolism. King Charles III and Queen Camilla use Jaguar vehicles, and the British military has relied on its iconic Land Rover fleet for decades.

New reporting by The New York Times uncovered other details of the investigation. Microsoft, for instance, had been tracking the Russian group and alerted Jaguar to who had

breached its systems, according to four of the people familiar with the case. The hackers had used novel ransomware with an encryption algorithm that some cybersecurity experts had not seen in previous attacks. One described it as “mind-blowing.”

Inside a hastily arranged war room during the episode, Jaguar huddled with cybersecurity investigators and private sector experts. Among those participating were Britain’s National Crime Agency and National CyberSecurity Centre, as well as Palo Alto Networks and Google’s Mandiant unit.

The FBI also assisted. They raced to contain the malware even as the hackers hurriedly

tried to erase their footprints.

The attack on Jaguar took place amid an increasingly hostile relationship between Russia and Britain, whose military assistance to Ukraine has angered the Kremlin. Britain has also mounted its own secret cyberintrusion and sabotage operations against Russia, according to former British and American intelligence officials.

A spokesperson for Britain’s National Crime Agency said that it knows that “some of the most high-profile cyberattacks against the UK are committed by criminals operating from within Russia, and that some of the groups responsible have links to the Russian state.” NYT

THE STATEMENT COMES AT A TIME WHEN US-INDIA TRADE DEAL TALKS ARE IN FINAL PHASE

Tariff rates may return to ‘exactly where they were’, signals Bessent

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 26

AS INDIAN negotiators have pressed for more clarity on Section 301 tariffs and the need for a competitive edge over other countries before signing a trade deal, US Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent has said that the tariffs will return to the previous levels with the use of Section 301 of the US Trade Act of 1974.

“We have rebooted the tariff program. Right now, we have something called Section 122 tariffs, which is a 10% global tariff. Currently, USTR Ambassador Jameson Greer is doing studies for Section 301s, and if those studies are successful, and I have no reason to believe they won’t be, but we don’t know until they are — then the tariff rates are going to go back to exactly where they were,” Bessent said in a TV interview.

The International Emergency Economic Powers Act (IEEPA) tariffs on India were set at 25% before it was brought down to 18% in February, just days before the US President

SEESAW GAME

THE INTERNATIONAL Emergency Economic Powers Act tariffs on India were set at 25% before it was brought down to 18% in February, just days before the US President Donald Trump’s powers under the IEEPA were declared illegal

WASHINGTON HAS already proposed 12.5% tariffs on India, which is expected to come into effect on July 7

THE RESULTS of another Section 301 investigation are also



expected before the end of next month.

Donald Trump’s powers under the IEEPA were declared illegal. Washington has already proposed 12.5% tariffs on India, which is expected to come into effect on July 7.

The results of another Section 301 are also expected before the end of next month.

“I would say the good thing about having used IEEPA in 2025... it allowed us very quickly to get to trade deals that

we never would have gotten to before. You know, the EU... the EU is going to pay us 15%, and they are going to charge us zero. So we have had a big rebalancing there. And they are bringing down their non-tariff trade barriers, many of their unfair financing practices. And it’s the same around the world, whether it’s Japan, Korea, our allies... whether it’s China,” he said. The Commerce and In-

dustrial Minister on Thursday said that the India-US trade deal was confirmed by both the countries on February 6 based on IEEPA tariffs, which gave India a competitive edge over competing countries such as Vietnam, Thailand, the Philippines, Indonesia, Malaysia and China and that India is looking for a similar advantage in the new US tariffs architecture.

Meanwhile, India has accelerated its attempts to strike more and more trade deals. The UK trade deal is set to come into effect next month, EU by the end of the year. The India-Oman deal also came into effect on June 1.

Indian negotiators are also in talks with the Russia-led Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU), Canada, Peru and Chile.

Notably, the United States Trade Representative (USTR) was due to visit Uzbekistan after India this week. While the India-US deal was not announced, the US and Uzbekistan agreed to an early harvest of trade commitments to strengthen the bilateral ties.

USTR had launched two

sets of broad Section 301 investigations based on forced labour and excess capacity. India, China, the European Union, Japan, Vietnam, Taiwan, Switzerland and South Korea feature in both the lists, and the US has already proposed the first set of tariffs.

However, countries like the UAE, the UK, Israel, Qatar, Saudi Arabia, as well as Pakistan only feature once and may face lower tariffs compared to other countries.

US proposed a lower rate of 10% on Pakistan, Canada, Ecuador, the European Union, Indonesia and Mexico, stating that they have demonstrated a commitment to addressing forced labour imports and have committed to imposing and enforcing a forced labour import prohibition through a formal Agreement on Reciprocal Trade (ART) with the United States. Separately, the US has launched a third investigation on Vietnam and a fresh case against Germany. China has also been facing Section 301 tariffs since Trump’s first administration.

Goldman Sachs hikes India’s FY27 growth forecast to 6.5%

ENS Economic Bureau
Mumbai, June 26

GLOBAL INVESTMENT and financial services firm Goldman Sachs has raised its calendar year 2026 real GDP growth forecast for India by 30 basis points to 6.8% and FY27 forecast by 40 bps to 6.5% in the wake of the fall in crude oil prices.

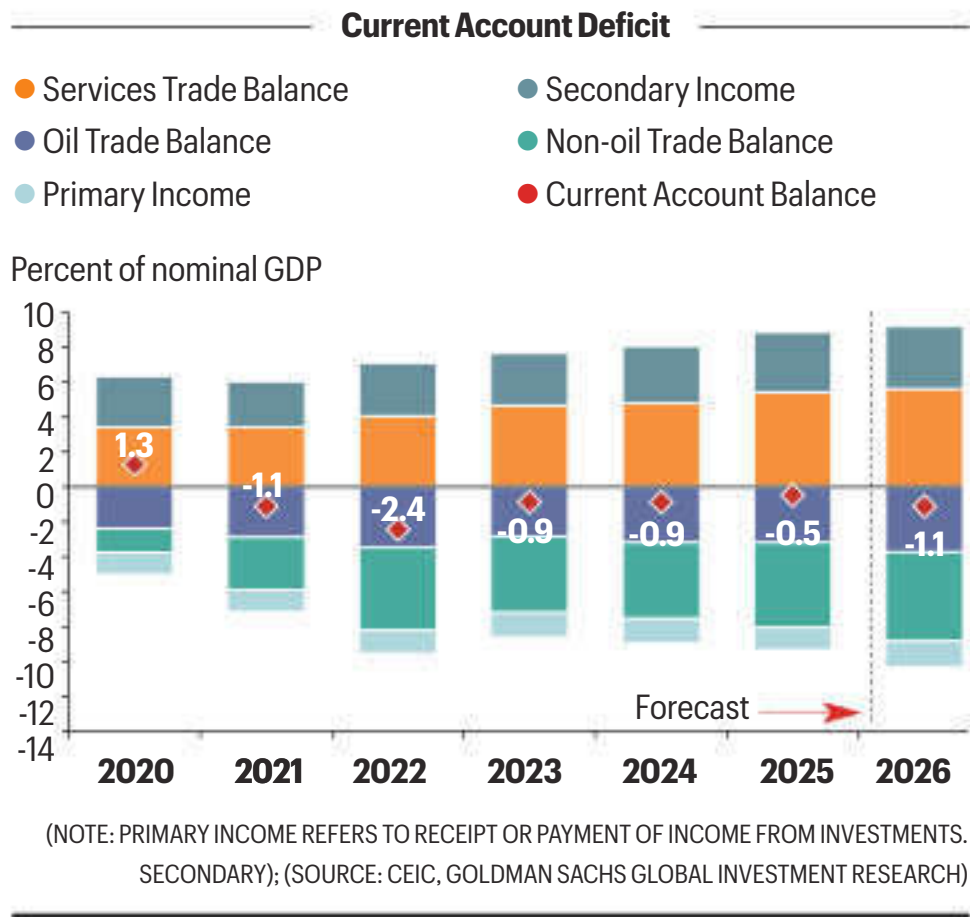
The recent US-Iran peace deal should improve India’s growth outlook — lower oil prices have taken out the risk of additional fuel pass-through to consumers, while easing supply constraints were already beginning to support a recovery in investment related indicators in May from their March-April troughs, the firm said in a report. On June 5, the RBI’s Monetary Policy Committee lowered the growth projection from 6.9% to 6.6% and hiked the inflation forecast from 4.6% to 5.1%. International benchmark Brent crude futures for August were 3.2% lower at \$72.83 a barrel on Friday.

“While the fuel price hikes already announced will continue to feed through into inflation over the coming months, the lower oil price path suggests that the risk of additional pass-through has diminished materially,” Goldman Sachs said.

The firm said lower crude oil prices have also been accompanied by a decline in petrochemical product prices.

“Although the earlier increases in polymer price are still likely to lift core goods inflation in the near term, we now expect the impact to be limited (vs. our earlier expectations), with a lower likelihood of incremental price increases across the core goods basket,” it said. Reflecting the lower oil price assumptions

OIL BOOST



and reduced manufactured goods inflation pressures, Goldman Sachs lowered its core goods inflation forecast for CY26 and FY27 by 30 basis points and 50 bps each to 3.2% and 4.1% respectively.

“Going forward, we expect consumption growth to moderate in Q2 and Q3 on earlier pump fuel price increases. We have also seen deterioration in the RBI’s urban and rural consumer confidence surveys (90.7 in May vs. 93.2 in April for the urban confidence index),” Goldman Sachs said.

However, the recent decline in oil prices reduces the likelihood of further fuel price increases, implying no further incremental drag on consumption growth from Q4, it said.

Further, the sharp correction in global urea prices is likely to limit the increase in the government’s fertilizer subsidy

bill relative to the earlier expectations. “Recent import tenders have cleared at substantially lower prices than those seen at the peak of the Middle East conflict, prompting the government to indicate that the FY27 fertilizer subsidy requirement could be reassessed. Together with lower oil prices, this should help alleviate near-term fiscal pressures,” it said.

Goldman Sachs said the Indian economy remained resilient through the West-Asia shock, as fiscal and quasi-fiscal measures absorbed much of the increase in energy costs and limited pass-through to consumers. As a result, consumption held up in March and April, even as investment somewhat softened amid supply disruptions and commercial LPG allocations remained around 70% of pre-conflict levels, it said.

Fitch, Moody’s and S&P have been unfair to India: Goyal

Ravi Dutta Mishra
New Delhi, June 26

COMMERCE AND Industry Minister Piyush Goyal on Friday said that global rating agencies such as Fitch, Moody’s and Standard & Poor have been unfair to India and that Mumbai-based rating agency CareEdge has done their job extremely objectively.

“So far, we only had Fitch, Moody’s and Standard & Poor, and I can say on record that they have been unfair to India. They have not recognised the India growth story, the strong India fundamentals, and the Indian capability and future, and captured it as much as a rating agency should have done. I will not cast any motives to it, but I do express surprise.

“I think what CareEdge has done is do their job extremely objectively. They have assessed much weaker economies than India, with absolutely no future, to whom other agencies have given better ratings than India, for reasons best known to them,” said Goyal at an industry event in the UK.

Goyal launched several reports during the industry event, including ‘Indian Roots British Soil’ by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), a UK India Business Council (UKIBC) manual on India-UK FTA, a report by CareEdge, India’s ratings agency, and a report by FICCI on the evolution of the bilateral partnership.

Moody’s has a Baa3 rating on India — the lowest investment grade rating. In April, the rating agency had lowered India’s GDP growth forecast to 6% from 6.8% for 2026-27.

At 6%, the agency’s growth forecast is lower than the RBI projection of 6.9%.

FULL REPORT ON
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Behind Asian markets’ tanking: Apple’s price hike, South Korea’s new tax proposal

Akash Mandal
Mumbai, June 26

ASIAN STOCK markets tanked as much as 6% on Friday as Apple’s move to jack up prices of some of its product lines by as much as 25% and the South Korean government’s proposal to tax unrealised gains on equities weighed on sentiment for AI and chip-related stocks.

South Korea’s Kospi index ended 5.8% lower on Friday, briefly triggering the 8% lower circuit midway into the session, leading to a halt in trading for the second time this week after having lost 10% on Tuesday. For the week, the index ended around 7% lower.

Japan’s Nikkei 225 index lost 4.2%, with major constituent Softbank tanking 12.5%.

Meanwhile, Taiwan’s Taiex index fell 3.6% on Friday. Both Japan’s and Taiwan’s stock markets are heavily dominated by chipmaking companies.

Samsung and SK Hynix make up over 50% weight on the Kospi, while TSMC constitutes around 40% weight on the Taiex.

American technology giant Apple’s announcement on Thursday particularly triggered panic across markets, with investors preferring to cut their exposures in AI and tech stocks. The Nasdaq Composite index in the US lost 0.5% overnight after the announcement. Shares of Apple fell by over 6%. Competitor Dell fell 5.5%. All other big tech stocks in the US also ended lower.

In Asia, shares of chipmaker SK Hynix plunged over 8% on Friday. TSMC and Samsung fell 2.5%. “Apple’s price hikes likely confirmed that the chip shortage is not likely to go away anytime soon. If a company like Apple with big balance sheets cannot absorb the high costs, the entire industry will be



Kospi index briefly triggered the 8% lower circuit midway into the session on Friday. REUTERS

forced to keep increasing prices. And that will eventually lead to lower margins and subdued volumes with some part of their customer bases being priced out of new products,” a head of research at a domestic research firm said.

Indian markets were closed on Friday on the occasion of Muharram.

Apple’s price hike

Apple raised prices across its iPad and MacBook offerings by as much as 25% on Thursday, citing surging chip costs due to the recent global AI surge. It also hiked prices across TVs and HomePods.

“We have never seen a component price increase this much, this quickly. We have shielded our customers from these increases so far, but we have now reached a point where we need to begin raising prices on a number of products, including today’s increases for iPad and Mac,” the company said in a statement.

This comes at a time when a host of companies across the world have been forced to raise prices due to shortages and sur-

ging prices of graphics and memory chips. The global chip market is dominated by a handful of names such as SK Hynix, Samsung, and Micron.

These players have focused on producing high-bandwidth memory (HBM) chips used for AI data centers due to higher margins, sharply cutting production capacities for other chips used in consumer devices such as phones, PCs, laptops, and other electronics.

This has led to a shortage in chips for consumer electronics, leading to exorbitant prices. Dubbed as the “RAM-ageddon” shortage, this has led to companies such as HP, Dell, and ASUS all announcing price hikes in recent times. Hours after Apple’s price hikes on Monday, gaming console maker Xbox also announced price hikes of up to 25% — their second such announcement within a year.

South Korea’s tax proposal

Many market participants believe that the South Korean market has also been weighed down by the government’s new proposal to tax unrealised gains. Introduced on Tuesday, the proposal seeks to treat unrealised gains from assets such as stocks and real estate as actual taxable income.

The South Korean market fell 10% on Tuesday in what was dubbed “Bloody Tuesday,” with the new proposal adding to concerns of the overstretched AI rally.

The government’s proposals would lead to significantly higher costs for investors, especially for foreign institutional investors, who have been heavily investing in the South Korean market.

FULL REPORT ON
WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Samsung readies \$648 bn bet as AI boom reshapes South Korea

Seoul: Samsung Group will pledge on Monday 1,000 trillion won (\$648 billion) in South Korea over the next decade, a media report said, in a sweeping effort to turn a global AI-driven chip boom into a nationwide growth engine.

Top executives from Samsung Electronics and SK Hynix — firms that have reaped huge profits as AI drives relentless demand for chips — will attend a meeting with President Lee Jae Myung and lay out investment plans targeting regions beyond Seoul, the *Macell Business Newspaper* said on Friday. Samsung’s investment will include spending on AI data centres, batteries and displays as well as a potential 300 trillion won push to build chip factories in the country’s southwest, it said without citing sources. The initiative underscores how South Korea is racing to convert surging AI-driven chip demand into a broader economic boost beyond Seoul, but infrastructure limits and labour shortages threaten to complicate efforts to redraw the country’s industrial map. The concentration of the chipmakers’ production facilities in areas around Seoul has long drawn political pressure, and has been amplified by Lee’s push for balanced regional development.

Opposition lawmakers say the plan is politically driven, accusing the government of pressuring companies to invest in the ruling party’s southwest stronghold. REUTERS

George Mathew
Mumbai, June 26

HDFC Bank on Friday said external law firms, which conducted a “thorough and objective review” of its former chairman Atanu Chakraborty’s statement about “certain practices and happenings” in the bank, reported that Chakraborty’s statement and its implications were “not substantiated”. Giving a “clean chit” to the bank, the law firms — Wilson Sonsini Goodrich & Rosati, PC and Wadia Ghandy & Co — said the contemporaneous evidence reviewed was inconsistent with Chakraborty’s statement, and law firms’ review did not identify any basis for the statement.

Interestingly, Chakraborty did not interact with the law firms which were appointed by the bank’s board.

“The contemporaneous evidence reviewed was inconsistent with Chakraborty’s statement, and external law firms’ review did not identify any basis for the statement,” the law firms said, according to a stock exchange filing by HDFC Bank.

On March 18, HDFC Bank part-time chairman and Independent Director Atanu Chakraborty resigned with immediate effect, saying that “certain happenings and practices within the bank are not in congruence with my personal

values and ethics”. Six days later, HDFC Bank announced that the board of directors appointed external law firms — domestic and international — to review the points highlighted by Chakraborty in his resignation letter.

The law firms said the legal review was conducted over a three-month period and involved the review of thousands of documents and interviews of the Independent Directors and several members of senior management.

“The bank and external law firms repeatedly requested that Chakraborty speak with them as part of the legal review, but ultimately the interview with Chakraborty did not occur,” the law firms said.

Having now completed an extensive legal review, law firms found that Chakraborty’s statement and its implications were not substantiated by the record and witness interviews, they said. “Specifically, the minutes of the meetings Chakraborty attended were a product of a comprehensive drafting, review and approval process that afforded Chakraborty an opportunity to record any ‘happenings and practices’ that purportedly were not in congruence with his personal values and ethics,” they said.

They said no contemporaneous support for Chakraborty’s statement was found in

the board or board committee minutes or materials reviewed, or in contemporaneous communications about the review and approval of the minutes of meetings he attended.

“Witness interviews did not support or substantiate the statement,” they said.

“Although Chakraborty referred to the Dubai matter in post-resignation public statements, no contemporaneous evidence was identified reflecting that he raised any concerns about his personal values and ethics, or that he disagreed with any decisions made by the board or relevant board committees, in connection with the Dubai matter (or any other matters that the Board and those Committees addressed),” the law firms said.

HDFC Bank said external law firms reviewed the minutes and agenda materials of meetings of the board and the relevant Committees during the reference time period.

“Further, the external law firms interacted individually with each of the independent directors including the chairpersons of the relevant committees, the managing director & CEO and other senior management personnel heading certain control and assurance functions of the bank,” the bank said.

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THE TURNAROUND COINCIDES WITH COMPANY’S EFFORTS TO REPAIR ITS BIGGEST WEAKNESS — AFTER-SALES SERVICE

EV boom gives fillip to Ola sales, but turnaround drive has just begun

Narayanan V
Chennai, June 26

Bhavish Aggarwal is no stranger to big ambitions. Over the past few years, the Ola Electric founder has repeatedly outlined aggressive targets on sales, profitability and market leadership, only for the company to revise timelines or fall short of its own guidance.

Ola Electric had guided for revenue of Rs 3,000- Rs 3,200 crore for FY26 but ended the year at Rs 2,253 crore. It had also projected sales of 325,000-375,000 electric scooters but sold less than 174,000 units.

For the first time, however, execution appears to be catch-

ing up with ambition. The Bengaluru-based electric scooter maker guided for 40,000-45,000 units in the June quarter. As per the latest Vahan data, Ola Electric has already retailed 40,540 scooters during the quarter so far, putting it on track to meet — or even exceed — its guidance.

The recovery, however, is not solely an Ola Electric story. It reflects a broader shift underway in India’s electric two-wheeler market.

Electric two-wheeler registrations surged 63% year-on-year to 170,733 units in May, according to the Federation of Automobile Dealers Associations (FADA), making it the



Aggarwal has admitted that mounting service backlogs had eroded customer confidence and weighed on sales. REUTERS

second-highest monthly retail volume on record. EV penetration in the two-wheeler market climbed to 9.3% from 6.1% a year ago, marking one of the sharpest

annual gains. According to FADA President CS Vigneshwar, rising fuel prices triggered by the West Asia conflict have made running costs a far bigger con-

sideration for consumers, accelerating the shift towards electric mobility. Dealers also reported a noticeable rise in enquiries for electric vehicles as buyers increasingly prioritised lower ownership costs. Ola Electric has been among the biggest beneficiaries of this demand revival. The turnaround also coincides with the company’s efforts to repair its biggest weakness — after-sales service.

During the company’s third-quarter earnings call, Aggarwal admitted that mounting service backlogs had eroded customer confidence and weighed on sales. “We do have a service challenge, which we are working through. That has impacted

brand trust and hence sales are down in the last couple of quarters,” he had said.

Since then, Ola Electric has rolled out its ‘Hyper Service’ initiative to improve customer experience. During the fourth-quarter earnings call, Aggarwal said service turnaround time had fallen 88%, same-day closures had risen to around 87%, parts pendency was down 69%, while warranty costs for the Gen 3 platform had fallen 70% compared with Gen 2.

The effects are visible in monthly sales. After plunging to a low of 3,968 units in February, Ola Electric’s monthly volumes steadily improved to 10,117 units in March. FE

BRIEFLY

Uber India chief Prabhjeet Singh steps down

New Delhi: Uber India and South Asia President Prabhjeet Singh has stepped down, after more than a decade at the company. Singh had joined Uber in August 2015, and was appointed president for India and South Asia in July 2020. Uber on Friday confirmed that Singh is moving on from the company for another leadership opportunity. The company has yet to announce a successor. India is one of Uber’s most important markets globally, a spokesperson said. PTI

Foxconn infuses \$37.2 million into its India arm

New Delhi: Electronics manufacturing giant Foxconn has infused \$37.2 million, or around Rs 351 crore, in its India arm Foxconn Hon Hai Technology India Mega Development Private Limited, said a regulatory filing. Foxconn has infused the fund through its Singapore-based subsidiary. With the latest transaction, Foxconn Singapore’s cumulative stake in the Chennai-based subsidiary has increased to 99.99% at a valuation of \$2.82 billion or about Rs 26,600 crore. PTI



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• HISTORY

Patrice Lumumba: DRC’s icon, now a World Cup highlight

Arav Shah
New Delhi, June 26

Among the new entrants making waves at the expanded FIFA World Cup are the Democratic Republic of Congo (DRC). Along with their performances on the pitch, a phenomenon in the stands has also drawn international attention: DRC superfan Michel Kuka Mboladinga, who resembles the country’s first democratically elected Prime Minister, Patrice Lumumba.

Mboladinga dresses as Lumumba in brightly coloured suits — red, yellow and blue, the DRC’s national colours — and stands motionless with one arm raised like a statue throughout the match. Mboladinga has stated that his stance represents national sovereignty and freedom: tenets that Lumumba advocated.

Anti-colonial leader

Patrice Emery Lumumba (1925–61) was DRC’s first PM. His ascent is deeply linked to a history of colonisation. Before achieving independence in 1960, Congo suffered brutal colonial exploitation by Belgium.

In February 1885, Belgian King Leopold II established the Congo Free State: what set it apart was the fact that it was a private dominion of King Leopold, effectively making it his personal fiefdom. Leopold justified his actions in the name of bringing civilisation and Christianity to Central Africa. Dismantling any form of governance, the Belgians ensured the Congolese were forced to labour for mining their resources and critical minerals.

Varying estimates agree that by the end of Leopold’s rule of the Congo in 1908, close to 10 million Congolese people had died of malnutrition, disease and calculated cullings. Although Congo was subsequently managed by the Belgian state until it achieved independence, it remained structurally segregated with no access to education, healthcare or positions of governance for its people.

Lumumba established himself as an advocate and co-founded the Mouvement National Congolais, promoting a unified Congo across its variety of ethnicities. After independence and nationwide elections in 1960, he became PM. Less than a year later, however, Lumumba was abducted along with two of his aides and assassinated by Belgium-backed individuals, who had commercial and strategic interests in the region. His remains were later exhumed and dissolved in acid, but not before a golden tooth was kept by one of the Belgians involved in his killing. Only in 2022, was it returned to Lumumba’s family and buried.

Vision of African unity

Despite having barely served a year, Lumumba’s vision of unity for the Congo survives as a ray of hope for the country — a sentiment that Mboladinga hopes to portray during games. His advocacy of African unity and liberation, and support for nationalist movements across the continent positioned him as a volatile figure for the West. Lumumba was adamant about achieving a sovereign state that opposed tribalism, seen as the biggest divider of the Congolese people.



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• GLOBAL

‘Genocidal intent’: The implications of a UN panel report for cases against Israel

Madhurita Goswami
New Delhi, June 26

IN A report released this week, a United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) commission of inquiry said that Israel has deliberately targeted Palestinian children in Gaza, documenting a pattern of acts to establish genocidal intent.

The commission called children “not just part of a population” but whose survival was “central to the existence and continuity” of the Palestinians. “The sheer number of cases investigated and documented by the commission showing a clear pattern that children were directly targeted by the Israeli security forces constitutes a key element in the Israeli authorities’ genocidal intent to destroy the Palestinian group in Gaza,” it said.

The commission

The report has been released by the UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory, including East Jerusalem and Israel. The commission was established in May

2021 through a UNHRC resolution as an independent body to follow up on the conditions in the occupied Palestinian territory. It is mandated to submit annual reports.

The commission is currently chaired by S Muralidhar of India, who retired in 2023 as the Chief Justice of the Odisha High Court. Other members are Florence Mumba of Zambia and Chris Sidoti of Australia.

Israel’s actions

The commission cited instances to describe what it called “the intentional killing of Palestinian children through airstrikes in populated areas”. As part of the inquiry, it interviewed medical practitioners who reported a consistent pattern of children with single gunshot wounds inflicted by quadcopters or snipers, and reviewed photos, videos, CT scans and X-rays provided by them.

The report highlighted that the October 2025 ceasefire between Israel and the Palestinian militant group Hamas did not stop the violence. There have been increasing killings of Palestinians, including children, near the “yellow line” — an Israel-declared



Mourners at the funeral of an Israeli airstrike victim in Gaza City. AP

security buffer zone that cuts north-to-south through the Gaza Strip. The line, originally established as part of the US-mediated October 2025 Gaza peace plan, marks the specific boundary to which the Israeli military withdrew while maintaining control over a

significant portion of the Strip.

The report also discussed the torture of children during arrests and detention, including “rape, threats of rape, sexual assault, violence to the genitals, forcible stripping and humiliating acts”. It also alleged that Israeli forces intentionally targeted schools and orphanages, forced the closure of paediatric hospitals, and destroyed infrastructure necessary for children’s survival.

The commission urged Israel to halt operations in Gaza, return the bodies of killed children and adjudicate incidents involving children in special courts, among other things. Israel has called the report a “libellous sham” and “defamatory”.

In September 2025, the commission, then chaired by Navi Pillay of South Africa and comprising Miloon Kothari of India and Chris Sidoti of Australia, had reached similar conclusions on genocidal intent.

Defining genocide

The UN Genocide Convention, under Article II, defines genocide as “any of the following acts committed with intent to de-

stroy, in whole or in part, a national, ethnic, racial or religious group, as such:

1. Killing members of the group;
2. Causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group;
3. Deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part;
4. Imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group;
5. Forcibly transferring children of the group to another group.”

While a UN commission does not have the power to impose legal penalties, its findings can be used by international courts as documentary evidence. Noah Weisbord, associate professor of law at McGill University in Montreal, Canada, told *The Indian Express* that the report adds to the growing body of evidence of “genocidal intent” in cases against Israel.

For instance, in South Africa’s genocide case against Israel before the International Court of Justice, the court has said that Palestinians in Gaza have plausible rights under the UN Genocide Convention that

require protection. Weisbord said this points to plausible violation, but the evidence required to prove genocide is held to a much higher standard.

“Ethnic cleansing, indiscriminate killing, or war crimes alone are not sufficient to establish it,” he said. According to him, testimony from commission members, along with photographic and documentary evidence and individual witness statements, would play the deciding role.

Raushan Tara Jaswal, assistant professor of law at O P Jindal Global University, said that it is hard to establish the mental element of genocidal intent. She told *The Indian Express* that unlike in the case of the Rohingya in Myanmar where an ethnicity was targeted, Palestinians do not squarely fit into such definitions of identity.

Weisbord said there was more hope for the one against Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu in the International Criminal Court “as more details emerge about the chain of command behind acts of genocide, identifying specific battalions and government leaders’ involvement”.

• POLICY

What a ‘right to walk’ can look like for India



EXPERT EXPLAINS
ARKAJA SINGH

FELLOW AT CENTRE FOR POLICY RESEARCH, NEW DELHI

LAST WEEK, the Supreme Court recognised walking on demarcated footpaths as a fundamental right and urged the government to introduce a law that declares this right. The two-judge bench’s ruling came in a case involving the death of a schoolboy in a road accident.

India has the dubious distinction of having the world’s highest number of road accident fatalities. The court identified this as the result of the exclusion of pedestrians in the way roads are built.

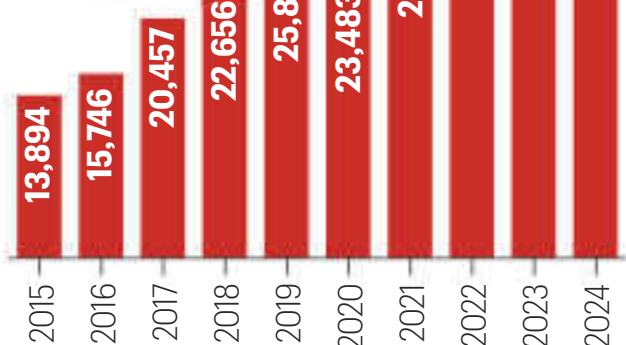
The issue of road safety is a type of “elite capture”, in which the use of public infrastructure by wealthier people is privileged over the needs of others. Pedestrians and cyclists (along with two-wheeler and public transport users) are more likely to be road accident victims than private car users. They are also likely to be poorer than private car users, and are forced to walk or cycle because they cannot afford any other option. These social divisions are exacerbated by the lack of safe roads. This absence worsens poorer peoples’ quality of life and prospects, constrains children’s access to school and playtime, and deprives adults of the health and well-being effects of walking in wealthier neighbourhoods.

It is in this context that the right to walk needs to be considered — not just as something to be expected as a part of how roads are built, but rather as a fundamental right guaranteed through the right to “move freely through the territory of India” and the “right to life” under Articles 19(1)(d) and 21 of the Constitution.

But what precisely is the legal import of the right to walk, and how can it have a real effect on the ground? By reading the right to walk into fundamental rights, the court has created a basis for its development. The case at hand had limited scope, but after settling the immediate legal issues, the court asked for it to be relisted as a writ petition. One can expect that the issue of walking will be considered in more specific terms in this subsequent iteration.

• SHRINKING SPACE

Pedestrian deaths in the country have more than doubled in 10 years.



SOURCE: MINISTRY OF ROAD TRANSPORT & HIGHWAYS

Here’s a look at some of the directions in which the right to walk can be developed, considering its social and cultural ramifications as well as implementation challenges.

Walking is cultural and social, not just about infrastructure

The Supreme Court has pointed out that “walking is not just motion” but embodies expressional, congregational and associational rights under Article 19(1)(a), Article 19(1)(b) and Article 19(1)(c).

To this, we can add the words of the iconic former mayor of Bogota, Enrique Peñalosa, who said: “Sidewalks are the relatives of parks and plazas, not of streets.” They are for conversations, socialising, doing business and children playing, as much as they are for individual autonomy and mobility.

The pedestrian “right of way” has to respond to the social and biophysical requirements of the human beings who use it. A pavement imagined as a sterile strip of infrastructure is not necessarily safe or comfortable for its users without shade-giving trees, places for rest, food and water, and “eyes on the street”. The last of these is a concept developed by the urban theorist Jane Jacobs, who observed that public spaces become safer when more people — residents, shopkeepers, pedestrians, cafe patrons — are around.

When viewed in isolation from its social setting, the right to walk could easily run into conflict with the livelihood rights of hawkers. This, however, is a self-defeating understanding of the ecosystem of walking, which includes cycling, walking, public transport, neighbourhood life and workday



Two-wheelers occupy a footpath on a Delhi bridge. PRAVEEN KHANNA/FILE

commutes. Moreover, to interpret a fundamental right in a way that denies the vulnerabilities and lived realities of people would defeat the purpose of the Constitution.

The right to walk should not come at the cost of making people poorer, or by closing off avenues of everyday commerce, rest and refreshment. Social interactions and the exchange of news and views are all part of the life of pavements.

The presence of vendors and shade-giving trees on the roadside might seem inconvenient from an engineering point of view, but they are necessary accompaniments of our street life. Ideally, they should coexist alongside the pedestrian right of way. This is not an impossible task if it is secured through administrative intervention at the street-level, by shifting vending spots a few paces here and there, working around the trees and planning spaces for rest and shade where they are not available.

Whose streets?

When viewed in isolation from its social setting, the right to walk could easily run into conflict with the livelihood rights of hawkers.

- But this right should not come at the cost of making people poorer, or by closing off avenues of everyday commerce, rest and refreshment.

The right to walk should not be limited to islands

Many of the social and cultural issues around walking are in fact taken into account in a clutch of recent design-led projects such as Chandni Chowk and Aurobindo Marg in Delhi, Church Street and Gandhi Bazaar in Bengaluru and CG Road in Ahmedabad. But while these interventions are well-intentioned, they tend to be small and intensive projects with limited geographical impact.

The Supreme Court’s intervention on this issue nudges us in a different direction, to think about how walking as a fundamental right can be made mainstream and local. For

this, it should be achievable within available budgets and resources. Perfect design-led solutions may have to be sacrificed for making conditions safer and more comfortable for pedestrians on every kind of street.

This is not to say that pedestrian life does not need aesthetic imagination, but that form should follow functionality. It is more critical that people get networks of circulation — from home to the bus, work, school, or the market — rather than small islands of perfectly constructed space. Interventions should prioritise the needs of vulnerable groups and focus on places where there are lots of walkers, such as in the areas around schools, bus stands and train stations, labour chowks and low-income neighbourhoods.

Institutional fragmentation around pedestrian rights

There is a legal and institutional vacuum around the issue of walkability. The Motor Vehicles Act, 1988 imposes duties on motorists vis-à-vis pedestrians, but it is primarily a law for motor vehicles and cannot secure the public rights of pedestrians.

There are, separately, a number of engineering designs and standards of road safety that should be applied in road construction projects, but these are not legally enforceable and fall short of a right for pedestrians.

To end this vacuum, the Supreme Court has sought a standalone framework for pedestrians in which municipalities, development authorities and panchayats are responsible for ensuring the right to walk. It has called for a regulatory structure through which the right can be implemented.

In many states, the current relationship of municipalities to pavements is fragmented into a cluster of different tasks — tree pruning, sweeping, drainage, regulating hawkers — without responsibility for overall outcome. Municipalities also deal with pavements side-by-side with other agencies: development authorities and public works departments construct many of the city roads, and electricity departments and water boards plant their infrastructure all over it (often blocking the way for walkers). The traffic police are responsible for policing the movement of cars, and municipalities run demarcated parking areas, but sometimes neither considers themselves accountable for cars parked on the pavement.

It would be impractical to unify these diverse functions into one administrative agency. It could, however, be the task of the municipality to integrate and pull together the various pieces of the puzzle to ensure a safe and comfortable right of way for walkers.

• DIPLOMACY

From 5 Indians to 5% of population: Diaspora key to Seychelles ties

Divya A
New Delhi, June 26

IT WAS in 1770 that five Indians landed in Seychelles as plantation workers, along with seven African slaves and 15 French colonists, recorded as the first inhabitants of the Islands located in the Indian Ocean. Today, persons of Indian origin comprise 5% of the island nation’s population.

As Prime Minister Narendra Modi heads to Seychelles on a three-day visit beginning Saturday, here is a look at the ties that bind the two countries located 4,000 km apart.

Migration and trade

It was from the 20th century that a constant flow of Indians, mostly from Tamil Nadu, Puducherry and later Gujarat, came to reside in Seychelles as traders, labourers and construction workers.

In fact, during the British colonial period, Seychelles was governed from the Bombay Presidency for some time, with regular shipping and flow of goods from

India. These trade links facilitated the migration of an Indian trading community looking for greener pastures, having reached a saturation point in East Africa.

The number of Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs) with Seychelles citizenship is estimated at around 6,000 presently, which is significant in a country with a population of about 120,000. A majority belong to the Gujarati and the Tamil communities.

Diplomatic relations

When Seychelles attained freedom on June 29, 1976, a contingent from the Indian Naval Ship, INS Nilgiri, took part in the Independence Day celebrations. This year, as PM Modi is attending the 50th Independence Day celebrations as the Guest of Honour, an Indian Armed Forces contingent and two Indian Navy ships are participating as well.

Diplomatic ties were established with Seychelles in 1976. Earlier this year, Modi also described Seychelles as a key part of India’s maritime policy — Vision MAHASAGAR (Mutual and Holistic Advancement for Se-

Global south strategy

- Seychelles is an important part of India’s Global South strategy, serving as a critical maritime partner in the Western Indian Ocean.
- The island nation also helps India combat sea-borne terrorism, piracy, and illegal fishing.
- Situated close to Africa, the Middle East, and Asia, Seychelles serves as a vital counterweight against China’s expanding influence in the Indian Ocean.

curity and Growth Across Regions).

Cultural ties

With a significant Indian diaspora, cultural contacts have been primarily community-driven. In June 2022, a statue of Mahatma Gandhi was erected at the Peace Park in Victoria, which also had statues of Nelson Mandela, the first President of South Africa and Sir James Mancham, the founding President of Seychelles.

Today, the Indian-origin community is visible in all walks of life, but mostly dominating the trading and construction sectors. There are also over 9,000 NRIs holding Gainful Employment Permits, working in the construction sector, as shop assistants and as professionals.

In 2015, the Pravasi Bharatiya Samman Award was conferred on Justice D Karunakaran of the Supreme Court of Seychelles, becoming the second recipient from the country after V Ramadoss (2006), an entrepreneur and medical advisor to the Seychelles President.

PM’s visit

PM Modi had earlier visited Seychelles in 2015, while the first Indian PM to visit Seychelles was Indira Gandhi in 1981. During his three-day visit, Modi will address the National Assembly of Seychelles and interact with members of the Indian community. Beyond cultural relations, India has emerged as one of Seychelles’ most trusted development partners through grants, concessional credit and capacity-building initiatives. More than 1% of Seychelles’ population has received professional training in India.

Over the years, New Delhi has extended significant Lines of Credit and grant assistance supporting infrastructure, healthcare, education and public transport.

This year, Modi also announced a Special Economic Package of \$175 million for Seychelles. India also continues to be a premier medical tourism destination for Seychelles, with institutional tie-ups connecting island hospitals with facilities in cities like Chennai.

Shalini Langer

IN THE DC Comics and Cinematic universe, Supergirl is a minor star – and pointedly still a ‘girl’ when cousin Clark Kent, not much older, has always been a ‘Super-man’.

Put that behind you. If not the stratosphere, Milly Alcock definitely hits escape velocity, breaking free of the gravity of Supergirl’s famous kin to seal her place in the firmament. The breakout *House of the Dragons* actor, who also got noticed for her comic skills in *Upright*, is a winsome combination of the two here as a superhero who, at least initially, would rather be drunk senseless than do the whole saviour routine.

Lately, with superheroes crowding the sky, it has helped to have a funny bone to tell one muscle from another. Alcock hits the right notes without trying too hard, and co-writer-director Craig Gillespie allows her to do that by keeping *Supergirl* unweighted by the burden of too many expectations even as she hops imaginatively from one planet to another.

It is during one pub crawl — this one between planets, differentiated into categories such as ‘Yellow Sun’, ‘Red Sun’, Yellow and Green Sun’ — that Supergirl/Kara runs into Ruthye (Eve Ridley, from *3 Body Problem*). In an effective scene, Ruthye’s parents and brother are killed by a brutal Krem (Matthias Schoenaerts), a brigand who goes about looting planets and collecting girls to be his all-male gang’s brides.

Jason Momoa does several brief but striking turns as a headhunter, rocking a beastly motorcycle, red eyes and a cigar whose size just about matches his. David Corenswet reprises his role as Superman in a cameo, mostly video-calling in awkwardly to check on his young cousin who has been gallivanting around the Milky Way.

Ruthye wants ‘revenge’ against Krem for killing her ‘innocent and honourable’ family; she talks about ‘righteousness’ and what is deserved. Ridley manages to tick off all these big totem poles without sounding fake.



Free Reign

SUPERGIRL

★★★★

Director: Craig Gillespie

CAST: Milly Alcock, Eve Ridley, Matthias Schoenaerts, Jason Momoa, David Krumholtz, David Corenswet

Kara is also chasing Krem as he has the antidote against the poison he has struck her adorable dog Krypto with. The girls, or the girl and the woman, hence team up. Several other women come by to help the story along, without the film wearing overtly its feminine message.

There are various encounters as Kara takes on the bad guys and steps between them and Ruthye. Both in space, when Supergirl is fighting ‘tech pirates’ or on the ground, when she is bashing brigands, Gil-

lespie manages to impress and enthrall, without losing sight of the people at the heart of the fights.

The flashbacks into how Kara came to leave Krypton, in a different arc from Superman’s, and how it has left them two different people, is also well told. She explains her cynicism to Ruthye thus: “He sees the good in everyone. I see the truth.”

Not as convincing is Kara’s apprehension that actually seeing her revenge against Krem through would do more

harm than good to Ruthye. Given all the bodies around and behind them — a blood streak across space and time — surely that ship has left the orbit. However, there is killing and there is slaying. In one scene when Ruthye has to tell off Krem, she seethes: “You fragile excuse of a man... You are more deplorable than the excrement at the bottom of your shoe.” Krem, the killer feared across his part of the universe, is bamboozled: “So many words...” When words can kill, who needs X-ray vision?



Revenge Served Cold and Flat

ANANTHAN KAADU

★

DIRECTOR: Jiyen Krishnakumar

CAST: Arya, Indrans, Sunil, Nikhila Vimal, Murali Gopy, Regena Cassandra

Anandu Suresh

LIKE MANY of Murali Gopy’s previous scripts, *Ananthan Kaadu* is packed with references to real-life scenarios and socio-political issues. However, this time, the hollowiness in his writing leaps off the page, largely due to director Jiyen Krishnakumar’s subservient adherence to the script, as if it were a holy text.

Vetrivel Kumaran (Arya) is an Eelam Tamil revolutionary who has led several uprisings. As one of the most wanted militants in Sri Lanka, Vetrivel flees to Kerala in the late 1980s to lay low for a while before striking back. In Thiruvananthapuram (also referred to as Ananthapuri), he is looked after by Krishnankutty (Indrans) and his men, including Thankaraj (Murali Gopy).

Once notorious criminals with about 40 cases to their names, Krishnankutty and his gang now lead a rather peaceful life, but aren’t ready to bow their heads before anyone. However, following IG Sampath Rao’s (Sunil) instructions, they agree to take up one last mission after learning it’s for chief minister KK Menon (Vijayaraghavan). This, however, changes the lives of Krishnankutty and his men, as well as Vetrivel, forever.

In a way, it can be said that *Ananthan Kaadu* deals with the same topic as director Rajeev Ravi’s magnum opus *Kammatipadam* (2016) — how the elite and the powerful create criminals for their agenda and eliminate them once their needs are met or when they start talking back. However, what *Ananthan Kaadu* lacks is a soul. The biggest shortcoming of the screenplay is its lack of genuineness. The film is not about the characters or even Ananthapuri; rather, it’s about the many topics it attempts to address.

Not that the script has addressed any of them adequately either. More than focusing on the characters or the overall growth of the story, Murali has concentrated on including as many references to real-life incidents and socio-political issues as possible, making them appear like footnotes rather than integral emotional components of the movie. His contempt for Leftist organisations is evident. Not only does he portray Leftists as those suppressing people’s religious beliefs, but also as traitors who go to great lengths for their own gain. It is interesting that Murali adhered to this rhetoric after the *L2: Empuraan* (2025) fiasco.

The film opens with poet Ulloor S Parameswara Iyer’s famous lines: “*Namukku naame panivathu naakam, narakavumathupole* (We ourselves build our own heaven and hell is also just like that).” This raises an interesting question: Did the makers choose to present these verses simply because one person found them profound, even though they did not fit the narrative? There’s little to praise in this film except Ranjith Kotheri’s production design that presents a bygone era with some authenticity.

Lost in the Woods

Shubhra Gupta

FINISHED READING the credit list? Phew.

All right, eyes here, as I tell you more. The intention, from the get go, is clear. Whistle up a massive cast, making the previous editions of the *Welcome* series seem positively sparse in comparison. Have it led by Akshay Kumar, currently riding his comedy wave. Concoct a plot line where anything goes. Get in a couple of leggy ladies, whose job is to swoon and be silly. And when all else fails, conjure up a CGI gorilla.

Not going to bother sharing any other details because there are none. As befits such films, the premise is thinner than a wafer. A richie rich guy wants to make a flop film to pour black money down the drain, leading this bunch into a jungle where reel villains turn out to be real, and mayhem ensues.

The trouble with going down the brain rot path is that it needs to be consistently rotting our brains at a fast pace. Remember David Dhawan, who worked at a time when there was no internet constantly telling us how to define pop culture, in his heyday? This *Welcome*, groaning under the presence of all the heavyweights, lumbers about, giving us time to think. Where are the zippy writers when you need them?

And that, straight up, is the problem. It just isn’t madcap enough. For that the writing needs to be smart and self-aware, and the only time it is, is when it is parodying big bad Bollywood. There are, haha, swipes at Akshay’s long streak of flops, before his return to broad comedy; producers working hard to cook the books have been an urban legend; there’s even a jibe at stars and their obsession about vanity vans, which has a meta touch: how many such vans would the sets of this movie have housed at one time?

Those who enjoy these things will note the mini reunions of the cast from many yesteryear hits, including the previous editions



WELCOME TO THE JUNGLE

★★

DIRECTOR: Ahmed Khan

CAST: Akshay Kumar, Suniel Shetty, Jackie Shroff, Jacqueline Fernandez, Disha Patani, Arshad Warsi, Raveena Tandon, Farida Jalal, Tusshar Kapoor, Paresh Rawal, Lara Dutta, Johnny Lever, Rajpal Yadav, Urvashi Rautela, Yashpal Sharma, Shreyas Talpade, Aftab Shivdasani, Mukesh Tiwari, Zakir Hussain, Sudesh Berry, Puneet Issar, Kiran Kumar, Krushna Abhishek, Kiku Sharda, Daler Mehndi, Vinu Dara Singh

of the *Welcome* series. Akshay, Suniel Shetty and Paresh Rawal from *Hera Pheri*, as well as many of those who made their names with *Mahabharat* and *Border*. A village square is very *Sholay*-like, as are the horse-riding baddies. Other references abound: Raveena Tandon’s character will remind you of Rakhee from *Karan Arjun* (two characters in this one are named thus), while doing a little nudge-wink moment with Akshay; Jackie Shroff’s kohl-eyed, flowy-locked baddie is nothing but a version of Akshay Khanna in *Dhurandhar*, which has turned into an urban legend already, given the times it is mentioned.

Alert viewers will also note that the film is nothing but desi take of the 2008 *Tropic Thunder*, in which Ben Stiller and co had sent up the rah-rah Vietnam movies Hollywood loved churning out, as well as the celebrity worship of its time: in that one, a fading Hollywood star was aiming for lost glory, and that’s what a Bollywood star is doing here.

But the jabs in Ahmed Khan’s film land softly: anything harder would be impossible in an industry full of fragile egos, even if it has no problems in making fun of disability, knowing people will laugh. And they did, in my show, with Farida Jalal’s old lady’s stammer becoming a nudge. Ugh. Stuffing a film with a large ensemble, with-

out giving them enough to work with, results even in fine actors like Arshad Warsi floundering. Also, a woman’s waist is not where you first train your camera in her introduction scene. Double ugh.

And given our times, a dose of patriotism even in brainless comedies seems to have become non-negotiable. A strong streak of let’s-save-India-from-the-mujahideens colours the anti-*Bajrangji Bhaijaan* second half: that little girl who has lost her voice finds it when she is safe in India, having left her terrorist-ridden border PoK village behind. An elderly man (Kiran Kumar) speaks in high-falutin’ Urdu that no one understands: why spare a language which is consistently being invisibilised? Not funny.

The film ends with plastering the screen with a single star from an unknown critic, haha, and an announcement of it having become a hit. Wishful thinking? Or brain-rot *zindabad*, because when nothing else around us is making sense, why should our brains have to do any work? But how much lower can your low-hanging fruit go? Daler Mehndi’s big scene involves a bullet and a bum. Slapping and spitting are still being used as tired comic devices. Sigh.

Me, I don’t have any problem with leaving my brain at the door. Just don’t bore me.

•STREAMING WATCHLIST



In the Hand of Dante

NETFLIX

WHEN AUTHOR Nick Tosches is drawn into a violent quest to confirm the origins of a manuscript believed to be Dante’s *The Divine Comedy*, time and space collide in parallel lives spanning 700 years. Soon, Nick is summoned by a mafia don for his expertise on the Italian writer. The movie weaves together the lives of Nick and Dante in their search for love, beauty, and the divine.



Avatar: Fire and Ash

JIOHOTSTAR

DIRECTOR AND co-writer James Cameron takes audiences back to Pandora in a new adventure with Marine turned Na’vi leader Jake Sully (Sam Worthington), Na’vi warrior Neytiri (Zoe Saldana), and the Sully family. The movie, the third installment in the *Avatar* film series and the sequel to *Avatar: The Way of Water*, won Best Visual Effects at the 98th Academy Awards and was nominated for Best Costume Design.



Perfect Family

SONYLIV

PANKAJ TRIPATHI’S debut series as a producer, *Perfect Family* is a refreshing family drama that explores the conflicts and the bonds that shape modern relationships. Blending humour and heart, this series offers an honest and relatable portrayal of family life. The series features Gulshan Devaiah, Neha Dhupia, Manoj Pahwa, Seema Pahwa, Girija Oak Godbole and Kaveri Seth in the cast.



The Sheep Detectives

PRIME VIDEO

DIRECTED BY Kyle Balda, the film follows a flock of sheep whose peaceful lives are disrupted when their beloved shepherd is found dead under mysterious circumstances. Convinced that his death was no accident, the sheep begin investigating the humans around them. The mystery comedy stars Hugh Jackman, Nicholas Galitzine, Emma Thompson, Nicholas Braun, Molly Gordon, and Hong Chau.

Chris & Martina: The Final Set

NETFLIX



IN THIS Rebecca Gitlitz’s documentary, tennis legends Chris Evert and Martina Navratilova talk about their parallel journeys to sports stardom while touching upon their rivalry and friendship, especially as the duo continue to support each other through their shared experience of cancer treatment. Both of them aimed to be the number one tennis player in the world. Evert’s all-American background contrasted with Navratilova’s upbringing in communist Czechoslovakia.

ALAKA SAHANI

Debunking Myths

Shubhra Gupta

SEASON 2 of this rural-com returns with its low stakes, lo-fi storytelling, in which the TVF mandate — keep it cosy, bro — stays comfortably uppermost.

No surprises then that our idealistic doctor stays the course, even as the clashes between the twain — the citified outsider and the set-in-their-ways villagers — continue. Also back in harness is his little unit of compounder, nurse and helpers, the colleague-turning-into-friendly-companion, the rival local quack, and the *gaonwalas* themselves, slowly if reluctantly understanding the value of a real *daaktar saab* who can actually save lives.

As is the case with everything TVF, the struggle is to create characters with quirk and credibility, and often the former does the heavy-lifting more than anything else. But given that the first season has set the scene, acquainting us with the residents and their emphasised accents in fictionalised Bhatkandi, this time around we wait for things to move forward.

So compounder Phutani (Anandeshwar Dwivedi) will come late because his wife has taken off to the *maikaa*, and he

GRAM CHIKITSALAY 2

★★★★

DIRECTOR: Lalitam Anand

CAST: Amol Parashar, Akansha Ranjan Kapoor, Vinay Pathak, Dinesh Lal Yadav, Akash Makhija, Kartikey Raj, Anandeshwar Dwivedi, Garima Vikrant Singh

needs to do things for himself. Those around him — wardboy Govind (Akash Makhija), cleaner Dhelu (Kartikey Raj) — nod in perfect understanding. It doesn’t matter if the inspection team to judge the efficacy of the PHC (primary health centre), can swoop in anytime: if Govind needs to submit to a *pakadua vivaah*, then everything else needs to come to a standstill.

The solid presence of Dr Gargi (Akansha Ranjan Kapoor) is a continuing asset to the show (five easily digestible episodes, about 30 minutes each), as she helps the straight-laced Dr Prabhat Sinha (Amol Parashar) loosen up, and understand the rhythms of rural households. It’s always a pleasure to watch the seasoned Vinay Pathak, as he busies himself trying to save his practice as well as sending a daughter off to medical college to earn an actual degree.



The new addition of the corrupt official (Dinesh Lal Yadav) sitting on a stack of essential medicine is a nod to the real difficulties that impede the smooth functioning of these centres, but writers Vaibhav Suman and Shreya Srivastava soften the edges by revealing his human face: anything more — class is fine, and sure, we’ll touch gently upon patriarchy and gender politics, but let’s stay far away from caste and religion — would go against the grain

of the show.

The scenes created to showcase characters shooting the breeze — a wheelchair has been dragged out in the open to create a makeshift chair, as a threesome gossip about the latest goings-on — build in nothing more than slack. The appearance of two characters from the *Panchayat* series seems more like a gimmick than anything else, hoping that its popularity will rub off here. The time has come for show-runners

to realise that this kind of time-fill is no longer necessary; if you have confidence in your material, the padding is superfluous.

What redeems *Gram Chikitsalay 2* is a couple of strong elements created around two women, whose individual troubles are used to debunk myths around epilepsy, and widowhood, both of which can be deeply isolating. It’s nice that they are woven in not merely as learning boards (*joota mat sung-hao, usse kuch nahin hota*) but telling plot-points: the woman with epilepsy is shown as intelligent, quick about her wits; the widow, raising her son on her own, confesses that she hasn’t fought against her being labelled a *daayan* because it kept the wolves at bay. But was showing her as unkempt and straggly-haired unnecessary? If you are advocating acceptance, then why this stereotypical look?

Amol Parashar has grown into his role, and while he shares the screen with everyone else, it is his Prabhat, refusing to give in and give up, which is the fulcrum. A last-mile complicated delivery gives the show the chance to end on a high: a genuinely tense-making sequence in which the team is shown working to save both mother and baby and succeeding, is worth a hearty cheer.

Overall, though, *Gram Chikitsalay* is developing into a nice comfort watch. I think I’m all ready for Season 3.

The Big Picture

SATURDAY, JUNE 27, 2026

HOW IMMIGRANTS ARE SHAPING THE WORLD CUP

The united colours of football

From France to England, Australia, Spain and the US, national football teams have immigrants at the centre of their game. SANDIP G on what it takes to form a winning team: a dream, a park and a country left behind

Kylian Mbappe

COUNTRY: France

ROOTS: Father from Cameroon, mother of Algerian descent. Grew up in Bondy near Paris

- Real Madrid striker is among the best contemporary footballers, alongside Lionel Messi and Erling Haaland
- 27-year-old took Les Bleus to doorstep of WC title in 2022

Lamine Yamal

COUNTRY: Spain

ROOTS: Mother from Equatorial Guinea, father from Morocco. Grew up in Barcelona

- Now 18, the Euro winner is Barcelona and Spain mainstay
- At 16 years, 57 days, he is the youngest to play and score for Spain

Marc Guehi

COUNTRY: England

ROOTS: Family moved from Ivory Coast to southeast London when he was a year old

- 25-year-old defender earned his stripes at Crystal Palace before heading to Manchester City
- Helped England win U17 World Cup in India in 2017

Folarin Balogun

COUNTRY: USA

ROOTS: Raised in UK by Nigerian-origin parents, but was born in New York where family was on vacation at the time

- Ex-Arsenal man is one of Europe's most promising forwards
- 24-year-old is only the second American player to score more than once in a World Cup game

Nico Williams

COUNTRY: Spain

ROOTS: Born to Ghanaian refugees who walked barefoot across the Sahara desert to get to Spain

- Was among architects of Spain's Euro 2024 triumph
- 23-year-old Athletic Bilbao winger renowned for pace, dribbling skills

THE MAKESHIFT tent on the edge of the playing field at Flushing Meadows Corona Park, a sprawling public park in New York's Queens borough, is blaring the Latino chartbuster *DTMF* by the Puerto Rican rapper Bad Bunny.

A few teenage players tap their feet to its tunes, their gaze fixed on a game of football in the middle. A volley from 20 yards clangs onto the crossbar, and coach Vincent Cordoba, a stern-looking elderly Colombian with small, sharp eyes, throws a water bottle to the ground in anger. He shouts expletives in Spanish and instructs his players to tighten up their defence and fall back in numbers.

Here in the immigrant hub of Queens, where entire worlds coexist within a few steps of the subway, every Sunday, semi-professional and recreational footballers converge to relive their unfulfilled dreams of playing professional football, making new friends and being reassured of their identity. Most of the players are from immigrant communities, largely Latin American, scattered across Queens. They are joined like a moving thread by New York City Subway's famous Train 7 that stops at stations with some of the densest immigration populations, from Flushing Main Street through Jackson Heights and Corona, all the way to St Hudson Yards.

According to US government data, around 45 per cent of the 2.3 million residents of Queens are "foreign born".

"We are a small club called La Bogota, and almost all of us are Colombian, living in Jackson Heights (in Queens). If there is a Sunday, we are here, wherever we are working," Cordoba says a little later, once the irritation at the missed goal has subsided. "In America, the immigrants have been central to the game's growth, like it is in most countries. Look at Spain, France, England..." he says.

It's a paradox of the World Cup — that while the tournament is being held in the backdrop of anti-immigrant policies across Europe and the US, it is being lit up by the children of those who left their countries for a better living, or just to live

From France's Kylian Mbappé, who is of Cameroon-Algerian descent, to UK's Marc Guehi, who was born in the Ivory Coast, and US forward Folarin Balogun, who was born in New York when his Nigerian parents were on a vacation, immigrant players have been central to this World Cup, deified across the globe regardless of nationality, even among teams that have historically relied on their non-immigrant majority. It's also the paradox of the tournament — that while the World Cup is being held in the backdrop of anti-immigrant policies across Europe and the US, it is being lit up by the children of those who left their countries for a better living, or just to live.

A beautiful game

When politicians are busy drawing up stringent anti-immigration laws, football, as this World Cup has shown, is dismantling the boundaries drawn by men. The walls are crumbling at the outposts of the game.

Only two of France's 26 players are of non-immigrant ancestry — 22 of them have African roots. Some, such as Mbappé, are deeply connected to their countries of origin.

Of England's 26 players, eight have Caribbean forebears, 10 African, and 20 who were eligible to represent at least one other country because of their family heritage or birthplace. Belgium has players who trace their lineage to its former colonies — Congo, Burundi and Mali. The Portugal team has those of Cape Verdean, Angolan, and Guinean lineage.

Those surplus to their requirements — players of African descent born and raised in Europe — in turn, populate most of the African teams. Ten of the 11 Senegalese players in the starting lineup against France in the opening game were born in France.

Spain and Italy were latecomers to the multicultural transformation of European football. European heavyweights such as France, Portugal, England, Germany and Belgium had blended them long ago, so much so that most of their heroes and talismans this century have been of African descent, much to the irritation of the far-right parties that feel the France team is less French, or the England squad is less English.

But Spain — and its teen sensation Lamine Yamal — are more than making up for the country's slow start.

In the immigrant neighbourhood of Spain's Rocafonda, roughly 40 km from Barcelona, nearly every wall wears the graffiti, "En El Barrio de Rocafonda/Mas Lamina Yamals/Ye Menos Desa Hucious (In the Rocafonda neighbourhood, more Lamine Yamals and fewer evictions)".

The residents, largely from former Spanish colonies in North Africa, have long lived under the twin shadows of economic marginalisation and the stigma attached to immigrant communities. Then, along came Yamal, born in Spain to immigrant parents — his mother Sheila had illegally entered Spain from Equatorial Guinea as a teenager and his father Mounir Nasraoui, a painter from Morocco, had immigrated a few decades earlier.

The Barcelona star's rise in the 2024 European Championship offered a new voice and identity for millions of immigrants in Spain. Before Yamal, players with immigrant descent had played sporadically.

In a podcast for DAZN Espana, reputed pundit Alberto Edjogo Owono explained the social context: "The ethnic mix arrived much later in Spain than it did in England

and France. So it took time for them to become visible in mainstream football."

Unlike other Black players who played for Spain after gaining citizenship — Donato, Catanha and Marcos Senna — the new wave, including Yamal and his partner in-wing, Nico Williams, were born in Spain. "That's very important for children of immigrants, the second generation," Owono said.

Some 500 km away in Pamplona, in Spain's Navarra province, children of immigrants from Africa have Nico's face plastered on their bedroom walls. Nico's parents had fled Ghana to escape the abject poverty there.

In his early days, Nico and his brother, Inaki, were subjected to racial slurs from stands, especially during games in Spain's capital, Madrid. But now, Nico is greeted as

fervently as any other player.

Football & the American dream

At Flushing Meadows, coach Cordoba, 55, says he migrated from Colombia as a teenager. "All gangs and fights... My parents

thought it was not the right atmosphere for us to grow, so we moved here. Those days, in the 80s, migrating to the States was not difficult," he says, the musical tilt of Spanish still intact.

Ever since he has been in New York, he remembers playing weekend football in Queens. "It becomes a slice of Latin America," he says. His assistant Andreas says, "We come here to play and share our experiences, problems. Almost a hundred games are played here every weekend."

There are just 20 football grounds, though, at the Flushing Meadows park for these 100 games. A few are of regulation size, some are smaller and shapeless. A game between two Venezuelan clubs is unfolding on an oval-shaped pitch. One pitch has an enormous oak tree in the middle. "All we need is a little

bit of space, and of course, different teams take different shifts," says Cordoba.

Most teams playing here are organised around the countries the players left behind — like Cordoba's team with mostly Colombian immigrants, there are leagues with those from Mexico, Ecuador.

Andreas interjects, "It's not like we only have Colombians in our league. There are a couple of boys from Guatemala, though primarily Colombians tend to play in Colombian clubs and Mexicans in Mexican clubs. And we make a lot of friends from other countries. We have a sort of immigrant bond, because our stories are similar."

The stories he refers to feature gangs, shootouts, poverty and a guardian angel landing them on the promised land, the United States. "The only thing is, not all of us enter the country illegally," says Cordoba, guffawing.

Though their loyalties are unshakably tied to their country of origin, of late, the USA national team (USMNT) has become their second favourite.

Says Manuel Fernandez of Salta FC, a Uruguayan-heavy team that plays at the park, "The US national team has become more relatable; it has mixed cultures and players proud of their identity. Many of them had a tough upbringing." As an aside, he says, chuckling: "They have a Latin American coach too."

Six of the players in the US national team are of Afro-Caribbean heritage, including Tim Weah, son of George Weah, the Liberian regarded as the greatest African player ever. There are those from Nigeria, Ghana, and Jamaica. Three are from Hispanic backgrounds — Christian Roldan (Guatemala), Ricardo Pepi (Mexican-American) and Jesus Ferreira (Colombian-American). As many are from Europe, and three others have dual nationalities. "Now, it's a true reflection of the country we are. No matter how much some people want us out, we are integral to the country. We helped to make it," says Fernandez. "Our communities now have icons to look forward to, and hope to produce players who could play for the country."

Many of the US's immigrant sportsmen were helped by the Deferred Action for Childhood Arrivals (DACA) programme, which allowed undocumented immigrants brought to the US as children to work legally and avoid deportation, giving them greater access to college sports, professional opportunities and the stability needed to pursue athletic careers. About 6,50,000 athletes, including tennis player Adrian Escarate and footballer Miguel Aguilar, have benefited from the programme. But the programme, established in 2012 during the Obama administration, is now facing legal challenges and scrutiny under the Trump administration.

Team Socceros

In a crisp two-minute video on Instagram, Australia's variegated group of players reveal their descent. Awer Mabil, a winger who plays in the Australian men's national team and for the Spanish club CD Castellón, sets the tone: "I was born in Kakuma refugee camp in Kenya. My parents are South Sudanese." The full-back, Aziz Behich, says, "My family migrated from Cyprus." Jason Geria says: "My parents are from Uganda; I was born in Australia."

Professional Footballers Australia came up with the video to "highlight the profound impact of multiculturalism" on the country. "At a time when some seek to divide us and question who belongs, the Socceros [the Australian national football team] stand as a powerful reminder of who we truly are as a nation and as Australians," co-president Jackson Irvine said.

A country, where football was derided as "wogball" and marginalised as part of the identity of working-class immigrants, where episodes of racism still rear their ugly heads, where the Right-wing political party One Nation is gaining traction with its stringent stance against immigration, Australia now is the cultural portmanteau of this World Cup.

Four players were born in refugee camps. The players represent 15 ethnic backgrounds and include a Malaysian with Sri Lankan roots. Eighteen other players have direct immigrant or refugee heritage. To contextualise, only one Black player (Sam Morris) and another of Caribbean descent (Andrew Symonds) have represented Australia in cricket. It was not until 2010 that the first Black player, Sanford Wheeler, got a contract with the Australian Football League.

In Mo Touré and Nestory Irankunda, Australia has its own version of Nico Williams and Yamal. Nestory, who scored Australia's first goal in the World Cup, was born to Burundian parents in a refugee camp in Tanzania. Mo Touré's parents were both children when they fled the war in Liberia in 1989, undertaking an 18-day journey on foot to the Guinean border. They met and married in their twenties. Shortly after Touré was born, the family received an Australian visa on humanitarian grounds.

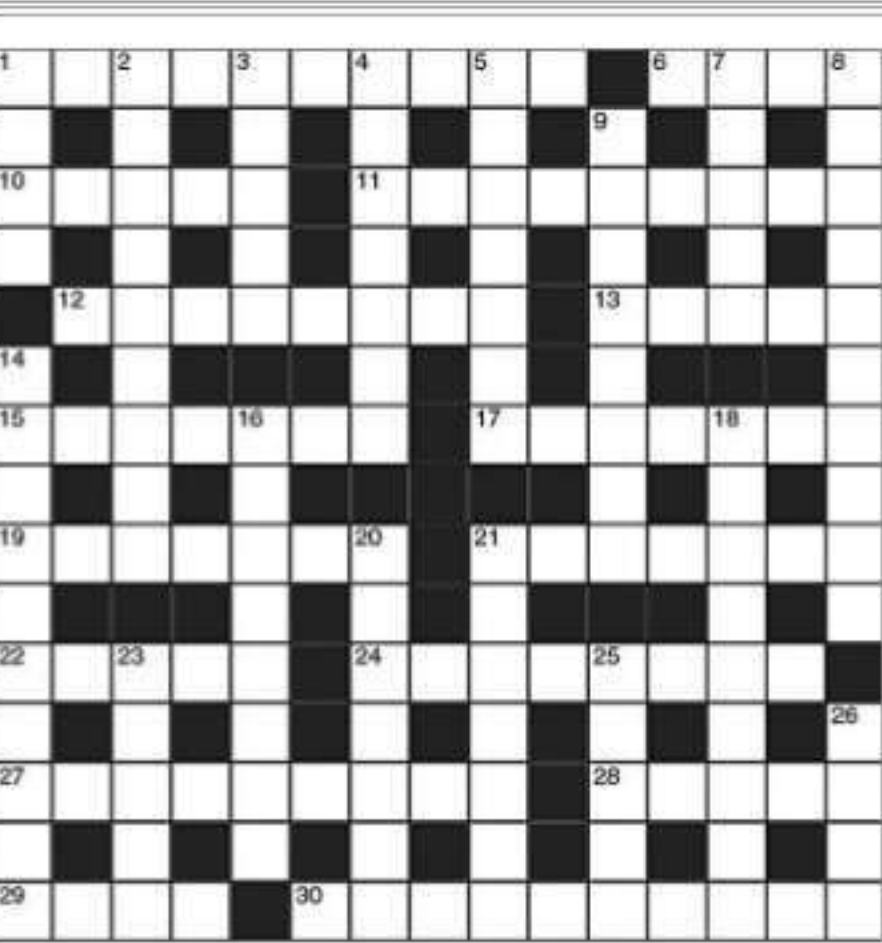
The beats of the immigrant song are reaching far and wide this World Cup, from European nations to the Middle East to the Americas and Australia. It is not some kind of migrant opportunism, but a reflection of what the world has been and is.



At Flushing Meadows Corona Park, Queens, NY. SANDIP G

epaper.indianexpress.com

CROSSWORD



- ACROSS
- 1 Sweepstake taken up by witches? (10)
- 6 Is entertained by current record (4)
- 10 Key officer (5)
- 11 Nice to run into an old soldier (9)
- 12 Caledonian will be put out by this cost (8)
- 13 A sudden thrust in spiteful ungentlemanly manner (5)
- 15 Suggesting it's a new motion to note (7)
- 17 It's meant to be read so make it clear (7)
- 19 Italian dish Rex is to turn to (7)
- 21 City finance (7)
- 22 It is abandoned by caller for face-saving purposes (5)
- 24 Offered to look after an assemblage of deer (8)
- 27 State you've had enough then keep quiet (3,2,4)
- 28 Hearing test (5)
- 29 Exploit that should be witnessed (4)
- 30 Urge a chap to become a PR man (5,5)
- DOWN
- 1 Rustic's family deserts him — what a blow! (4)
- 2 They may be conscientious in their protests (9)
- 3 Be entitled to credit (5)
- 4 In stitches temporarily while changing course (7)
- 5 Any chit of a girl perhaps (7)
- 7 Killer King who met revolutionary end (5)
- 8 She may be recalled in a children's story (10)
- 9 The point of punctuation (4,4)
- 14 Is outwardly better when played by ear (10)
- 16 Not without heart (8)
- 18 Girl collapsed in the race (9)
- 20 Beat gold in the open air (7)
- 21 Reckons wrongly it's a child's game (7)
- 23 Way the French follow an animal home (5)
- 25 He's paid to say nothing (5)
- 26 Dastardly plan devised in bed (4)

SOLUTIONS CROSSWORD 6025 ACROSS: 1 Pellets, 5 Caste, 8 Eloquence, 9 Arc, 10 Dose, 12 Boards, 14 Stairs, 15 Attend, 17 Sidestep, 18 Stem, 21 Ego, 22 Bewitched, 24 Satyr, 25 Yankees DOWN: 1 Plead, 2 Leo, 3 Ernus, 4 Sailor, 5 Concrete, 6 Statement, 7 Excused, 11 Stands out, 13 Crossbar, 14 Sisters, 16 Seaway, 19 Modes, 20 Eton, 23 Hie

JUMBLED WORDS

Given below are four jumbled words. Solve the jumbles to make proper words and move them to the respective circles below. Select the letters in the shaded circles and jumble them to get the answer for the given quip.

Remember that as a _____ you are at the last stage of your life when you will be happy to hear that the phone is for you - Fran Lebowitz (8)

EGRET

LACER

MOSYRT

EOXYGN

ANSWER: Remember that as a teenager you are at the last stage of your life when you will be happy to hear that the phone is for you - Fran Lebowitz

6026

OVER THE HEDGE



CALVIN & HOBBS



MARVIN



DIFFICULTY LEVEL 4s INSTRUCTIONS

To solve a Sudoku puzzle, every digit from 1 to 9 must appear in each of the nine vertical columns, in each of the nine horizontal rows and in each of the nine boxes.

DIFFICULTY LEVEL

1s = Very easy; 2s = Easy; 3s = Medium; 4s = Hard; 5s = Very Hard; 6s = Genius

SUDOKU 6362

4	3							
	6				1			
7	2		8				3	
9	5			4	1			
			5		8			
			9	7			8	3
	8			1		7		2
		6					9	
							4	8

SOLUTION SUDOKU 6361

4	1	8	6	3	2	9	5	7
2	5	9	7	4	1	8	3	6
6	7	3	5	9	8	4	1	2
9	3	7	4	1	5	6	2	8
5	2	4	3	8	6	1	7	9
1	8	6	9	2	7	3	4	5
7	9	5	1	6	3	2	8	4
8	4	1	2	7	9	5	6	3
3	6	2	8	5	4	7	9	1

BY MICHAEL FRY & T LEWIS

ROYAL STARS

BY GEORGIA NICOLS

♈

ARIES (MAR 21 - APR 20): This is a wonderful day for family discussions, home improvements and repairs. Plans related to travel, higher education, medicine or the law look doable. Tonight: Explore.

♉

TAURUS (APR 21 - MAY 21): You're bursting with energy today, which is why you're enthusiastic in all your conversations with others. You're extremely convincing. It's also a great day to tie up loose ends about shared property, taxes and inheritances. Tonight: Check your finances.

♊

GEMINI (MAY 22 - JUNE 21): Serious discussions with partners and close friends will go well today, especially about long-range plans for the future. You feel your finances are picking up. Tonight: Cooperate.

♋

CANCER (JUNE 22 - JULY 23): Today is full of wonderful opportunities for you. Whatever you do will likely expand your world. Get out and talk to others. Get involved in groups. People want your input because they respect you, especially at work. Tonight: Work and get better organised.

♌

LEO (JULY 24 - AUG 23): This is a marvellous, feel-good day. Discussions with kids might be serious, but they will also be productive. Creative projects will go well because you're focused. Romance with someone of an age difference might occur. Tonight: Playful socialising.

♍

VIRGO (AUG 24 - SEP 23): You're popular with others today because everyone wants to see your face. You also might be influential in groups and organisations. This is an excellent time to define future goals. A discussion with a family member might be serious, but it will be practical and productive. Tonight: Relax at home.

♎

LIBRA (SEP 24 - OCT 23): You make a fabulous impression on others. People see you as successful and popular. Use this to your advantage and accept any request for increased responsibilities. Tonight: Easy conversations.

♏

SCORPIO (OCT 24 - NOV 23): Explore opportunities in publishing, medicine, the law or anything to do with higher education, as well as travel. Make some sensible financial decisions. Tonight: Maintain your belongings.

♐

SAGITTARIUS (NOV 24 - DEC 22): Discussions with others will be sensible and productive today. This is a great day to teach children or to tie up loose details with creative projects. Financial assistance from other sources is encouraging. Tonight: You're in charge.

♑

CAPRICORN (DEC 23 - JAN 20): Relations with those who are close to you are warm and friendly today because people feel generous and openhearted. Issues related to a parent or your home and private world can be addressed with efficiency and assurance. Tonight: Enjoy privacy.

♒

AQUARIUS (JAN 21 - FEB 19): Roll up your sleeves and get as much done as possible at work today, because you'll be successful! Work-related travel is likely for many of you. One reason for the success of this day is your mind is clear, focused and detail-oriented. Tonight: Friendships.

♓

PISCES (FEB 20 - MAR 20): Accept invitations to socialise with others today. This is a joyful day for fun outings, sports events, playful activities with kids and romantic get-togethers. Financial discussions with bosses or parents will go well, which is why you feel the bases are covered. Tonight: Be modest.

BY BILL WATTERSON

BY TOM ARMSTRONG

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Amar S/o Chhavi Ram R/o Vagabond Patri, Jamuna Bazar, Kashmere Gate, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 01/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Kashmiri Gate, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Amar cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Amar has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that Amar in FIR No. 01/2020 U/s 379/411 IPC, PS Kashmiri Gate, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 28.07.2026.

By order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
Court No. 138, First Floor
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/7006/N/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person, namely, Amul Mandal, S/o Fullan Mandal H.No. F-6/217, Sultanpuri, Delhi, Also at: Village Bahadurpur, PS: Gogri, Khagaria, Bihar, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 78/20, U/s: 380/457/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Raj Park, New Delhi, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, Amul Mandal, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, Amul Mandal, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said, accused person, Amul Mandal, FIR No. 78/20, U/s: 380/457/411/34 IPC, registered at P.S.: Raj Park, New Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 16.10.2026.

By Order
Ms Aakanksha
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
North West, Court No. 107, First Floor,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8548/OD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) Deepak Tunda, S/o: Ram Chander R/o: C-324. JJ Colony Bawana, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 563/2021, Dt. 05.09.2021, U/s: 392/411/34 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Deepak Tunda, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Deepak Tunda, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Deepak Tunda, of FIR No. 563/2021, Dt. 05.09.2021, U/s: 392/411/34 IPC, PS: Narela Industrial Area, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 31.07.2026.

By Order
Sahil Gupta
Judicial Magistrate First Class-07
North Court
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8599/ON/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) (1) Charan Singh @ Sonu S/o Dalbir Singh, (2) Rashmi Sharma, R/o H. No. WZ-117/9, 1st Floor, Kishan Garg, Vasant Kunj, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 412/2016, U/s 406 IPC, PS Karol Bagh, Delhi and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) (1) Charan Singh @ Sonu, (2) Rashmi Sharma can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) (1) Charan Singh @ Sonu, (2) Rashmi Sharma has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) (1) Charan Singh @ Sonu, (2) Rashmi Sharma of case FIR No. 412/2016, U/s 406 IPC, PS Karol Bagh, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated 28.07.2026.

By Order
Nishat Bangarh
Justice Magistrate First Class-01
Central, Room No. 180
Tis Hazari Courts, Delhi

DP/8591/CD/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Sunil, S/o Mahle, R/o H.No. 1410, Panna Paposiya, Narela, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 576/2022, U/s 33/58 Delhi Ex Act, P.S. Narela, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Sunil cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Sunil has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Sunil accused of FIR No. 576/2022, U/s 33/58 Delhi Ex Act, P.S. Narela, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 04.08.2026.

By Order - Sh. Rishabh Kapoor
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01, North
DP/8530/ON/2026 Room No. 116, Rohini Courts, Delhi

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person Azim S/o: Firoz, R/o: H.No. 7816, Nai Basti Bara Hindu Rao, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No. 487/2023, U/S: 392/394/411 IPC, PS: Kashmere Gate, Delhi, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Azim, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Azim, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person Azim, of FIR No. 487/2023, U/S: 392/394/411 IPC, PS: Kashmere Gate, Delhi, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 03.08.2026.

By Order
Sh. Vaibhav Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-11
Central, Court No. 138 Central District
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8254/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Nand Ram @ Nanda @ Nandu, S/o Lt. Sh. Shyokaran, R/o 1) Jhuggi No. 63, Sita Ram Nagar, Kachhi Basti Triveni, Mahesh Nagar Jaipur, Rajasthan, 2) Santram Ka Makan, Gali No. 2, Infront of Barat Ghar, Village Rajokari, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case FIR No. 85/2016, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Barakhamba Road, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said Nand Ram @ Nanda @ Nandu cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said Nand Ram @ Nanda @ Nandu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Nand Ram @ Nanda @ Nandu accused of FIR No. 85/2016, U/s 33 Delhi Excise Act, P.S. Barakhamba Road, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 31.07.2026.

By Order - Ms. Vijashree Rathore
Judicial Magistrate First Class-05
Room No. 13, 1st Floor, Main Building
Patiala House Courts, New Delhi

DP/8635/NDD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Person(s) Bille Raja Dayal, S/o: Shiv Dayal, R/o: H.No. 18, Block A-1, Patel Marg, Sant Nagar, Jagatpur, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in CC No. 7583/24, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Kotwali, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) Bille Raja Dayal, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) Bille Raja Dayal, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) Bille Raja Dayal, of CC No. 7583/24, U/s: 138 NI Act, PS: Kotwali, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 01.08.2026.

By Order
Sh. Arjun Kirar
Judicial Magistrate First Class (NI Act)-05 (Central)
Room No. 02 Ground Floor (Central District)
Building Annexe-01
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8614/N/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused Jishan, S/o: Rauf, R/o: F-487, Gali No. 14, Khadda Colony, Jaipur Ext. Part-2, New Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case E-FIR No. 12083/24 U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S.: Kalindi Kunj, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Jishan cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Jishan has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Jishan accused of offence in case E-FIR No. 12083/24 U/s 379/411 IPC, P.S.: Kalindi Kunj, Delhi and is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 10.08.2026.

By Order
Sh. Azad Sehrawat
Judicial Magistrate First Class-10
South East District, 3rd Floor
Room No. 307, Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/8239/SE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr. P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused Ashok Singh @Kalu S/o Late Sh. Swaran Singh R/o J-547, J Block, near Chaudhary Medical, Shakurpur, Delhi-110034 has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case Registration No. 4549/22 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Rani Bagh, Delhi and it has been returned to warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused Ashok Singh @Kalu cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Ashok Singh @Kalu has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that Ashok Singh @Kalu in Case Registration No. 4549/22 U/s 138 NI ACT, PS Rani Bagh, Delhi is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 31.07.2026.

By order
Shri Sanyam Jain
Judicial Magistrate First Class-04 (North -West)
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/6524/OD/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C.)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, Gajender@Bahadur, S/o Virender Singh R/o H. No. D-138/11, Gali No.11, D Block, Gamri Extension, Garhi, Mendu, New Delhi, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in FIR No: 473/20, U/s: 20/NDPS, registered at P.S.: Shastri Park, Delhi, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, Gajender@Bahadur, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, Gajender@ Bahadur, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person, Gajender@ Bahadur, FIR No: 473/20, U/s: 20/ NDPS, registered at P.S.: Shastri Park, Delhi, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before 01.08.2026.

By Order
Sh Puneet Pahwa
Special Judge (NDPS)/Additional Session Judge
District North East, Room No. 63
Karkardooma Courts Delhi

DP/8578/NE/2026
(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

(See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely Rajesh S/o Om Parkash R/o 57/03, Gali No - 2, Shiv Vihar, Shahbad Dairy, Delhi has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case e-FIR No. 00576/2023, U/s 380/457/411/34 IPC PS: Vijay Vihar, Delhi and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused Rajesh cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused Rajesh has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said Rajesh accused of e-FIR No. 00576/2023, U/s 380/457/411/34 IPC PS: Vijay Vihar, Delhi is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before 11.08.2026.

By Order
Ms. Shagun
JMFC, Room No. 109, First Floor
Rohini, Court, Delhi

DP/8538/RD/2026
(Court Matter)



The night *La Tri* upset four-time champions

Ecuadorian players and staff huddle up after defeating Germany and confirming their spot in the knockout stages. AP

• RESULTS

GROUP E

Curacao 0-2 Ivory Coast
Philadelphia Stadium

Ecuador 2-1 Germany
New Jersey Stadium

GROUP F

Japan 1-1 Sweden
Dallas Stadium

Tunisia 1-3 Netherlands
Kansas City Stadium

GROUP D

Paraguay 0-0 Australia
San Francisco Stadium

Turkey 3-2 USA
Los Angeles Stadium

• MATCH SCHEDULE

GROUP L

Croatia vs Ghana
Philadelphia, 2.30 am

(Sunday)

Panama vs England
New Jersey, 2.30 am

(Sunday)

GROUP K

Colombia vs Portugal
Miami, 5.00 am

(Sunday)

DR Congo vs Uzbekistan
Atlanta, 5.00 am

(Sunday)

GROUP J

Algeria vs Austria
Kansas City, 7.30 am

(Sunday)

Jordan vs Argentina
Dallas, 7.30 am

(Sunday)

ZEE5 OTT & UNITE8 CHANNELS



Nicolas Pepe scored both goals in Ivory Coast's 2-0 win. AP

Ivory Coast go through and send Curacao home

NICOLAS PEPE'S double sealed Ivory Coast's first trip to the World Cup knockout phase with a 2-0 victory over Curacao on Thursday to finish second in Group E. Curacao became the eighth team eliminated from the tournament, a fate that arrived later than many anticipated. REUTERS

2026 edition breaks record for most goals

THE 2026 World Cup became the highest-scoring edition in the tournament's history during the United States' Group D match against Turkey on Thursday, with Auston Trusty's early opener producing the record-breaking 173rd goal and eclipsing the previous mark of 172 set at Qatar 2022. The record was broken in the 59th match of the 2026 World Cup. REUTERS

Ecuador complete miracle comeback

Sriram Veera
Mumbai, June 26

ROOSEVELT AVENUE in Jackson Heights, Queens, has been flying the tricolor since the squad announcement. The bakeries, the bars, the faces painted yellow. They had crossed oceans to watch this team. On Thursday, for the first time, the ocean came to them.

Nilson Angulo is 23. He was born in Quinindé, in Esmeraldas province, a coastal town of oil palm and red earth. He grew up running on the Malecón del Río, the riverbank track where the ball bounced unpredictably off the dirt and you learned to adjust or you went home. José Cabezas, one of his early coaches, told the Ecuadorian newspaper *Expreso* that he remembered Angulo arriving at six: *flaquito, inquieto, con esa necesidad de patearlo todo*. Skinny, restless, with the need to kick everything.

When he was eight years old, a truck hit him. Broken jaw, broken leg, hospital, cast. His mother, Dora Ramírez, told *Expreso* that even then he would

climb out of the bed to kick a ball. He could not stay still.

As a teenager, when the career first took him to Belgium, he would call home and tell Dora he wanted to come back. She still remembers the *madrugaderas*, the early-morning calls, his voice from Anderlecht. "*Lloraba y me decía que se quería venir*." He cried and told me he wanted to come home.

Dora's visa for this World Cup was denied the first time she applied. She did not give up. On Thursday she had made it to the United States. Back in Quinindé, neighbours sat on motorbikes outside their houses and waited.

Ecuador entered the match with zero goals in two games. In 1930 and 1950, Bolivia finished their entire World Cup campaigns without scoring. Ecuador had been edging toward that company. Germany, already through, four-time world champions, eleven consecutive wins. Win, and Ecuador might survive. Anything else, and they were done. The second minute had not been kind. Leroy Sané side-footed past Galíndez. The

Ecuadorian end of the stadium absorbed it. They had learned, in two weeks, how to absorb things.

In the ninth minute, Pedro Vite stole the ball in the German half and played it wide. Angulo received it with space. Twenty-six yards out, he pulled the trigger: a right-footed strike threaded between the legs of Pavlović, who was closing in. Neuer, playing his fifth World Cup at 40, got nothing on it.

In Quinindé, on the Malecón and in the side streets, nobody moved for a second.

Germany thought they had a penalty early in the second half. VAR overturned it: Sané had fouled Vite in the build-up. The same people who had gone quiet made a sound. MetLife has probably not heard before. From that point Ecuador pressed. Valencia had a fierce effort beaten away. Caicedo found Plata at the far post. The effort dropped wide. The clock ran. "The difference was today that the opponent wanted to win more than us," said Joshua Kimmich. "You could really feel it, especially in the second half. This is why they

won today, really deserved."

The 77th minute. A corner, a headed flick-on, Gonzalo Plata at the near post. Neuer was slow. Plata poked it in. Drinks flew into the air. Beccacece found his wife and daughters on the edge of the technical area and held them. "Life is different now," Plata said. "We suffered a lot. We suffered too much in the first two matches."

Seven minutes of stoppage time. Germany had chances. It didn't matter. After it all, Angulo stood with a microphone and thought about home. "*En Ecuador no me imagino. Mínimo han de estar bailando salsa*," *Expreso* reporter Luis Cheme visited Dora Ramírez's house in the barrio Central before the tournament. When you cross the threshold, the first thing you hear is Los Van Van playing. The walls hold Angulo's medals from Cabecitas FC, school diplomas, framed goals, jerseys from Liga de Quito and Belgium. And one she keeps with particular care: the shirt he wore against Brazil.

On Thursday, she was not in Quinindé.

Why are Americans singing 'Country Roads' at stadiums?

Sandip G
Boston, June 26

AT THE Harvard Square in Boston, a bistro is playing John Denver's ageless classic Country Roads on a loop from a pair of rickety loudspeakers. A few youngsters chime in and begin an impromptu sing-along, "Take me home, country roads..." The man behind the cash table quips: "Poor, John didn't think it would become a World Cup song."

Denver composed the first lines of the song in 1971, while travelling through Maryland with his friends for a concert in West Virginia, met with an accident, broke his thumb, completed the day he got discharged and performed it live the next day. He died in 1997, when the experimental aircraft he was flying crashed into Monterey Bay in California.

His country folk-songs, even though he dabbled in numerous genres, that spoke of nature and simple country life would live on for decades as cultural symbols. But he would not have imagined that the song about longing and nature would become the USMNT's post-match sing-along at the World Cup and strike a chord among the fans and players, blasted in arenas and public spaces from Seattle to Miami, California to Alaska.

The moment the match ends, Denver's wistful, quivering voice, accompanied by an acoustic guitar, takes over. The players hum it, the crowd takes on, and even the Argentine coach Mauricio Pochettino tries to whistle the song.

It has struck a chord with the players. Defender Auston Trusty would say, before the final group game: "I think 'Country Roads' is a very American song, and to hear it in that stadium, with everyone singing along, it's a dream come true. It's feelings that you can't really describe," defender Auston Trusty would say.

Even those raised outside the country like Folarin Balogun said he could relate with the song. "My mother knows all the lines. I have heard it a thou-



American fans have adopted John Denver's 1971 hit as their anthem. AP

sand times. It is a soft but inspiring song," he said. "Part of being American is knowing 'Country Roads'," defender Chris Richards said. The song, reportedly, was heard from coach Pochettino's office as well.

Official song

The story behind how the song became the anthem is fascinating too. It was not among the songs the team members recommended when FIFA sought them about the songs they wanted to play during breaks. Their recommendations were "WIN" by Jay Rock, "The Show Goes On" by Lupe Fiasco, "Livin' on a Prayer" by Bon Jovi and "Free Bird" by Lynyrd Skynyrd.

America should be spoiled for choice because of its vast spread of music and music-movements, from jazz and blues to hip-hop and R&B, not to forget the various rock and metal bands it had birthed.

But FIFA's World Cup chief strategy officer, Amy Hopfinger, who had worked with the USA counterpart for nearly two decades, felt something was amiss. Most of the songs, she felt, couldn't produce the mass appeal. "I heard Win after the Paraguay game and felt it didn't have that shared moment," she told *New York Post*.

She probed for more suggestions from her ex-colleagues. The association finally homed in on Neil Diamond's

The moment the match ends, Denver's wistful, quivering voice, accompanied by an acoustic guitar, takes over

Sweet Caroline, only to realise that England and the Netherlands had also submitted the song among their in-stadia playlist. "I decided to act on myself, I overruled Sweet Caroline and replaced it with Country Roads," she said.

Eventually, Country Roads and Livin' on a Prayer made it. But the Bon Jovi chartbuster, though more energetic, couldn't establish a distinct connection that could rally the masses. Even the Australian fans jived to it when it was played during the break in Seattle's Lumen Stadium.

The choice song surprised some of the fans, because its considered a sombre song, not that would rush the adrenaline on a sports field. "I thought it was a bit odd when I heard it for the first time," says Kenneth Jones, part of the fan group American Outlaws.

"But when the crowd began to sing along like a chorus in Seattle, I thought it was splendid and it elevated the atmosphere. And of course, it's a song with profound meaning," he adds.

CO-HOSTS TAKE FOOT OFF PEDAL

No Hollywood ending as Turkey expose US's depth

USMNT top their group but lack of defensive back-up will worry Poch



Sandip G
Boston, June 26

THE TWIST of the knife was saved for the last minute of the game. The contest locked at 2-2, a befitting result for a frantic and error-replete game, Kaan Ayhan stabbed the ball into the net.

A collective pause shook the stadium. For the first time in the ongoing World Cup, co-hosts United States lost a game. Suddenly, the sold-out crowd, among them several Hollywood celebrities, stopped reacting. The team lingered and applauded the crowd, consoled them not to worry. After all, this was an inconsequential game, fraught with risks rather than rewards. Manager Mauricio Pochettino is a wise man. He imperilled defeat for yellow cards that could have seen some of his regulars miss the Round-of-32 game, or a senior player getting injured or fatigued.

The Argentine was willing to gamble the momentum, and the glowy bounce winning streaks can inject. The margins were minuscule — had they not conceded the last-minute goal, or one of Christian Pulisic's strikes not hit the woodwork, his tactics would have been glorified as masterstrokes.

But whether it would be a defeat for the better or not, only



USA were the only side to concede to Turkey at this World Cup. AP

time would tell. For last-minute goals could leave psychological scars. It's not so much about the skills and tactics as it is about the mentality. Will USMNT recover from the shock? Weston McKennie, their captain for the night, is certain his team's momentum would not be disrupted.

"Everybody wants to go to a game winning the previous game. Obviously we didn't do that tonight, but I think that's going to motivate us even more." But the game slashed forth the co-hosts' vulnerabilities. The pandemonium of the makeshift defence could vex the manager. All of the back four plus the goalkeeper were second- or third-choice alternatives. But the product he beheld, even if that be his back-up squad, terrified him. The defence structure went off-kilter, predominantly originating from ponderous transition. They occupied a higher defensive line than usual, shedding the mid-block they had embraced so far in the tournament to limit the opponent's final-third touches.

He eschewed the double-pivot play that had worked fruitfully, simply because he didn't have alternatives on the bench. The result was a structural catastrophe with the hosts asserting little control on the game.

Porous at the back

Bolstered by the second-minute goal, they committed too many upfield, hovered far too aggressively for a second goal, and left far little cover at the back. Maybe, it was the overenthusiasm of those who had been benched till now.

Turkish goals were simple. Get the ball into the box, find space and shoot. The communication between Miles Robinson and Mark McKenzie was akin to two strangers walking in opposite directions on the New York subway, their vibes cold and frosty.

Each thought the other would perform the tidying up when Iper Yilmaz waltzed through them and found Arda Güler to equalise. Joe Scally and Robinson combined in the second faux pas that saw Orkun Kökçü nail home Turkey's second goal. Güler took out four defenders with a simple slide-rule pass. Scally left Elmalı utterly unmarked and his cut back sliced past a petrified Robinson.

When they attacked, the US were thrilling, hounding the Turkish defence, carrying

The communication between Miles Robinson and Mark McKenzie was akin to two strangers walking in opposite directions on the New York subway, their vibes cold and frosty

the ball with a maddening zeal and untrammelled energy. Only that they were caught napping when defending, did the Turks make quick and seamless transitions. There was space vaster than the Gulf of Izmir to attack. The backlash of pressing high, an ideal Pochettino dropped for want of conduits, was severe. It showed the lack of defensive depth at Pochettino's disposal. And his only prayer was that his first choice backline could play all the minutes in all the games (or game).

But there were moments that he would cherish. Sebastian Berhalter propelled a rocket through the narrowest space. Weirdly, it traversed a near-straight line and ripped into the net.

The biggest, and perhaps the only meaningful, takeaway from the match was the supreme mobility of Christian Pulisic, returning from an injury that had ruled him out of the Australia game.

The jewel in USMNT's crown, its undisputed talisman, he struck the crossbar and kissed the post with a curling brute. His movements betrayed little discomfort or weariness, but an alacrity to plot the winner. It didn't arrive, and they lost in the final second of the game.

The night ended in heartbreak. But the question is whether it's the last or the first of many.

Brazil vs Japan, Dutch vs Morocco: Round of 32 throws up early jeopardy

ONE IS a tactical duel between two of the smartest teams on either side of the Mediterranean. The other is a meeting between Asia's most sophisticated football project and the sport's greatest superpower. And almost hidden behind those heavy-weight ties is another intriguing subplot: co-hosts USA and Canada have landed the draw they wished for.

The World Cup has reached the point where every mistake will be terminal. After the group-stage, for some, the arithmetic is over. The safety nets have disappeared. Brazil and the Netherlands will feel the noose more. Brazil have exited early only in the inaugural 1930 edition and 1966, while the Netherlands haven't missed Round of 16 ever.

But for four teams, the Round of 32 has delivered exactly the sort of story FIFA would have hoped for.

Netherlands vs Morocco: Familiar strangers

It is one of those fixtures that almost feels domestic. The Dutch know Morocco intimately. So do the Moroccans. Several Moroccan internationals grew up in the Netherlands, came through Dutch academies or have spent years in the top flight Eredivisie. Ronald Koeman scarcely needed a scouting report after his side secured top spot in Group F. He admitted as much, describing Morocco as "a very good team" whose players are already well known.

That familiarity makes this fascinating. The Netherlands have perhaps been the tournament's most fluent attacking side outside the traditional favourites. They have scored freely, pressed aggressively and looked comfortable with every outing. Yet there remains one concern:

they have conceded in every group match. Koeman himself acknowledged that his side still needs greater compactness.

Morocco are perfectly built to exploit those moments. Unlike the fairy-tale side that thrilled the world four years ago by defending deep, this Moroccan generation has become increasingly comfortable dictating possession while still carrying frightening pace in transition. Their draw against Brazil proved they can live with elite opponents.

It is also a match loaded with emotion. Thousands of Moroccan fans living across Europe have traditionally turned Dutch venues into seas of red and green. Monterey may witness something similar.

For all the glamour elsewhere in the bracket, this could quietly become the knockout round's highest-quality tactical contest.

Japan vs Brazil: The ultimate examination

Japan probably could not have asked for a tougher reward. They topped nobody's list of favourites before the tournament but have once again demonstrated why they are Asia's benchmark. Their football has been crisp, technically secure and collective. Every player seems to understand exactly where to be.

Now come Brazil. There is something wonderfully symbolic about the pairing. Japan's entire football revolution has borrowed heavily from Brazil. The J.League invited Brazilian players and coaches during its formative years. Technical football became an obsession. Generations of Japanese players grew up idolising Brazilian stars.

Now the student meets the master. Brazil have not been spec-



Matheus Cunha (R) celebrates after scoring against Scotland. AP

tacular in every game, but they have been relentlessly efficient. They topped Group C ahead of Morocco, remaining unbeaten, and possess match-winners across the pitch.

Yet, Japan are exactly the sort of opponent Brazil would rather avoid.

They press intelligently, recover possession quickly and perhaps move the ball faster than anyone in Asia. Their challenge will be turning long spells of neat possession into chances before Brazil's individual brilliance decides the contest.

The draw the hosts wanted

The bracket has smiled on the hosts. The United States, despite ending the group stage with a defeat, still finished atop Group D and will meet Bosnia and Herzegovina rather than one of Europe's heavyweights. It is a fixture they will believe they can win, particularly playing at home.

Canada will head into their game with a feeling that they could progress further. They will face South Africa, who have gone from being ridiculed to finding redemption in a space of a week. It's an open match, with both fancying their chances. ENS

Triple jumper
Praveen seals
Asiad berth



Praveen Chithravel. AP

Pritish Raj
Bhubaneswar, June 26

NATIONAL TRIPLE jump record holder Praveen Chithravel soared 16.92m to win the title at the inter-state athletics championships and book his berth for the upcoming Asian Games at the Kalinga Stadium on Friday. Praveen was pushed all the way by veteran Kartik Unnikrishnan, who finished second with 16.80m while NCAA champion Selva Prabhu managed 16.79m to win the bronze medal. In all, six jumpers cleared the qualification mark of 16.28m and made it to the continental mega event to be held in Aichi-Nagoya, Japan from September 19-October 4. At the 2025 World Championships in Tokyo, Praveen failed to progress beyond the qualification round with a best jump of 16.74m. He has been trying to make up for that disappointment ever since. "I have lost a lot in the last two years. I was crying in Japan after failing to qualify for the World Championships final," Praveen said after winning the gold medal. Praveen has his eyes set on both the Asiad and Commonwealth Games podiums. "The aim for the season was to qualify for these two events and then peak there," he said.

Eye on national record

Praveen trains under former world championship silver medallist Yoandri Betanzos at the Inspire Institute of Sport facility in Bellary. The Cuban coach has his eyes set on the national record as the season progresses. The mark of 17.37m is owned by Praveen himself. "We want to break the national record. That was our target here but the track was bouncy due to rain. But the qualification is achieved, so I am happy with the result," Betanzos told *The Indian Express*.

Tejas going to Asiad

National record holder in 110m hurdles, Tejas Shirse clocked 13.61s to book his Asian Games berth. Despite multiple false starts in the final, Tejas managed to breach the qualification mark of 13.63s. In women's discus throw, Seema, Sanya Yadav and Nidhi breached the qualification mark of 55.48m. Seema won the gold medal with an effort of 59.73m.

India's T20I era under Shreyas begins with a jolt from the Irish

Ireland overcame absence of several first-choice players to upset T20 world champions by 34 runs in Belfast

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, June 26

INDIA'S NEW T20I era under Shreyas Iyer started off with a shock defeat as a second-string Ireland bowling attack, missing key players, ended up bowling out the world champions. The 34-run defeat at Stormont in Belfast on Friday means that, for the first time in three years, India won't win a T20 bilateral series. It was Ireland's first-ever win over India in any format. On an afternoon where Irish fans were outnumbered clearly by Indian fans, who had arrived expecting 15-year-old Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to make his debut, it was the Irish debutant duo of Matt Holland and Jai Moonda who left their imprint. On an afternoon where Irish fans were outnumbered by Indian fans, who had arrived expecting Vaibhav Sooryavanshi to make his debut, it was the debutant duo of Matt Holland and Jai Moonda who left their imprint. Set 183 for win, India's chase never got going. Apart from Abhishek Sharma, who scored 50 off 20 deliveries, the rest of the batting unit failed to turn up. To start with, India had little business chasing the score. They had reduced the hosts to 51/4 in 71 overs before conceding 114 runs in the last 10 overs.



Shreyas Iyer scored three runs from seven balls in his first game as India's T20I skipper against Ireland on Friday. CREIMAS/BCCI

But given India's batting might, this should have been a total they should have overhauled with ease if one factors in that this was an Ireland team that was missing several of their first-choice players. Josh Little, Mark Adair, Curtis Campher, and Barry McCarthy are all missing the two T20s with injuries and at a time when all their focus is on the 50-over World Cup qualifiers, these two matches against India have come when they were least prepared. The second-string bowling attack, though, proved too hot to handle. At the toss, captain Shreyas revealed Sooryavanshi has to wait for his turn as they weren't going to disturb the top three who delivered them the second successive T20 World Cups. A fair call, but such is the hype around Sooryavanshi that it

looked controversial when, on any other day, dropping one of Abhishek, Sanju Samson and Ishan Kishan would have invited criticism. The slide started in the second over when Samson inside-edged debutant Moondra on to the stumps off his first delivery. Born in Rajasthan's Tonk, the hometown of Indian seamer Khaleel Ahmed, he moved to Ireland only in 2021 to pursue a master's degree in electronics and communication. Having caught the attention because of his pace in Dublin club cricket, he received a call-up for this series and, apart from Samson, pulled off a sensational caught and bowled catch to dismiss Shivam Dube when the left-hander was threatening with his massive blows. In between Moondra's strikes, it was fellow debutant Holland who hogged the limelight. The seamer struck off his second delivery, courtesy of a leading edge from Ishan. The wickets of Shreyas and Washington dealt India further blows, even as Abhishek fought a lone losing battle. Playing his first T20I since 2023, the pacer's economy was once again on the higher side. He started the day with a 15-run over and ended it with a 27-run over as his predictable lines and lengths were feasted on by the Irish batsmen. With Axar and Washington too failing to provide control, Ireland, from a spot of bother, ended up having a total that proved to be a slippery slope for India. **BRIEF SCORES: Ireland 182/9 in 20 overs (Lorcan Tucker 50; Harshit Rana 3/24) beat India 148 all out in 18.5 overs (Abhishek Sharma 50; Matthew Holland 3/28) by 34 runs.**

68/4 to 182/9

Ronaldo-inspired Rounak takes down World No 6

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, June 26

RONAK CHOUHAN started playing badminton at 8, watching his sister and inspired by his mother who played the sport in college. But there was one other thing common in her advice to what he followed in his favourite footballer – Cristiano Ronaldo. "She always says give 100% even on a bad day. With Ronaldo it's his hardwork that's inspiring. I used to watch him and jump every time from the back court. It became muscle memory," Chouhan would tell *The Indian Express* after the last Junior World's. On Thursday, Chouhan twice put his formidable attacking game to lethal use to swamp World No 6 Chou Tien Chen with 6 straight points, and won 21-17, 26-24 at the US Open Super 300 in Fullerton, California. Chouhan was on the offensive from the outset against the top seed Taiwanese. But the young Indian from Raipur, Chhattisgarh, showed remarkable guts to take the fight to the 35-year-old known for his impeccable shuttle control. Chouhan literally fought for every point after Tien Chen went 17-15 up in the opener. It was an attack unlike any seen from an Indian MS player at 18, and a sign of things to come.

'Focus on strokes'

Having taken the first set with a flurry of 6 points, Chouhan found himself staring at a 11-17 deficit. He again amped it up to level at 17 with 6 points, and then showed stunning fight to beat back 4 set points, and converting his second match point against an opponent built on never-say-die DNA. The world juniors had been a tough and toughening experience for Chouhan, who



Rounak Chouhan defeated World No 6 Chou Tien Chen 21-17, 26-24. BAI

trains at NCE, Guwahati. Even as India picked a team bronze, it had hit Chouhan that in international badminton, he needed to shut out noise, focus on breathing and calm himself down. "Focus on strokes, breathe properly," he would say. When he followed his sister

to the Police Grounds courts at Raipur, it was former coach, now BAI secretary Sanjay Mishra who would guide him. Moving to ITM University's 8 courts at Uparwara broadened his horizons, and helped him choose badminton over cricket which he played too. It helped that his mother had been an athlete. His father is a businessman. "Ronaldo's work ethic" Lin Dan was his badminton idol, but Cristiano Ronaldo truly proved a totem, as Chouhan dug the Portuguese legend's work ethic. The way he jumped in the box connecting to headers, how he celebrated imprinted on Chouhan's brain. Execution was a different matter. "From when young I learnt to jump from the back court. But the muscle memory needed explosive sessions," he said. He would start working

with S&C trainers at Reliance Foundation just to biomechanically sort out his jump and balance and stability after landing. His back court game is impressive for his age, though work is ongoing on back court variations. "The half smash, drop I need to use more. I need to learn the art of being aggressive and calm at the same time," he said, looking for badminton's golden balance. "I get too aggressive at times." His win over Chou Tien Chen addressed a complex goal he had set himself: "After a long high paced rally, the breathing rate is high. How to handle next 10-15 seconds, that's the goal." For that, he idolized Lakshya Sen. "He's calm when playing aggressive." He would also want consistency at the net. How does he rate his own defense? "8 on 10," says the World No 80. Chouhan next plays Israeli Misha Zilberman.

{ F I F A W O R L D C U P }

Croatia have champion gene, we fight: Stimac

Shivani Naik
Mumbai, June 26

FOOTBALL TEAMS from war-ravaged nations cherish a united fan base back home. It's the closest thing to normalcy. Igor Stimac, whose Croatia finished third at the 1998 FIFA World Cup, says a national football team winning heals political friction and fragments, better than anything he's known. "It's one simple, beautiful idea to stand by. When your country qualifies for a World Cup, nothing else is so important anymore. Everything else stops bothering. No political issues, no problems, no illness," Stimac, the former India coach, recalls the dizzy days when Croatia were finally allowed to qualify, and went all the way to bronze on debut. "I only have the medal from then as a keepsake. All money went to health services and surgeries of soldiers and civilians hurt by war," he recalls, on the sidelines of his TV punditry gig with Zee5. Football offered a legit distraction from the reality of war, even for the team based abroad. But nightmares of losing loved ones pierced that escape. From 1991-97, Serbia and Croatia clashed on a terrifying frontline.



Igor Stimac was part of the Croatia 1998 FIFA World Cup squad which finished third after losing to eventual champions France. AP

Stimac calls it "Serbian aggression." "Our team carried great responsibility because friends, people, courage, were losing lives, surviving aggression." What it did was unite a country dazed by destruction. "For football, everyone united. No left wing. No right wing. It was not easy. But it gave kids like Luca Modric idols like Davor Suker, Boban, Jarni to follow, and two more medals, 3 medals in 6 World Cups, not bad, eh?" he says. Present-day Croatia play Ghana in a battle of survival in a tricky group match on Saturday, and things could get dicey. Stimac, who spoke before the first match, however, maintains - a touch as hyperbole - that all Croats from eternity carry a "champion gene."

Great warriors

"We fight as if our life depends on it. Throughout history, there have been enemies wanting to perish us, Croats (sic)," he explains. "We have had warriors and been the first line of defense versus conquest and terror of central Europe. We defended our land with our lives and have 5 wins over (Ottoman) Turks, more than anyone. We fight.

That's our champion gene." For a country coming out of the Balkan tragedies of the 90s, football wasn't even on level ground. Croatia was the World U20 champions coming out of communist rule, but official recognition to participate as Croatia was an endless wait from FIFA and UEFA bureaucracy. "It was disgusting, and us professional players were not allowed official entry, only friendlies. When the chance came at the Euros, the team reached the quarters. The referee was responsible for Croatia not going through when we lost to Germany. We were sad, angry, but not bitter. We accepted the wrong decision because we got a chance to play at least," he recalls. At the World Cup in 98, they made it count. After Jamaica, Japan, Romania, the Croats defeated Germany, the old football enemy. "People came out on Croatia streets and sang songs on us. We had beaten them. The same Germany that had beaten us with the help of a referee," he narrates with a boom, like he's Gimli, son of Gloom. "Although in our culture, we don't believe in 'revenge'. When we lose at football, it's because the opponent is better than us. But because of

what happened at Euros, there was great satisfaction that the injustice was ended with the biggest defeat of the enemy (3-0). Trust and loyalty Throughout the whole campaign, Stimac recalls the team felt at home in France. "We had the best manager (Miroslav Blazevic) and the golden generation playing in the top clubs of Europe. We were relaxed, understood each other," he says. Loyalty and camaraderie also included some unsavoury business. But in their 20s, with fresh freedom, Stimac reckoned they needed a release. "Oh, myself and Davor Suker and few others would fly off to Madrid, you know," he says surreptitiously. "We would smoke at half-time!" he recalls. "We knew it was important to do our job on the field. But we smoked, which might be unacceptable to others. But there was trust and loyalty." He regrets it. A little. "In the second game, playing Japan took away a lot of energy. After 5-6 hours, we faced huge problems," he says. "So, write it in bold in your paper - DON'T SMOKE," Stimac says. Football, though, smelled of freedom - a feeling he will eternally remember.

Bud, Dew Drop and Bloom: How USA brought dogs for stress relief

Express News Service
New Delhi, June 26

THE US men's national team has a unique way to relieve stress during the 2026 World Cup. The team that lost 3-2 to Turkey, but still topped their group had special visitors waiting for them upon returning to their training base. According to the *Athletic*, the USMNT has partnered with their first official pet care partner in Purina to introduce three terrier/mixed breed puppies to the squad. They are Bud, Dew Drop and Bloom. The Athletic reports that U.S. coach Mauricio Pochettino approved the initiative, and both U.S. Soccer and Purina noted the session was so successful that they are already discussing a second visit for the knockout rounds. Future visits may feature different puppies. Bud, Dew Drop, and Bloom were introduced to the training center through Wags and Walks, a non-profit organization dedicated to minimizing euthanasia in local shelters and promoting the adoption of rescue dogs. Social media was filled with charming clips of the U.S. squad relaxing with puppies at their Ir-



USA manager Mauricio Pochettino. INSTAGRAM/USOCCER

vine headquarters. Yet integrating dogs into professional sports environments is a concept already familiar to followers of the new Premier League champions, Mikel Arteta, the manager of Arsenal, notably introduced a chocolate labrador named Win to the team in 2023. Arteta shared on the club's official site that Win's presence had helped foster a familial atmosphere. In conversation with the *Athletic*, Dr. Kerri Rodriguez, an assistant professor at the College of Veterinary Medicine at the University of Ari-

zona spoke about her recent study in which she observed that interactions with dogs is, "effective at reducing heart rate and anxiety symptoms." "Interestingly, dogs were more effective at reducing heart rate during stressful situations than being with another person, such as a friend or family member. We think this is because dogs offer non-judgmental support," she added. She says that according to academics, it can be stated "confidently" that "dogs alter our brain and body chemistry." Such interactions may influence levels of cortisol and oxytocin, the latter of which is frequently referred to as the love hormone. Dr. Annie Valuska, a pet behaviorist with Purina, told the *Athletic*, "when people look into the eyes of the dog, the hormone oxytocin is released in us. That's called the cuddle hormone. You may see it with a mom looking at her newborn baby... So when we look into the eyes of a dog, we release that hormone. But it's also released in the dogs, so they get those warm, fuzzy feelings because of their relationship with us and we know they form very deep bonds with us."